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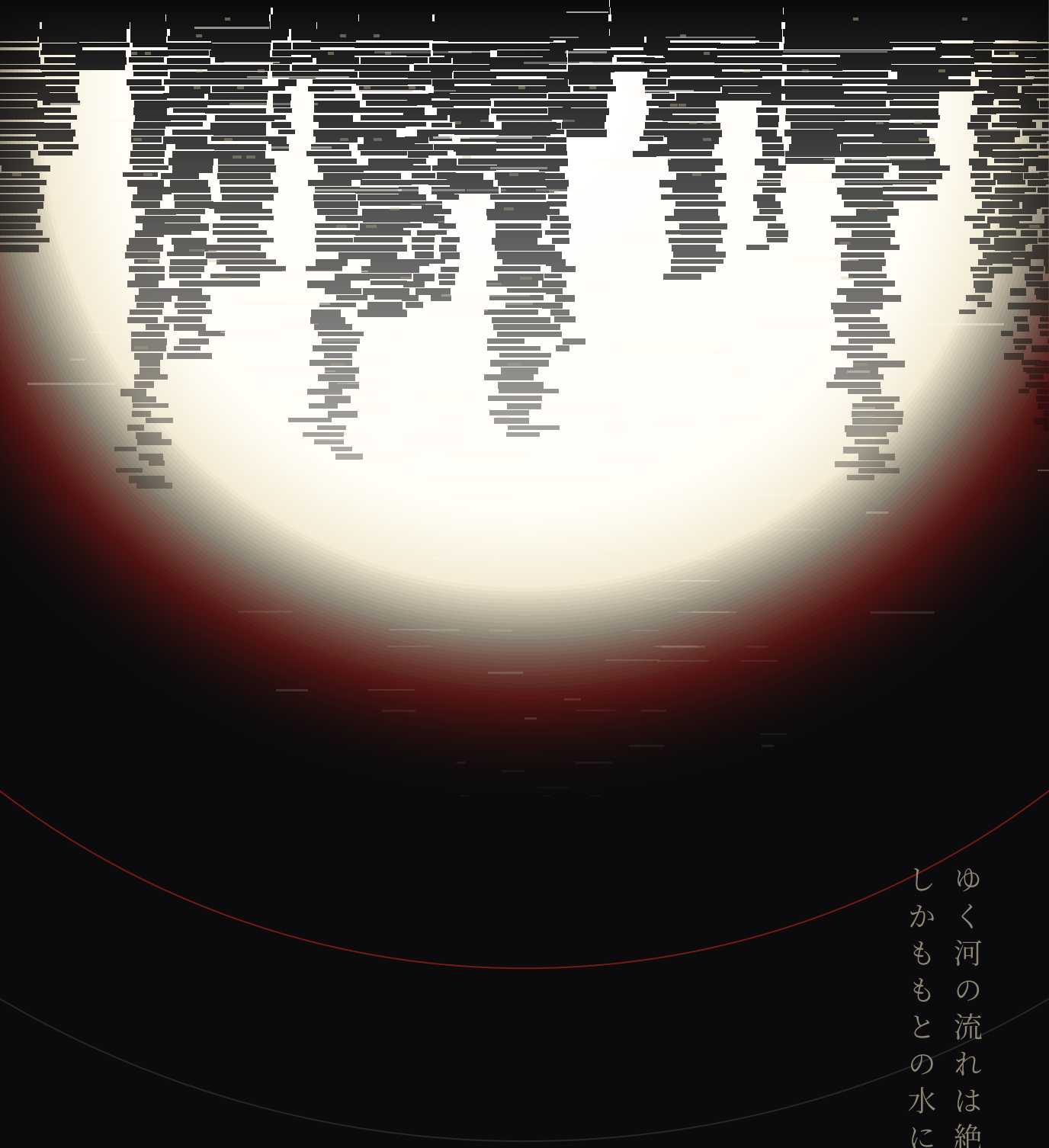
CATABOLIC SOVEREIGNTY

異化の主権

The Accursed Child, the Hollow Center, and the Metabolic Unconscious of Postwar Japan in Katsuhiro Otomo's Akira

1982 — 1990





ゆく河の流れは絶えずして、
しかももとの水にあらず。

KAMO NO CHŌMEI · HŌJŌKI · 1212

“The current of the flowing river never fails, and yet it is never the same water.”

ABSTRACT

Katsuhiro Otomo's Akira was serialized as a manga in Kōdansha's Weekly Young *Magazine* from 1982 to 1990 and released as an animated feature in 1988. It has been read chiefly in four ways: as an allegory of nuclear trauma (Napier 1993; Freiberg 1996), as a postmodern dramaturgy of youthful resistance (Standish 1998), as a figuration of capitalist modes of destruction (Lamarre 2008), and as a founding monument of an "exploding subculture" whose repressed origin is the atomic bomb (Murakami 2005; Sawaragi 2005). This dissertation contends that these readings, however acute, share a representational presupposition. Each treats destruction as the *referent* of the work: a past to be mourned, a spectacle to be consumed, or a logic to be exposed. Against this presupposition, it argues that *Akira* is less a representation of catastrophe than a speculative theory of its *administration*. Specifically, it theorizes a form of modern power here termed *catabolic sovereignty*: the custody, storage, deferral, and release of annihilating force, held in reserve within the bodies of children and sealed beneath the monuments of national renewal.

The dissertation adapts the biological distinction between anabolism, the energy-consuming synthesis of complex structures, and catabolism, their energy-releasing degradation, and reads that distinction through Georges Bataille's general economy of excess. On this basis it situates *Akira* against two backdrops. The first is the architectural and economic imaginary of postwar Japanese Metabolism: Tange Kenzō's *Plan for Tokyo, 1960*, Kurokawa Kishō's capsule architecture, and Isozaki Arata's ruin-futurism. The second is that imaginary's Bataillean counter-totem, Okamoto Tarō's Tower of the Sun (1970). The dissertation identifies in the ideology of high-growth Japan an *anabolic delusion*. This delusion disavows the degradative processes on which growth depends, and it displaces destruction onto the past (1945), the outside (the American nuclear umbrella), and the future (deterrence). *Akira* returns this disavowed catabolism to the center of the national body.

Three figures organize the argument. Shima Tetsuo embodies *anabolic sovereignty*: incorporation without limit, growth without measure, the Metabolist megastructure collapsed into a single cancerous body. Akira embodies catabolic sovereignty in its pure form. He is No. 28, the frozen child, the mute emperor of the Great Tokyo Empire, and a *hollow center* (Barthes; Kawai Hayao) whose only act is release. Kaneda Shōtarō and Kei figure a third term, *remnant sovereignty*. This is a polity constituted neither by growth nor by explosion but by the bare fact of having remained, and it is theorized here through Agamben's messianic remnant, Derrida's remainder, Benjamin's "destructive character," and Arendt's natality.

The intervening chapters proceed as follows. The numbered Espers are read through Foucault's biopolitics, Agamben's bare life, and Heidegger's standing-reserve. Tetsuo's flesh is read through Bakhtin's grotesque, Kristeva's abject, Deleuze and Guattari's cancerous body without organs, and Mishima Yukio's *Sun and Steel*. Akira's sovereignty is read through Schmitt, Kantorowicz, Maruyama Masao's "system of irresponsibility," and the political theology of the symbol emperor. The work's cosmology is read through several frames: the Buddhist kalpa-cycle of formation, abiding, destruction, and emptiness (成住壊空); the eschatologies of *mappō* and *yonaoshi*; the seismic iconography of the Edo catfish prints; and Nishitani Keiji's distinction between nihility and emptiness. A comparative chapter locates *Akira* within a lineage of speculative philosophy. That lineage runs from Mary Shelley and H. G. Wells through Olaf Stapledon, Arthur C. Clarke, Theodore Sturgeon, Philip K. Dick, J. G. Ballard, Abe Kōbō, and Tezuka Osamu, and on to Miyazaki Hayao, Anno Hideaki, Oshii Mamoru, William Gibson, David Cronenberg, and Tsukamoto Shin'ya.

The dissertation concludes that *Akira* anticipates the political ontology of the post-1989 world with a precision its critics have underestimated. In that world, sovereignty increasingly consists in the custody of technologies of annihilation whose release it cannot finally govern. The examples range from the nuclear latency of the Japanese archipelago to the triple disaster of 2011, the pandemic-deferred Olympiad of 2020, and the contemporary discourse of "containment" surrounding artificial intelligence. Against the catabolic sovereign, *Akira* proposes the sovereignty of those who remain.

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On Texts, Translation, and Romanization

Two principal texts are designated throughout by sigla. *Akira* (M) refers to the manga, cited by volume according to the six-volume Kōdansha edition (1984–1993). Its English translation by Yoko Umezawa, Linda M. York, and Jo Duffy has appeared in editions that differ in orientation, colouration, and pagination, so page-level citation is avoided because no pagination is common to them. *Akira* (F) refers to the 1988 film, cited by sequence. Italicized *Akira* denotes the work; roman Akira denotes the character.

Japanese personal names are given surname first (Ōtomo Katsuhiro, Tange Kenzō). The exceptions are scholars publishing in English under Western name order and the title, which retains the Anglophone form under which the work circulates internationally. Long vowels are marked with macrons except in place-names with established English forms (Tokyo, Osaka, Kyoto). Unless otherwise indicated, translations from Japanese, German, and French are my own. Citations follow an author–date system. Where a translated work is cited, the date of original publication appears in square brackets.

序

INTRODUCTION

The Explosion as Method

> ゆく河の流れは絶えずして、しかももとの水にあらず。
> *The current of the flowing river never fails, and yet it is never the same water.*
> — KAMO NO CHŌMEI, *Hōjōki* (1212)

> Unschuld ist das Kind und Vergessen, ein Neubeginnen, ein Spiel, ein aus sich rollendes Rad.
> *The child is innocence and forgetting, a beginning-anew, a game, a wheel rolling out of itself.*
> — FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE, *Also sprach Zarathustra* (1883)

0.1 The White Hemisphere

The film opens where apocalypses customarily close. An aerial prospect of Tokyo is rendered with the cool, depopulated exactitude of an architectural survey. It is then annulled from within by a white hemisphere that swells across the city until there is nothing left to see. A caption dates the event to 16 July 1988, the day of the film's own theatrical release. By an irony of the calendar that no reading can afford to discount, this was also the forty-third anniversary of the Trinity test at Alamogordo.

The manga, begun six years earlier, performs the same gesture in print. Its opening page records the detonation of a "new-type bomb" (*shingata bakudan*) over the Kantō region in December 1982, the month in which the serial itself entered circulation. The event precipitates a third world war, and beside its crater a new city will rise decades later. The phrase is itself a citation: *shingata bakudan* is the term under which the Japanese wartime press first reported the destruction of Hiroshima in August 1945.

In both versions, then, the moment at which the work enters public time is inscribed as the moment at which Tokyo leaves it. The text does not remember the explosion; it coincides with it. The survivor-literature of Hiroshima and Nagasaki construes the bomb as a wound to be witnessed and mourned (Lifton 1967; Ōe 1965). *Akira* instead stages it as a performative: the work announces itself *as* a detonation. Everything that follows

unfolds within the time of an aftermath whose cause has not yet been disclosed: the reconstructed metropolis, the gangs and riots, the coup, the cult, and the Great Tokyo Empire.

When that cause is disclosed, it reorganizes the entire field of meaning. The "new-type bomb" was not a bomb but a boy. The originary catastrophe of Neo-Tokyo's history was the awakening of Akira, the twenty-eighth subject of a secret state programme in psychic weaponry. The state has sealed his remains (in the film) or his sleeping body (in the manga) beneath the construction site of the Olympic stadium.

The work's entire philosophical wager is compressed into this substitution. Historical memory places at the origin an object released from an American B-29 over Hiroshima, a bomb that had killed some 140,000 people by the end of 1945; *Akira* places there a child produced by the domestic state. The postwar discourse of victimhood (*higaisha ishiki*) locates annihilation outside the national body; *Akira* locates it inside the capital, inside the laboratory, inside the body of a Japanese child. The explosion is thereby transposed from the register of the event to the register of the resource. It becomes something produced, numbered, stored, sealed, and held in reserve.

The film closes, moreover, as it opened: with a sphere. Tetsuo's metastasizing flesh is drawn into a second white globe, which contracts to a point of light. The film figures this, with unmistakable cosmogonic intent, as the germination of a new universe. Between the two spheres lies the whole work. The ancient figure of the sphere whose center is everywhere and whose circumference is nowhere (the metaphor whose migrations Borges traced from the pre-Socratics to Pascal) is here precisely inverted. Akira's sphere has its circumference everywhere, for it is coextensive with the city it consumes. Its center is nowhere, for at its heart there is only a child who does not speak. The chapters that follow attempt to take the measure of that hollow center, and of the forms of power that organize themselves around it.

0.2 The State of the Question

The critical literature on *Akira* is extensive, and its most influential contributions share a common center of gravity. Susan Napier's essay on the "panic sites" of the Japanese imagination of disaster (1993) established the interpretive default. On this view, *Akira* belongs to a genealogy of destruction-fantasy that extends from Honda Ishirō's *Gojira* (1954) through Komatsu Sakyō's *Nippon chinbotsu* (1973). In that genealogy the nation rehearses, in displaced form, the traumas of 1945 and the anxieties of high growth. Napier's later typology of anime's apocalyptic, festival, and elegiac modes (2005) refined this into an account of *Akira* as the paradigmatic instance of the apocalyptic mode. That mode is shot through with the carnivalesque energies of the festival: the riot, the bike run, the momentary collapse of hierarchy.

Other critics have developed adjacent readings. Freda Freiberg (1996) read the film's destructions as a "postnuclear sublime," in which the unrepresentable horror of the bomb is converted into an aesthetic of exhilarated annihilation. Isolde Standish (1998) placed its youth culture within a postmodern politics of resistance. For her, the culture's ambivalence toward authority is also an ambivalence toward the very possibility of a political subject. Thomas Lamarre, in an essay whose title announces its intervention (2008), relocated the work's catastrophes from the register of national trauma to that of capitalist modes of destruction. On his account, the cyclical annihilation of the built environment is a condition of accumulation rather than its interruption.

Two further contributions made *Akira* a key exhibit in a genealogy of subcultural explosion whose repressed origin is the bomb. Murakami Takashi's exhibition and catalogue *Little Boy* (2005) yoked, in its title, the Hiroshima bomb to the infantilized nation of the postwar settlement. Sawaragi Noi described postwar Japan as a "bad place" (*warui basho*) in which history is serially erased rather than accumulated (1998; 2005). Work on Japanese cyberpunk (Tatsumi 2006; Brown 2010) has situated the text within transpacific circuits of the posthuman. Azuma Hiroki's theory of "database consumption" (2009 [2001]) implicitly places it among the last grand narratives before the post-1995 dispersal of narrative into recombinable elements.

These readings are indispensable, and the present study is indebted to each. Yet they share what I shall call a *representational presupposition*. Each treats destruction as the referent of the work, as what *Akira* is "about." That referent may be construed as a historical trauma awaiting mourning (Napier, Freiberg, Murakami), a structural logic awaiting exposure (Lamarre), or an aesthetic intensity awaiting description (Freiberg, Standish). The question each poses, in effect, is: *what does Akira's destruction represent?*

That question is legitimate, but it occludes another, which the work poses with insistent literalism: *how is destruction produced, stored, administered, and released?* At the level of its plot, *Akira* is less a narrative of catastrophe than a narrative about the custody of catastrophe. Its principal institutions are apparatuses for the management of an annihilating force: the secret laboratory that numbers and drugs its child subjects, the cryogenic vault beneath the Olympic works, the orbital laser SOL, the Colonel's coup and martial law, the millenarian following of Lady Miyako, the American intervention, and the Great Tokyo Empire itself. Destruction in *Akira* is less an event than a reserve.

0.3 From Representation to Administration

It is instructive to read the work's dramatis personae not as psychological individuals but as positions in a field defined by their relation to this reserve.

- The Colonel (Shikishima) seeks to contain it.
- The councillor Nezu seeks to exploit it.

— Lady Miyako and the film's street prophets seek to sacralize it.
— The resistance seeks to seize it.
— The Americans seek to neutralize or appropriate it.
— Dr. Ōnishi seeks to know it.
— The Espers seek to guard it with their own bodies.
— Tetsuo seeks to become it.
— Kaneda, the only figure who wants nothing from it at all, seeks to survive it.

Here is a complete typology of political relations to annihilation: containment (the security state), exploitation (faction and capital), sacralization (religion), seizure (the revolutionary vanguard), hegemony (the imperial outside), knowledge (technoscience), sacrifice (a guardian caste), incorporation (the self-made sovereign), and survival (the remnant). The wager of this dissertation is that *Akira* is best understood as the working-out of this typology to its limit. It is a speculative theory of what sovereignty becomes when its ultimate object is neither territory, nor population, nor law, but the stored capacity for the end of the world.

This reorientation also lets us take seriously a feature that the representational readings tend to absorb into generic convention: the weapons of *Akira* are children. The Espers are not simply victims, in the idiom of *higaisha ishiki*. Nor are they simply mutants, in the idiom of the Anglophone superhero comic. They are a *caste*: a priesthood of containment whose bodies are the vessels in which the state stores what it cannot use and dare not release. The question *Akira* poses is therefore not "what happened to Tokyo?" but "what is a society that keeps its end in the bodies of its children?" Beyond that lies a further question: "what would a polity look like that no longer did so?"

0.4 Method: Detrital Reading, General Economy, Stereoscopy

Three methodological commitments follow. The first I call *detrital reading*. Ōtomo's draughtsmanship is celebrated for a hyperrealist line that refuses the conventionalized shorthand of the Tezuka tradition; the phrase "Ōtomo shock" (*Ōtomo shokku*) names its impact on the manga of the late 1970s and early 1980s. His faces carry recognizably Japanese physiognomies rather than the culturally "odorless" (*mukokuseki*) features that Iwabuchi Kōichi (2002) identified as a condition of the exportability of Japanese media. His urban perspectives are constructed with the rigour of architectural drafting. Above all, he draws debris.

Ōtomo's rubble is not background but figure. Every fragment of a shattered façade, every twisted length of reinforcing bar and pulverized slab, is individually drawn. In the great spreads of collapse, the density of hatching becomes the primary signifier of force. In Peircean terms, debris is an index: it bears the physical trace of the energy that

produced it. To read *Akira* detritally is to read for remainders rather than for meanings, attending to what is left over when a structure is broken down. It is also to treat the work's obsessive rendering of breakdown products as the key to its ontology.

The inverse is equally telling: where force is greatest, the line fails. As Chapter 2 will argue, *Akira*'s detonations are drawn above all as whiteness, as zones of unmarked paper bounded by the densest hatching in the book. For an artist whose signature is the proliferating line, the explosion is the degree zero of drawing, the place where the medium itself is catabolized.

The second commitment is to general-economic analysis in Bataille's sense (1988 [1949]). This means studying systems not from the standpoint of scarcity and utility (what Bataille calls the "restricted economy") but from the standpoint of the surplus energy. Every living system accumulates such a surplus and must expend it, gloriously or catastrophically. Applied to a text, general-economic analysis attends to excess, meaning the surplus of detail, violence, and duration that exceeds any narrative function, and to the modes of its discharge.

The two *Akiras* offer an exemplary case. The manga, more than two thousand pages composed across eight years, is a work of expenditure, prodigal in digression and destruction. The film, running a little over two hours, is a compression. It breaks the manga's narrative down into its energetic components and recombines them into a new form. It is a catabolic reduction that is also, as its cosmogonic ending insists, a genesis.

The third commitment is cautionary and concerns the cultural politics of theory. Two errors bracket the field. The first is the culturalism that treats Japan as an essence explicable only by native categories (the discourse of *nihonjinron*). The second is the "techno-orientalism" (Morley and Robins 1995) that treats Japan as a screen onto which Western anxieties about technology are projected, and to which Western theory is applied without remainder. Against both, I adopt a *stereoscopic* method in which Japanese and Euro-American conceptual archives are read as co-equal and mutually illuminating.

Several pairings illustrate the method. Bataille's general economy is set beside the Buddhist cycle of formation, abiding, destruction, and emptiness (*jō-jū-e-kū*, 成住壊空). Schmitt's decisionist sovereign is set beside Maruyama Masao's "system of irresponsibility." Deleuze and Guattari's body without organs is set beside Mishima Yukio's metaphysics of sun and steel. Agamben's messianic remnant is set beside the millenarian *yonaoshi* (世直し, "world-rectification") of the catfish prints of 1855. The stereoscope does not fuse its two images into one; it produces depth from their disparity. So too here.

0.5 Thesis and Lexicon

The dissertation's central claim can now be stated. In narrative and graphic form, *Akira* articulates a theory of modern power that I term *catabolic sovereignty*. The term adapts the biological distinction between the two limbs of metabolism. *Anabolism* is the constructive synthesis of complex structures from simpler components, and it consumes energy. *Catabolism* is the degradative breakdown of complex structures, and it releases energy. Every living system is the rhythm of both.

I argue that the postwar Japanese state articulated its legitimacy through an ideology of pure anabolism. Its elements were growth, reconstruction, and income-doubling; the Olympiad and the Exposition as rites of rebirth; and the Metabolist megastructure as the architectural image of a city that renews itself without dying. At the same time, the state disavowed the catabolic processes on which that growth depended and displaced them onto three elsewheres. The first was the past: 1945, the war as a closed chapter. The second was the outside: the American nuclear umbrella and the bases that sustained it. The third was the future: deterrence, the catastrophe perpetually deferred. I call this ideology the *anabolic delusion*.

Akira returns the disavowed catabolism to the center of the national body. Its secret state is sovereign not because it decides on the exception, as in Schmitt's formula, but because it holds the explosion in reserve. The sovereign is the one who keeps custody of catabolism.

Four further concepts articulate this thesis.

The *accursed child* names the figure in which a growth society stores its "accursed share" (*la part maudite*). This is Bataille's term for the surplus that can be neither productively used nor safely retained. The figure thereby inverts what Lee Edelman (2004) calls the "reproductive futurism" that installs the Child as the emblem and guarantor of the future. In *Akira*, the child is not the guarantor of the future but the storage medium of its end.

The *hollow center* draws on Barthes (1982 [1970]) and Kawai Hayao (1982). It names the structural position of Akira himself: a sovereign whose power is coextensive with his muteness. In him the work stages, with a directness unmatched in postwar popular culture, the political theology of the symbol emperor.

Catabolic historicity names the temporality of a city whose history is less a progress than a rhythm of accumulation and discharge. For Tokyo, that rhythm runs through 1657, 1855, 1923, and 1945, and in fiction through 1982 or 1988 and the second destruction that follows decades later. It is legible both in Bataille's general economy and in the Buddhist kalpa-cycle.

Finally, *remnant sovereignty* names the alternative the work proposes in its closing pages. It is a polity constituted neither by growth nor by explosion but by the bare fact of having remained: a sovereignty of survivors whose founding act is the refusal of external

tutelage. Its emblem is neither the throne nor the bomb but the motorcycle, repurposed from the vehicle of the accident into the vehicle of a beginning.

Three figures carry this argument, and their triangulation structures the whole dissertation. Tetsuo is anabolic sovereignty: the will to incorporate, the body that grows without measure until it becomes a cancer upon the city it has absorbed. Akira is catabolic sovereignty: the child who does nothing but release, emptiness enthroned. Kaneda, with Kei, is the remnant: the one who neither grows without limit nor explodes, but rides on. The three are not moral types. They are positions in a general economy, and the drama of the work is the drama of their relation.

0.6 Architecture of the Argument

Part One ("Genealogies") reconstructs the conditions of the work's emergence.

- **Chapter 1** establishes the textual situation: two *Akiras*, two endings, a serial overtaken by its adaptation. It traces the work's antecedents in Ōtomo's earlier fiction, in Yokoyama Mitsuteru's *Tetsujin 28-gō*, in the sociology of the *bōsōzoku*, and in the periodization of postwar Japanese culture as an "age of fiction."
- **Chapter 2** reads the work's nuclear iconography through three frames: the nuclear criticism of the 1980s, Günther Anders's philosophy of the Promethean gap, and a comparison with Tezuka's *Tetsuwan Atomu*. That comparison discloses *Akira*'s systematic typology of the pathologies of maturation.
- **Chapter 3** reads Neo-Tokyo as a Metabolist city. It locates the historical origin of the anabolic delusion in the conjunction of 1960: the Metabolist manifesto, the income-doubling plan, and the renewed Security Treaty.

Part Two ("Economies") follows the disavowed energy into bodies.

- **Chapter 4** reconstructs the genealogy that runs from Marcel Mauss's theory of the gift through Bataille to Okamoto Tarō's Tower of the Sun. It reads the orbital laser SOL and the amputation of Tetsuo's arm through Mishima's *Sun and Steel*, and it formulates catabolic sovereignty as a revision of Schmitt through Bataille.
- **Chapter 5** reads the Esper programme through biopolitics, bare life, and standing-reserve. It situates the programme within the Cold War history of state parapsychology and the Japanese history of "supernatural ability" (*chōnōryoku*), from the clairvoyance controversies of 1910 to Aum Shinrikyō.
- **Chapter 6** reads Tetsuo's body as grotesque, abject, and cancerous body without organs, and as a parodic fulfilment of Mishima's metaphysics of the body. It then interprets his regression into a colossal infant through Doi Takeo's psychology of dependence and Nietzsche's three metamorphoses.

Part Three ("Theologies") turns to sovereignty and the sacred.

- **Chapter 7** reads Akira as the hollow center of a political theology whose referent is the symbol emperor, and situates the manga's imperial arc within the final years of the Shōwa era.
- **Chapter 8** reads the work's cosmology through Buddhist eschatology, the millenarian tradition of *yonaoshi*, the catfish prints of 1855, and the Kyoto School. It argues that Akira is the catfish sleeping beneath the stadium's keystone.
- **Chapter 9** situates *Akira* comparatively among the speculative philosophies of Anglophone, European, and Japanese science fiction.

Part Four ("Synthesis") consists of two parts.

- **Chapter 10** formalizes the theory of catabolic sovereignty.
- **The Conclusion** reads the manga's final ride through the ruins as the founding scene of remnant sovereignty, and considers the theory's purchase on the catastrophes of the twenty-first century.

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PART ONE

Genealogies

01 Two *Akiras*

02 The Atomic Child

03 Neo-Tokyo as Metabolist City

01

CHAPTER ONE

Two *Akiras*

Texts, Media, and the Archaeology of a Catastrophe

1.1 Serial Time and Sealed Time

Akira exists in two principal forms, and their relation is neither that of original and adaptation nor that of draft and fair copy. The manga was serialized in *Weekly Young Magazine* between December 1982 and June 1990. It was collected in six oversized volumes, the last of which appeared only in 1993.

The film was produced by a production committee (*seisaku iinkai*) that united Kōdansha with Mainichi Broadcasting, Bandai, the advertising agency Hakuhōdō, and Tōhō, among others. It was animated by Tokyo Movie Shinsha and released in July 1988, when the serial was still two years from its conclusion; serialization was intermittently suspended while Ōtomo directed. The film therefore ends a story that had not yet ended. It imposes on the unfinished serial a closure that the serial would subsequently decline. The manga, resuming, survives its own adaptation and continues for two further years beyond the cosmogonic terminus the film had already reached.

The relation between the two texts is best described in the vocabulary this dissertation develops. The film is the manga's first catabolism: a breakdown of its narrative into an energetic core that is then reconstituted as cosmology. The manga is the film's remnant: the part that remains after the first ending and goes on to found a polity.

The two endings accordingly encode the two poles of the argument. The film closes in *metaphysics*. Tetsuo, drawn into Akira's sphere, is dissolved into the singularity from which a new universe emerges, and his disembodied voice pronounces the self-naming that stands as the first utterance of the new creation: *boku wa Tetsuo*, "I am Tetsuo." The manga closes in *politics*. After the final annihilation, Kaneda, Kei, and the surviving youths confront the arriving international (principally American) forces and decline their

aid. They declare the independence of the "Great Tokyo Empire Akira" (*Dai-Tōkyō Teikoku Akira*) and ride out into ruins through which, for a moment, the spectral city of the past rises again.

Any adequate reading must hold both endings in view. There is the cosmogony and the constitution, the new universe and the new polity. There is the genesis that follows catabolism and the sovereignty that remains after it. The film asks what comes after the end of the world. The manga asks who comes after it.

The divergence also bears on the status of interpretation. Critics who work primarily from the film (Freiberg's postnuclear sublime is paradigmatic) tend to read *Akira* as a work of transcendence, in which catastrophe opens onto cosmic rebirth. Critics who work from the manga tend to read it as a work of political immanence, in which catastrophe opens onto the question of order. Neither reading is wrong. Each mistakes one limb of the work's metabolism for the whole. The present study treats the relation between the two texts as itself meaningful: the film's cosmogonic closure is a *premature* ending, a transcendence reached too early, and the manga's continuation is the work's own critique of it.

1.2 Before *Akira*: *Fireball*, *Dōmu*, and the Senescent Child

Ōtomo Katsuhiro was born in 1954 in Miyagi Prefecture and moved to Tokyo in 1973, the year of his professional debut. That debut was a short adaptation, for *Manga Action*, of Prosper Mérimée's "Mateo Falcone" (1829), a tale in which a Corsican father executes his young son for betraying a fugitive to the authorities. This inaugural choice deserves a pause. The filicidal logic it dramatizes, the sacrifice of the child to a code that transcends him, will recur in *Akira* transposed from the household to the state as the work's foundational violence.

The short fiction of the following years (collected in *Shōto Pīsu*, 1979, and elsewhere) developed a laconic realism. It is widely recognized as indebted both to the American New Cinema and to the *bande dessinée* of Jean Giraud (Moebius), whose clarity of line and depth of space Ōtomo absorbed and radicalized. This realism records drifting young men, provincial ennui, and the flat affect of the *shirake sedai*, the "apathetic generation" that came of age after the collapse of the student movements. It is the soil from which *Akira*'s gangs grow.

Two works bridge this realism and *Akira*'s speculative register.

Fireball (1979), left unfinished, sets an urban insurgency against a central computer pointedly named ATOM, and lets psychic power erupt from the body of one of its members. Already the triad of city, machine, and uncontainable body is in place. Already, too, the name of Tezuka's benevolent atomic boy has been transferred to the apparatus of domination.

Dōmu (serialized 1980–81; collected 1983) became, in 1983, the first manga to receive the Japan SF Grand Prize (*Nihon SF Taishō*). It transposes the psychic war into a *danchi*, one of the vast public housing estates that were the high-growth state's signature contribution to the lived environment. The Japan Housing Corporation's ferroconcrete slabs, stacked in rational grids on the urban periphery, were the domestic face of the Metabolist dream. In this setting a senile old man, Chō, possessed of telekinetic powers, kills residents one by one with the capricious cruelty of a child. He is at last opposed by a little girl, Etsuko, whose psychic strength exceeds his own.

The *danchi* of *Dōmu* invites comparison with J. G. Ballard's *High-Rise* (1975), in which a luxury tower block regresses into tribal warfare. In both, the rationalized dwelling-machine of welfare modernity becomes the stage of a regression that its planners could not model. The difference is instructive. Ballard's regression is social: the residents revert to atavistic hierarchies. Ōtomo's is *developmental*: the old man reverts to infancy, and the child assumes the gravity of age.

Dōmu's central inversion, the old man as child and the child as sage, anticipates *Akira*'s Espers, whose child-sized bodies bear the wizened faces of the elderly. I shall call this figure the *senescent child*: a body in which the developmental time of growth has been short-circuited, so that infancy and senility coincide without the mediating term of maturity. The senescent child is the first of *Akira*'s pathologies of maturation, and its genealogy runs through *Dōmu* to the heart of the later work (Chapter 2).

1.3 The Iron Man and the Lost Controller

Akira's most conspicuous borrowing is from Yokoyama Mitsuteru's *Tetsujin 28-gō* (Iron Man No. 28, 1956–66), the founding text of the Japanese giant-robot genre. Yokoyama's robot was conceived by the Imperial Army as a secret weapon to reverse the course of the war. The war ended before it could be deployed. In the postwar narrative, the robot is operated by remote control by a boy detective, Kaneda Shōtarō, the son of its designer.

Ōtomo's borrowings from this cast are extensive. His protagonist bears the same name. His antagonist is Tetsuo, "iron hero" (鉄雄). The Colonel's surname, Shikishima, is drawn from Yokoyama's cast, where it belongs to the scientist who guards the boy and his weapon. Akira himself is "No. 28." The homage is well known; its structural significance is not.

Tetsujin 28-gō is a parable of the postwar settlement. A war machine of unprecedented power survives the defeat and is domesticated as the instrument of a child in the service of justice. The machine has no will of its own: whoever holds the controller commands it, for good or ill. The robot's moral neutrality, together with the plot's recurrent struggles for possession of the controller, amounts to a popular political

theory of the weapon as pure means. That theory is exactly congruent with the postwar constitutional imaginary, in which the capacity for violence persisted but its operation was relocated elsewhere.

Akira rewrites this parable at every point. The secret weapon is no longer a machine but a child. It has not been domesticated but frozen. The boy who bears Kaneda Shōtarō's name holds no controller at all. The weapon has become a subject, indeed two subjects, the silent Akira and the raging Tetsuo. The whole narrative can thus be read as the drama of a lost remote control: the end of the postwar fiction in which the archipelago's catabolic capacity was operated, at a distance, by someone else.

The name Shikishima deserves further note, for it is also an archaic poetic appellation for Japan itself. The phrase *shikishima no michi*, "the way of Shikishima," denotes the tradition of *waka* poetry. The Colonel who guards the sleeping weapon on behalf of the state thus bears the name of the nation. The overdetermination is characteristic: Ōtomo's onomastics are rarely innocent. Tetsuo's surname, Shima, means "island," and the iron hero of the island will prove to stand in an intimate relation to the archipelago's fantasies of hardness and of self-sufficient power (Chapters 4 and 6). The genealogy of iron also extends forward. Tsukamoto Shin'ya's *Tetsuo* (1989), made in the year after Ōtomo's film, stages the fusion of flesh and scrap metal as an erotic apocalypse, and its very title invites comparison.

1.4 The Capsules: *Bōsōzoku*, Parody, and the Pharmacology of Youth

Kaneda's gang, the Capsules, are *bōsōzoku*: the motorcycle "speed tribes" whose nocturnal runs were among the most visible forms of youth deviance in 1970s and 1980s Japan. Ikuya Sato's *Kamikaze Biker* (1991), based on fieldwork among Kyoto gangs in the early 1980s, remains the indispensable account. Sato reads the *bōsōzoku* not simply as a pathology of anomie but as a form of *play*. The run is a structured experience of absorbed "flow," a performance of danger before an audience, and a parody of adult institutions. Strikingly, the parody extends to the iconography of the wartime state, from the rising-sun flag to the "special-attack uniforms" (*tokkōfuku*) modelled on those of kamikaze pilots.

The *bōsōzoku*, in other words, were parodic kamikaze. They re-enacted the sacrificial velocity of 1945 at the level of the body and the machine, emptied of its political referent and returned as spectacle. This is the precise historical texture of *Akira*'s opening sequences, in which the Capsules and the Clowns wage their highway war beneath the towers of Neo-Tokyo. It explains why that war, though ostensibly about nothing, carries such a charge. The gangs are rehearsing, in the idiom of play, the sacrificial logic the state has stored in the Espers.

Three features of Ōtomo's gang deserve emphasis.

The first is its insignia: a pill capsule, encircled on the back of Kaneda's jacket by the English legend "Good for health, bad for education." The gang is named not for an animal or a weapon but for a *dose*, a unit of pharmacological containment, and the pun ramifies throughout the work. The Capsules deal in pills. Tetsuo's powers are first managed and then fed by the laboratory's capsules. The Espers are sustained by drugs. Akira himself sleeps in a cryogenic capsule. The capsule is the elementary form of the work's economy of containment, and Chapter 3 will trace its architectural genealogy.

The second is the gang's institutional frame: a vocational training school, the lowest rung of the educational meritocracy that sorted the postwar population into its productive destinations. The Capsules are the residue of the examination system, the human by-product of an education optimized for growth. Their "bad for education" is less rebellion than description.

The third is the gang's affect. It belongs to the *shirake* cohort of the late 1970s and the *shinjinrui*, the "new humans," of the mid-1980s. It also belongs to a period of moral panic about school violence (*kōnai bōryoku*) and bullying (*ijime*). The film's flashbacks show that Tetsuo was bullied as a child and protected by Kaneda. His entire trajectory can be read through what Maruyama Masao called the "transfer of oppression" (*yokuatsu no ijō*): the mechanism by which pressure from above is discharged downward, each level compensating for its subordination by dominating the level beneath (Maruyama 1963). Tetsuo's power, when it comes, is the transfer of oppression raised to cosmic scale. The bullied child becomes the bully of the universe. It is no accident that his first victims are members of his own gang.

1.5 The Age of Fiction and the Terminal Text

The sociologist Mita Munesuke divided postwar Japan into an "age of ideals" (*risō no jidai*), an "age of dreams" (*yume no jidai*), and an "age of fiction" (*kyokō no jidai*) (Mita 1995). Ōsawa Masachi reworked the scheme into two phases. The first was an age of ideals from 1945 to about 1970. The second was an age of fiction from about 1970 to 1995, closed by the Aum Shinrikyō sarin attack on the Tokyo subway. After that attack Ōsawa would speak of an "age of impossibility" (Ōsawa 1996; 2008).

Akira is the paradigmatic text of the age of fiction. It was produced after the collapse of the ideals that had organized the political imagination of the first postwar decades: the Anpo struggles of 1960, the Zenkyōtō occupations of 1968–69, and the self-destruction of the United Red Army in its purges and in the siege at Asama Sansō in 1972. It was produced before the moment at which, in Ōsawa's account, the apocalyptic fictions of subculture passed over into act.

Ōtsuka Eiji's contemporaneous theory of "narrative consumption" (1989) holds that the consumers of serial fictions desire not individual stories but access to the "grand narrative," the world-setting from which the stories are generated. This explains the

form of *Akira*'s appeal: its world is vast, systematically worked out, and only partially disclosed. Azuma's later account of the decay of the grand narrative into a "database" of detachable elements (2009 [2001]) marks the horizon beyond which *Akira* could no longer be written.

The riot sequences of *Akira* are, for a reader of Ōtomo's generation, unmistakably citational. Students and the unemployed battle riot police; there are Molotov cocktails and water cannon, and barricades in the entertainment district. These scenes recall the street battles of 1968–69 in Shinjuku and on the Hongō campus of the University of Tokyo. The resistance cell to which Kei belongs is a late avatar of the New Left sect: doctrinaire, hierarchical, and compromised by its dependence on the councillor Nezu. The work thus stages the ideals of the 1960s as already fictional, available to the 1980s only as iconography. Its genuinely new political energy belongs to those who, like Kaneda, have no ideals at all.

Finally, the manga's composition coincides with an extraordinary cluster of terminal events.

- Its imperial arc was drawn across the final years of the Shōwa era, including the months from September 1988 to January 1989 in which the emperor lay dying and the nation practised ritual "self-restraint" (*jishuku*) (Field 1991).
- The Berlin Wall fell in 1989.
- Francis Fukuyama announced "the end of history" in the same year (1989).
- In December 1989 the Nikkei index reached a peak it would not regain for thirty-four years, before the collapse of the asset bubble inaugurated Japan's "lost decade."

The serial ended in June 1990. *Akira* is in this sense a *terminal text*. It narrates the end of a world at the moment when several worlds were ending in fact: the Shōwa era, the Cold War, and the high-growth economy. Its claim upon us derives in large part from a double discrepancy. The ends it imagined were not those that occurred, and the ends that did occur have proved, in retrospect, less terminal than they seemed.

1.6 The Film as Apparatus

The film's production history is itself a chapter in the general economy of the bubble. It was financed by a consortium on a budget then without precedent in Japanese animation. It was animated with a density of drawings, fluidity of motion, and range of colour unmatched in the industry, with a palette extended especially to render the saturated neon of the nocturnal city and the phosphorescence of its detonations. The film also recorded its dialogue before animation. This practice, standard in American studios but unusual in Japan, allowed mouths to be animated to voices rather than voices dubbed to mouths.

Its score, by the collective Geinoh Yamashirogumi under Yamashiro Shōji, fused Balinese gamelan (including the massive bamboo *jegog*), Nō vocal technique, and Buddhist liturgical chant; one cue is titled "Shōmyō," after the Japanese tradition of sutra-singing. The result is a sonic cosmology in which ritual time, cyclical and collective, is superimposed upon the linear velocity of the image. Chapter 8 will argue that this superimposition is the film's most precise formal statement of catabolic historicity. The eye sees the arrow of progress. The ear hears the wheel of the kalpa.

The work's international trajectory was equally consequential. The film was released in North America in 1989 by the small distributor Streamline Pictures and in Britain by Island World Communications, and was subsequently canonized on video. It thereby became the threshold through which "anime" entered Anglophone critical consciousness (Napier 2005). In parallel, Marvel's Epic Comics imprint published a colourized English edition of the manga (1988–1995), whose computer colouring by Steve Oliff was among the first of its kind in American comics.

The globalization of *Akira* is thus coeval with its composition. While still unfinished, the work was already a transpacific object. Its Western reception, which read it as cyberpunk, as the Tokyo cousin of *Blade Runner*, and as exemplary "Japanimation," forms part of the history this dissertation reads. That reception also exemplifies the techno-orientalist gaze described in §0.4, against which the stereoscopic method is directed.

1.7 Conclusion: A Force Operated by No One

The genealogies reconstructed in this chapter converge on a single figure. Ōtomo's early realism supplied the drifting, affectless young men who will be caught up in a catastrophe they neither cause nor understand. *Dōmu* supplied the senescent child and the psychic violence of the welfare estate. *Tetsujin 28-gō* supplied the wartime weapon preserved beyond the war and operated by remote control. The *bōsōzoku* supplied the parodic kamikaze, whose play rehearses a sacrificial velocity emptied of its referent. The age of fiction supplied the framework within which the ideals of the political past survive only as iconography.

Each of these lines leads to the same image: a force produced for war, preserved beyond it, and operated by no one. That image has a name in the work, and a body. It is the atomic child.

02

CHAPTER TWO

The Atomic Child

Nuclear Criticism, the Remainder, and the Pathologies of Maturation

2.1 *Shingata Bakudan*: The White Light and the Failure of the Line

The phrase with which the manga opens binds the work, from its first line, to the discursive history of the bomb. *Shingata bakudan* belongs to the brief interval in August 1945 when the Japanese state, and the press it controlled, possessed a word for the weapon's novelty but not yet for its nature. The survivors' vernacular that displaced it, *pika-don* ("flash-boom"), named the event as a sequence of sensations: light preceding sound, whiteness preceding the blast.

Ōtomo's detonations privilege the *pika* over the *don*. They are rendered first and above all as light, an expanding field in which figure and ground cease to be distinguishable. The iconography draws on a deep reservoir. It includes the photographs of the mushroom clouds and the *Daigo Fukuryū Maru* (Lucky Dragon No. 5), whose crew was irradiated by the American thermonuclear test at Bikini in March 1954. It includes the monster that emerged from the same year's anxieties in Honda Ishirō's *Gojira*. It includes, finally, the diffuse cultural sensibility that the press would later call the nation's "nuclear allergy" (*kaku arerugī*).

Critical accounts have read this iconography through the aesthetics of the sublime. The classical theory of the sublime presupposes a surviving subject whose recovery completes the experience. For Burke (1757), this is the delight of terror felt from a position of safety. For Kant (1790), it is the mind's elevation above the might of nature, which it cannot resist but can think.

It was precisely this presupposition that the "nuclear criticism" of the 1980s placed in question. In the special issue of *Diacritics* devoted to the topic in 1984, Frances Ferguson examined the fate of the sublime under the nuclear condition. Jean-François Lyotard's contemporaneous redefinition of the postmodern sublime as the allusion, within presentation, to the unpresentable (1984 [1979]) supplied a vocabulary for artworks that

gesture toward what they cannot show. Freiberg's "postnuclear sublime" belongs to this constellation. It reads the film's spectacle as a conversion of horror into exhilaration, and it is persuasive as an account of the animated film's kinetic pleasures.

Ōtomo's solution to the problem of the unpresentable is, I suggest, more austere than either sublimity or spectacle. For a draughtsman whose signature is the proliferating line, the explosion is rendered as the *absence* of line. It appears as unmarked paper, bounded by the densest hatching in the book, the line that renders every brick, every shard, every rivet of Neo-Tokyo. The catastrophe is drawn as the place where drawing fails.

In semiotic terms, the explosion itself has no index. It is legible only in the debris that surrounds it, which bears its trace as a footprint bears the weight of a body. This is the first principle of detrital reading: *Akira*'s catastrophes are never shown, only inferred from their remainders. The Japanese pictorial tradition speaks of *yohaku* (余白), the eloquent blank that suggests plenitude through reserve. Ōtomo's blanks invert the convention. They do not suggest plenitude; they record annihilation. They are *yohaku* after the bomb.

2.2 *No Apocalypse, Not Now*: The Catastrophe with Remainder

Jacques Derrida's contribution to the same issue of *Diacritics*, "No Apocalypse, Not Now" (1984), argued that nuclear war, never having occurred in its total form, is a "fabulously textual" referent. It exists only in discourse, strategy, simulation, and anticipation. Its specificity lies in the prospect of a destruction without remainder. Such a destruction would annihilate the archive, and with it the very possibility of mourning, memory, and symbolic survival. Literature, for Derrida, belongs in a singular way to the nuclear epoch. As an institution, it depends entirely upon an archive that total war could annihilate without residue.

Akira can be read as a sustained counter-proposition. Its catastrophes are never remainderless. The first leaves a crater, which the new city preserves at its edge. The second, in the manga, leaves a drowned metropolis inhabited by survivors, cultists, and gangs. Even the last, which the film figures as cosmogony, leaves Kaneda, Kei, and Kai on the ruined ground, and the manga leaves an entire polity. Above all, the first catastrophe leaves Akira, or what remains of him.

The film's treatment of these remains is one of its most arresting inventions. Tetsuo penetrates the cryogenic vault beneath the Olympic works expecting to find the source of the power he has come to claim. Instead he finds a set of refrigerated glass cylinders containing preserved organs: the child has been dissected, catalogued, and stored.

Here Derrida's later analysis of the archive (1996 [1995]) becomes indispensable. The archive, Derrida argued, is structured by a double movement of conservation and destruction. It is governed by the power of the *archons*, those who guard its documents

and hold the right to interpret them. The "archive fever" (*mal d'archive*) that drives the search for origins is inseparable from the death drive that works silently within every act of preservation.

Akira's vault is an archive of annihilation, and the Colonel is its archon. Tetsuo's descent into it is archive fever in its purest form: the burning desire to return to the origin and to seize the *arkhē* in both of Derrida's senses, commencement and commandment. What the archive yields is the lesson of all archives: the origin is not there. The jars contain organs, not power. The film intimates that the force Akira released was never located in his body at all. It is latent in matter as such, and the child was only its unprecedented aperture. The state has preserved the remainder of a force it never possessed. In this sense, catabolic sovereignty is from the outset a sovereignty over remainders. It claims custody of the explosion by keeping custody of what the explosion left behind.

2.3 The Promethean Gap

The most penetrating philosophy of the nuclear condition written in the first postwar decades is Günther Anders's. His *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956) diagnosed the "Promethean gap" (*prometheisches Gefälle*): the widening discrepancy between what human beings can produce and what they can imagine, feel, and take responsibility for. We can manufacture the bomb, Anders argued, but we cannot represent to ourselves the deaths of a hundred thousand. Our production has outrun our imagination, and our imagination our feeling, so that the gravest acts become "supraliminal," too large to register in the moral sensorium at all.

Anders's correspondence with Claude Eatherly gave the theory its human figure (Anders and Eatherly 1961). Eatherly was the weather-reconnaissance pilot of the Hiroshima mission, and he spent the postwar years tormented by a guilt the society around him refused to recognize. He was the one man in whom the gap had closed, and he was therefore treated as mad.

Akira distributes the terms of Anders's analysis across its cast with remarkable precision.

- **Tetsuo is the Promethean gap made flesh.** His production outruns every image he has of himself. His power grows faster than his capacity to represent, direct, or bear it, until the body that produces it can no longer contain its own products.
- **The Espers are the Eatherlys of Neo-Tokyo,** the beings in whom the gap has closed. Their precognitive visions, Kiyoko's above all, are nothing other than the anticipatory feeling of catastrophe. They are the imagination commensurate with production that Anders demanded and found almost nowhere, and their bodies, withered in childhood, bear the cost of that commensurability.

— **The Colonel stands between them.** He is the one official who knows exactly what the reserve beneath the stadium is, and who alone among the state's servants acts from that knowledge rather than from ambition or faith.

Everyone else lives in what Anders called "apocalypse-blindness" (*Apokalypse-Blindheit*), the incapacity to perceive the catastrophe one is preparing. This includes the council's squabbling politicians, the rioting crowds, and the believers who await Akira's return as salvation.

The distribution has a political corollary that the remainder of this dissertation will develop. In *Akira*, knowledge of the catastrophe is concentrated in the two extremities of the social order. At one end is the apex of the security state, the Colonel. At the other is its most abject subjects, the numbered children. The vast middle, where politics in the ordinary sense takes place, is blind. Catabolic sovereignty is, among other things, an epistemic arrangement: the knowledge of the end is sequestered with the end itself.

2.4 Atom's Shadow: The Atomic Child and the Pathologies of Maturation

No figure of the postwar popular imagination stands closer to Akira, or further from him, than Tezuka Osamu's Tetsuwan Atomu, known in English as Astro Boy (serialized 1952–68). Atom is an atomic-powered boy robot built by Dr. Tenma, head of the Ministry of Science, to replace his son Tobio, who was killed in a traffic accident. Tenma rejects the substitute when he realizes that it cannot grow, and sells it to a circus. Atom is rescued from the circus and becomes the benevolent defender of a technological society.

The chronology is eloquent.

— Atom's serialization began in 1952, the year the Occupation ended.

— In December 1953, Eisenhower's "Atoms for Peace" address to the United Nations inaugurated the programme through which the United States would promote civilian nuclear power among its allies.

— In March 1954, in the same fortnight in which the irradiated *Daigo Fukuryū Maru* was returning from Bikini, the Diet took up the country's first budget for nuclear research.

— In 1956, an "Atoms for Peace" exhibition was mounted in Hiroshima's Peace Memorial Museum itself, temporarily displacing the museum's displays of the bombing (Zwigenberg 2014).

Atom is the child of this conjuncture: the atom domesticated, infantilized, and made kind. He is the nuclear as a small boy with a good heart and a reactor at its core.

Akira is Atom's shadow, the return of everything Atoms for Peace repressed. The inversions are systematic. Atom is a machine made to resemble a child; Akira is a child made into a weapon. Atom's body is a sealed casing around a reactor; Akira's body, in the film, has been opened, reduced to organs in cryogenic jars, the interior exposed as specimen. Atom was built to replace a dead son; Akira was made by a state that had no sons, only subjects.

Most striking of all is a structural rhyme that has, to my knowledge, gone unremarked: *both atomic children are born of traffic accidents*. Atom exists because Tobio died on the road. *Akira*'s narrative begins when Tetsuo, riding ahead of the Capsules at the edge of the old city's ruins, collides with Takashi, the escaped Esper. The accident awakens Tetsuo's latent power and sets in motion the resurrection of Akira.

Paul Virilio's thesis supplies the frame here: every technology invents its own accident, so that to invent the ship is to invent the shipwreck and to invent the reactor is to invent the meltdown (Virilio 2007 [2005]). That thesis receives its narrative demonstration here. In both founding fables of the Japanese atomic child, the accident is not an interruption of technological modernity but its primal scene. The road, the paradigmatic infrastructure of high growth, of the Olympic expressways and the remodelling of the archipelago, is where the atomic child is born.

Ōtsuka Eiji's *Atomu no meidai* (2003), the most searching theoretical account of Tezuka's legacy, provides the next term. Ōtsuka argues that postwar manga was founded on a contradiction Tezuka inherited from wartime culture: the rendering of a "symbolic" cartoon body, a body composed of conventional signs, as a body that can be wounded, bleed, and die. Atom's inability to grow is the emblem of this contradiction. A body of signs cannot mature, for maturation belongs to flesh.

Ōtsuka's "Atom thesis" converges with the most influential diagnosis of postwar Japanese literary culture, Etō Jun's *Seijuku to sōshitsu* (Maturity and Loss, 1967). Etō argued that the postwar Japanese subject had failed to mature because it had failed to pass through the loss that maturation requires: the loss of the mother and of the protective enclosure. Both echo, as if in involuntary citation, the analogy with which General Douglas MacArthur, testifying before the United States Senate in May 1951, characterized the occupied nation. Measured against the standards of modern civilization, he said, the Japanese were like a boy of twelve.

Several later thinkers took up this infantilizing figure. Murakami's *Little Boy* took its title from the Hiroshima bomb and from the figure at once. It argued that the child-cult of postwar subculture, in the *kawaii* and in *otaku* taste, was the aesthetic sediment of a nation kept by its protector in perpetual minority. Katō Norihiro's account of the "twisted" (*nejire*) structure of postwar self-understanding (1997) extends the diagnosis into political theory. So does Shirai Satoshi's thesis of "permanent defeat" (*eizoku haisen*), in which the refusal to acknowledge defeat perpetuates subordination to the victor (2013).

Against this discursive background, *Akira* can be read as a systematic typology of the pathologies of maturation, each corresponding to a figure.

- **Atom cannot grow.** The work ghosts him rather than cites him. He is the child of signs, arrested by his mode of production.
- **Akira will not grow.** He is frozen, cryogenically suspended between his first detonation and his second: a child for decades beneath the city he destroyed.
- **The Espers grow old without growing up.** They are the senescent children, their small bodies stunted by the laboratory's regimen, their faces lined with an age they have not lived.
- **Tetsuo cannot stop growing.** His body, once awakened, proliferates without measure, incorporating machinery, flesh, and finally the stadium itself. This growth recapitulates the whole ideology of high growth as metastasis.
- **Kaneda does none of these.** He neither sleeps, nor ages, nor swells, and he remains an adolescent until the last pages, when he performs the work's single act of maturity: the refusal of tutelage.

The whole of Etō's question is thus distributed across the cast. Maturity, *Akira* suggests, is impossible within the anabolic delusion. Maturation requires the integration of catabolism, of loss, limit, decay, and death, into the life of the organism. A society that has disavowed its catabolism can produce only children who never grow, children who grow old, and children who grow without end.

2.5 Cryostasis: The Sleeping Weapon and the Long Postwar

The image of Akira sleeping beneath the Olympic works condenses the temporal structure of the postwar settlement. That settlement placed the archipelago's catabolic capacity in suspension through three instruments. Article 9 of the 1947 Constitution renounced war and the maintenance of war potential. The Security Treaty of 1951, revised amid mass protest in 1960, placed Japan under an American nuclear umbrella. Prime Minister Satō Eisaku's Three Non-Nuclear Principles (1967–68) pledged that the nation would neither possess nor produce nuclear weapons, nor permit their introduction.

Yet over the following decades the civil nuclear programme accumulated a substantial stockpile of separated plutonium, together with a technical capacity that commentators across the political spectrum came to describe as "latent." This was a deterrent held *in potentia*, neither possessed nor renounced. The discourse of nuclear latency is the exact political correlate of Akira's sleep: a catabolic capacity frozen beneath the monuments of

peaceful growth. In this light the Colonel's apparatus is the guardian of a latency. The Esper programme, which the film places in the years before the first catastrophe, is the story of how a latent capacity was produced in the first place.

Here too the genealogy of *Tetsujin 28-gō* returns. Yokoyama's robot was a wartime weapon that survived the war. Ōtomo's sleeping child is a weapon from before the first catastrophe preserved into the time after it. In both cases, the postwar is not a break with wartime but a *refrigeration* of it: the preservation, at low temperature and out of sight, of the capacity that defeat supposedly abolished.

Sawaragi Noi's account of postwar Japan as a "bad place" finds here its most concrete image. In that bad place history does not accumulate but is periodically erased and reset. The time of cryostasis is not historical time but its suspension. The postwar is imagined, in *Akira*, as a long refrigeration in which the war's weapon is preserved intact beneath a society that has chosen to forget it.

Akira's awakening is the thaw. Like all thaws, it releases not the past but the past's unspent energy. This is why the second destruction of Neo-Tokyo, in the manga, is not a repetition of the first but its intensification. What has been held in reserve returns with interest.

2.6 Conclusion: The Developmental Ontology of *Akira*

The findings of this chapter can be summarized as a developmental ontology. *Akira* distributes the modalities of growth across its figures: arrest, senescence, metastasis, and the precarious adolescence that alone remains open to maturity. It makes the relation of each to the reserved explosion the measure of its being.

The explosion is not, in this ontology, a trauma lodged in the past. It is the organizing principle of the present, the thing around which every developmental possibility is arranged. It is kept cold, catalogued, and guarded by a sovereign whose authority derives from its custody. The nuclear criticism of the 1980s asked whether the absolute catastrophe could leave a remainder. *Akira* answers that it does, and that the remainder is precisely what power keeps.

The next chapter turns from the body of the atomic child to the body of the city built above it.

03

CHAPTER THREE

Neo-Tokyo as Metabolist City

Tange, Kurokawa, Isozaki, and the Anabolic Delusion

3.1 The City on the Bay

Neo-Tokyo stands on reclaimed land in Tokyo Bay, beside the flooded crater of the old city. This topography has a precise architectural antecedent. In 1961, Tange Kenzō and his laboratory at the University of Tokyo published *A Plan for Tokyo*, 1960. The plan proposed to relieve the congestion of a metropolis approaching ten million inhabitants by abandoning its radial, centripetal structure for a linear "civic axis" projected across Tokyo Bay. The axis was a spine of elevated highways and transit loops from which office megastructures and colossal A-frame residential blocks would branch like the vertebrae of an organism.

The plan was never built, but it defined the imaginary of the Japanese megastructure. It also gave the architects in Tange's orbit their programmatic charter. These were Kikutake Kiyonori, Kurokawa Kishō, Maki Fumihiko, and Ōtaka Masato, with the critic Kawazoe Noboru and the designer Awazu Kiyoshi. At the World Design Conference in Tokyo in 1960 they had announced their movement under the name *Metabolism*.

The Metabolist manifesto, *Metabolism 1960: The Proposals for New Urbanism*, conceived the city as an organism undergoing continuous renewal. Permanent infrastructural megastructures would host replaceable, short-lived units, the city's cells, which could be plugged in, detached, and exchanged as the city grew. Kikutake's Marine City (1958), Kurokawa's Helix City (1961), and the Tokyo proposals of Isozaki Arata (who never formally joined the group) gave the vision its iconography.

Its biology was selective. The Metabolists took from their metaphor the principle of renewal, the replacement of old cells by new ones. They did not take the principle of degradation that makes renewal possible. The Japanese term for metabolism, *shinchin taisha* (新陳代謝), literally names a substitution: the new succeeding the old. It names an

exchange in which nothing is broken down, only replaced. Metabolism, in other words, was an *anabolic theory of metabolism*. It imagined growth without catabolism, renewal without decomposition, and the organism without death.

Neo-Tokyo realizes this imaginary with eerie literalism. The film presents clustered towers of glass and light, the stepped mass of the government complex, and elevated expressways on which the gangs conduct their wars. Above all, it presents a city raised from nothing on the bay by a state that has abandoned the old center. What the Metabolists could not achieve by planning, the abandonment of the old radial city, the catastrophe accomplishes by erasure. Neo-Tokyo is Tange's plan realized by explosion.

Ōtomo adds what Metabolism omitted: the crater. The old Tokyo is not replaced but *kept*, as a flooded ruin at the edge of the new city, visible from its highways. It is a restricted zone into which the gangs ride for their races. The Metabolist city renews itself without remainder. Neo-Tokyo carries its remainder beside it like a shadow.

3.2 Capsule and *Homo Movens*

Of all the Metabolists, Kurokawa Kishō took the cellular logic furthest. His "Capsule Declaration" (1969) and the contemporaneous *Homo Movens* (1969) proposed the capsule as the dwelling proper to a new anthropological type: the mobile individual of the information society, detached from the family house and plugged into the infrastructural networks of the city. The Nakagin Capsule Tower in Ginza (1972) realized the proposal. It consisted of one hundred and forty prefabricated capsules bolted to two concrete cores, each capsule designed to be replaced after roughly twenty-five years.

None was ever replaced. The capsules decayed in place. After decades of deterioration and preservation campaigns, the tower was demolished in 2022. A handful of its units survive as museum pieces.

The fate of the Nakagin tower is the fate of the anabolic delusion in miniature. A structure designed for metabolic renewal proved incapable of metabolizing. Having disavowed the gradual degradation that renewal presupposes, it could undergo only total degradation: demolition. Here, in concrete and steel, is the logic this dissertation reads in *Akira*. Systems that refuse catabolism in its ordinary, continuous forms undergo it in its catastrophic form.

The capsule is also, as Chapter 1 observed, the elementary unit of *Akira*'s economy of containment. The Capsules, nomads of the expressway, are *homines moventes* without homes, a parody of Kurokawa's mobile individual in which mobility has become pure circulation without destination. The drug capsules that the gang deals and the laboratory administers are units of pharmacological containment, measured doses of an alteration that the body cannot produce on its own. The cryogenic capsules of the Espers and of Akira are units of *vital* containment, in which life is held in suspension, neither lived nor

ended. Across these registers the capsule promises what the anabolic delusion always promises: growth by the addition of discrete, replaceable units, without the breakdown of anything. What it delivers is suspension, dependence, and, at the last, rupture.

3.3 "Ruins Are the Future": Isozaki, Tange, and the Catabolic Monument

Metabolism had, from the beginning, a catabolic conscience, and its name was Isozaki Arata. He was born in 1931 and came of age among the burned cities of the defeat. Isozaki worked in Tange's laboratory but never subscribed to the Metabolist faith in endless renewal. His photomontage *Incubation Process* (1962) grafts megastructural cores onto the broken columns of a classical ruin, and in the accompanying text he declared, in effect, that the city of the future would itself be a ruin. *Re-ruined Hiroshima* (1968) superimposes a ruined megastructure upon a photograph of the city's atomic devastation, so that the future is shown already in ruins atop a past that has not ceased to be ruined. For Isozaki, the megastructure did not transcend the cycle of construction and destruction; it was one of its phases. *Akira* is, among other things, Isozaki's vision narrativized.

The catabolic monument, however, is older than Isozaki's montages. It is the work of Tange himself. Tange's first great commission, the Hiroshima Peace Memorial Park (designed from 1949 and completed in the mid-1950s), organized its composition along an axis that runs from the museum through the cenotaph to the skeletal ruin of the former Prefectural Industrial Promotion Hall. This is the Atomic Bomb Dome, whose permanent preservation the city resolved upon in 1966. The founding monument of postwar Japanese architecture thus aligned the future with the ruin, installing the remainder of the explosion as the vanishing point of the civic axis. Neo-Tokyo's crater performs the same function. It is the ruin that orients the city, the remainder toward which the new metropolis faces.

Tange's career reads, from this vantage, as the trajectory of the postwar state rendered in concrete:

- the Peace Park (1955), which enshrined the ruin;
- the *Plan for Tokyo* (1960–61), which proposed to leave the old center behind;
- the Yoyogi National Gymnasium (1964), which gave the Olympic rebirth its most celebrated form;
- the master plan and space-frame Big Roof of the Festival Plaza at the Osaka Exposition (1970), which Okamoto Tarō's Tower of the Sun would pierce (Chapter 4);
- the twin-towered Tokyo Metropolitan Government Building in Shinjuku, designed in 1986 and completed in 1991.

The last of these, with its stepped silhouette and cathedral-like mass, looks in retrospect like a set from Neo-Tokyo. Neo-Tokyo, in turn, is a Tange city: the condensation of a career that began by enshrining the ruin of one atomic child and culminated in the seat of the government that, in *Akira*, keeps another in the basement.

3.4 The Stadium over the Sleeper

The Tokyo Olympics of 1964 were the rite of metabolic rebirth *par excellence*. The nation that had been firebombed and occupied re-entered the international order as host, and it rebuilt its capital to do so. The Tōkaidō Shinkansen opened in October 1964. Tange's Yoyogi gymnasium gave the Games their emblem. The Metropolitan Expressway was driven through the city, famously across the Nihonbashi, the bridge from which distances on the national road network had been measured since the Edo period. The bridge was entombed beneath an elevated highway: the symbolic zero-point of the old city buried under the infrastructure of the new. That this expressway is now itself slated for relocation underground, more than half a century later, is a small emblem of catabolic historicity.

Akira places its sleeping weapon precisely here. It lies beneath the construction site of an Olympic stadium, the monument of rebirth rising over the vault that contains its disavowed condition. Chapter 8 will interpret this configuration through the seismic iconography of the Edo catfish prints, in which the earthquake-bringing catfish is pinned beneath the earth by a keystone (*kaname-ishi*). It suffices here to observe that the stadium *is* the keystone. The anabolic monument is literally built upon a buried catabolism. The Olympic Games, rite of the growth state, are staged atop the reserve they presuppose and deny.

History has since supplied an uncanny coda. Tokyo was awarded the 2020 Olympics in 2013. To host them, the National Stadium of 1958, the main stadium of 1964, was demolished. The competition-winning design by Zaha Hadid was cancelled in 2015 amid controversy over its cost and replaced by Kuma Kengo's timber-latticed stadium. In March 2020, with the city's construction complete, the Games were postponed by a pandemic. When they were finally held in the summer of 2021, it was largely without spectators.

The film's stadium-site billboard, counting down to the Games of 2020 and defaced by a graffito demanding their cancellation, circulated globally as a "prophecy." Its prophetic force, however, lies elsewhere than coincidence. What it anticipated was not a date but a structure. The monument of metabolic rebirth was interrupted by a catabolism the growth state could not govern. It arose this time not from beneath the stadium but from within bodies, as a biological breakdown propagating through the circulatory networks the anabolic city had built.

3.5 Scrap and Build: The Catabolic History of Tokyo

The anabolic delusion was not merely an architectural style. It was a governing ideology whose historical origin can be dated with some precision to 1960. In that single year:

- the renewal of the US–Japan Security Treaty provoked the largest mass protests in the nation's postwar history and brought down the Kishi cabinet;
- the Metabolists announced their movement;
- Tange's laboratory prepared its plan for the bay;
- Ikeda Hayato's cabinet adopted the National Income Doubling Plan.

The conjunction is not accidental. The political crisis over the treaty, which is to say over the external custody of the archipelago's capacity for war, was resolved by redirecting national energy toward growth. The strategic compact later named the "Yoshida Doctrine" thereby received its definitive form: minimal armament, reliance upon American security, and the concentration of the nation's collective effort on economic expansion.

In the vocabulary of this dissertation, 1960 fixed a division of metabolic labour. The United States would hold the catabolism, meaning the bases, the fleet, and the bomb. Japan would specialize in anabolism. Tanaka Kakuei's *Plan for Remodelling the Japanese Archipelago* (1972) and the "construction state" (*doken kokka*) it consolidated (McCormack 1996) were the domestic extension of this compact. Growth became not a policy but a mode of legitimacy, and construction became the medium through which the state reproduced itself.

Yet the city on which this ideology was inscribed had always been catabolically driven. Edo's proverb held that fires and quarrels were the flowers of the city (*kaji to kenka wa Edo no hana*). The Great Meireki Fire of 1657 consumed much of the shogunal capital. The Ansei Edo earthquake of 1855 levelled whole districts and, as Chapter 8 will show, provoked an outpouring of popular prints that read the disaster as world-rectification. The Great Kantō earthquake of 1923 destroyed much of Tokyo and Yokohama and gave rise to the grand reconstruction schemes associated with Gotō Shinpei. The incendiary raid of 9–10 March 1945, flown by the US Army Air Forces' XXI Bomber Command under Curtis LeMay against the densely built wooden districts of the low city, killed on the order of a hundred thousand people in a single night.

Edward Seidensticker's two-volume history of the modern city (1983; 1990) is organized, almost involuntarily, around these rhythms of destruction and rebuilding. Jinnai Hidenobu's spatial anthropology (1995 [1985]) demonstrates a complementary truth: the older structures of Edo's topography persist beneath every reconstruction. Catabolism in Tokyo never achieves the remainderless erasure it seems to promise.

The bubble years added a speculative inflection. They saw the practice of *jiage*, the clearing of holdouts from urban land for redevelopment, and a culture of "scrap and build" in which buildings barely a generation old were demolished for their sites. The general economy of the bubble made demolition itself a mode of accumulation. This is the terrain Lamarre's reading rightly identifies as a capitalist mode of destruction. What I add is the claim that this mode was *disavowed* by the very ideology it sustained. The anabolic delusion could not acknowledge that growth ran on destruction, and so it could not integrate destruction into its self-understanding except as accident, catastrophe, or the fault of others.

Barthes's celebrated reading of Tokyo (1982 [1970]) supplies the missing term. The city, he observed, possesses a center, but that center is empty: the Imperial Palace, walled, wooded, and forbidden, around which the whole city turns while its traffic avoids it. The bubble years added an economic gloss: a much-repeated calculation held that the land of the palace grounds was worth more than all the real estate of California. The hollow center was thus also the point of maximal speculative value, a void in which the city's accumulated worth was condensed without being usable. *Akira* relocates this void. The empty center of Neo-Tokyo is not the palace but the vault, and its value is not speculative but explosive. Chapter 7 will develop the homology in full.

One further text belongs to this genealogy, and it is the oldest. Kamo no Chōmei's *Hōjōki* (1212) records the catastrophes of the late-twelfth-century capital:

- the great fire of 1177;
- the whirlwind of 1180;
- the abrupt transfer of the capital to Fukuhara in the same year;
- the famine of 1181–82;
- the earthquake of 1185.

From them Chōmei draws the lesson of impermanence that his celebrated opening already announces. His response to the catabolic city was to withdraw into a hut ten feet square, which could be dismantled and carried away on a pair of carts. It was the first capsule of Japanese letters: a minimal, mobile dwelling built by one who had learned that the city is a rhythm of accumulation and ruin. The Conclusion will return to Chōmei's hut when it reads Kaneda's motorcycle as its modern descendant.

3.6 Velocity, Circulation, and the Ballistic Eye

Fredric Jameson's call for a "cognitive mapping" of the postmodern city (1991) responded to the disorientation of individuals within spatial totalities too vast and complex to represent. Neo-Tokyo is among the most influential answers in popular culture to that

demand. So, differently, are the Los Angeles of Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982), set in the same year as Ōtomo's film, 2019, and the Chiba City of William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984).

Scott's city is vertical and stagnant, a mire of rain and advertising beneath the pyramids of corporate power. Gibson's is a network, legible only as data. Ōtomo's is *circulatory*. It is legible at speed, from the saddle of a motorcycle on an elevated expressway, and it discloses itself as a system of arteries through which bodies, vehicles, and energy flow.

Thomas Lamarre's distinction between *cinematism* and *animetism* (2009) clarifies the stakes. Cinematism, in Lamarre's account, drives movement into depth along a projectile trajectory. It is a way of seeing that Lamarre, following Virilio's analysis of the co-evolution of cinema and weaponry (Virilio 1989 [1984]), associates with the ballistic gaze. Animetism instead lets movement play across and between layered planes. *Akira* (F) is an apex of cinematism in Japanese animation: a film of plunging perspectives, tracking shots along expressways, and headlong velocity into depth. Its signature image is the smeared red trace of Kaneda's tail-light, rendered as if by a long photographic exposure, a visible residue of speed. That trace is velocity's own detritus, the index of a motion that has already passed.

This is the dromological city that Virilio's *Speed and Politics* (1986 [1977]) theorized, a polity in which power is exercised as the control of velocity. Tange's linear axis was a design for circulation. The expressways were its realization, and the state's helicopters and orbital laser are its vertical supplement: the ballistic eye above the circulatory city. The *bōsōzoku* parasitize this system. They convert the state's arteries into the medium of play, and they smooth, in Deleuze and Guattari's terms, a space the state has striated (1987 [1980]). They are a nomadic war machine running on the infrastructure of the State apparatus, and this is why the state can neither ignore them nor fully suppress them.

The manga follows this logic to its catabolic conclusion. After the second destruction, Neo-Tokyo becomes a city without circulation: flooded, its expressways severed, its population scattered among the ruins. The new order that arises there is organized around a stationary center rather than a network of flows. Tetsuo's Great Tokyo Empire convenes in the Olympic stadium, and Akira is enthroned at its center. The city passes from the vector to the throne, from circulation to cult. The anabolic city of flows, catabolized, reorganizes itself around its hollow center. When circulation returns at the end, in the final ride of Kaneda and Kei, it will return in a different mode. That return is the subject of the Conclusion.

3.7 Conclusion: The Anabolic Delusion

Neo-Tokyo is the anabolic delusion made concrete. It is a city of growth, raised by a state that has abandoned the old center, standing beside the ruin it pretends to have transcended. It is organized by a sovereign that has stored its catabolism in a child beneath the Olympic works. Its rhythm is scrap and build, its time is cryogenic, and its center is hollow.

The Metabolist city disavows degradation. Degradation therefore returns as catastrophe, as it returned to the Nakagin tower in the form of total demolition, and as it returned to the Olympiad of 2020 in the form of a pandemic. What Metabolism excluded from its biology, the breakdown of structure and the release of energy, does not disappear. It is stored.

Part Two follows the stored energy to where *Akira* locates it: in bodies. It first traces the energy's economy and genealogy, through Bataille, Okamoto Tarō, and the sun.



PART TWO

Economies

04 Sun and Steel
05 The Numbered Children
06 Flesh without Measure

> Le soleil donne sans jamais recevoir.
> *The sun gives without ever receiving.*
> — GEORGES BATAILLE, *La Part maudite* (1949)

> 芸術は爆発だ。
> *Art is explosion.*
> — OKAMOTO TARŌ

04

CHAPTER FOUR

Sun and Steel

Bataille, Okamoto Tarō, and the General Economy of Catastrophe

4.1 The Accursed Share

The theoretical armature of this dissertation derives from a line of thought inaugurated not by a philosopher but by an ethnologist. Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1990 [1925]) drew on the ethnographies of the Pacific Northwest and Melanesia to reconstruct a system of "total prestations." In that system goods circulate not as commodities but as gifts that obligate: to give, to receive, and to reciprocate. Its most spectacular institution was the potlatch of the Kwakiutl and their neighbours, as documented by Franz Boas, which drove the logic of the gift to its agonistic limit. Chiefs competed for rank by giving away accumulated wealth and, at the extreme, by destroying it. Blankets were burned; coppers were broken or cast into the sea; prestige accrued to whoever could annihilate the most. The potlatch disclosed that exchange is not the primary form of economic life. Beneath it lies a more archaic relation in which power is constituted through loss.

Georges Bataille generalized Mauss's discovery into an ontology. "The Notion of Expenditure" (1985 [1933]) distinguished two kinds of consumption. Productive consumption uses resources to reproduce life and the means of production. *Unproductive expenditure* includes luxury, mourning, war, cults, monuments, games, spectacles, the arts, and non-reproductive sexuality. Bataille argued that unproductive expenditure is not a deviation from economic rationality but its concealed end, so that a society is to be understood by how it squanders.

La Part maudite (1988 [1949]) grounded this claim in a cosmology. On the surface of the earth, living matter receives from the sun more energy than it needs to maintain itself; the sun, paradigm of the gift, gives without receiving. Growth can absorb the surplus for a time, through the extension of the organism, the multiplication of

individuals, and the accumulation of productive forces. But growth meets limits. The surplus it can no longer absorb must then be spent, gloriously in festival, sacrifice, and art, or catastrophically in war.

Bataille called the economics of the political economists the "restricted economy." It is calculated from the standpoint of scarcity and so perceives only the phase of accumulation. The "general economy" perceives the entire cycle. It recognizes that the question which ultimately confronts every living system is not how to acquire but how to squander.

Bataille's historical examples are Aztec sacrifice, the military expansion of early Islam, the monastic economy of Tibet, and the Reformation's sanctification of accumulation. They culminate in a reading of the twentieth century that bears directly on *Akira*. Industrial capitalism had converted its surplus into productive forces with unprecedented rigour. It then found itself with an excess that neither consumption nor further growth could absorb. In Bataille's analysis, the world wars were the discharge of that excess: the catastrophic expenditure of a civilization that had refused glorious expenditure.

Bataille wrote his closing chapters in the shadow of the atomic bomb. There he looked to the Marshall Plan as a possible alternative: a gift of the American surplus on a planetary scale, which might forestall a third war by doing deliberately what war does blindly. The alternative Bataille posed, *give it away or it will explode*, is the alternative *Akira* dramatizes.

The anabolic delusion diagnosed in Chapter 3 is nothing other than the restricted economy elevated to a principle of state legitimacy. The high-growth state reinvested its surplus in further growth more thoroughly than any other capitalist society. It classified expenditure as waste and destruction as accident. The one form of surplus it could not reinvest, its capacity for annihilation, it stored in reserve, under foreign custody and beyond the reach of politics. Bataille's general economy predicts the consequence. A society that refuses glorious expenditure will undergo catastrophic expenditure, and a surplus that is not given will explode.

4.2 Art Is Explosion: Okamoto Tarō and the Underground Sun

The line from Mauss through Bataille does not reach *Akira* only through theory. It also passes through Japanese art history, in the person of Okamoto Tarō (1911–1996).

Okamoto lived in Paris from 1930 to 1940. He attended Mauss's lectures in ethnology and moved in Bataille's circle; by his own account he participated in the anti-fascist group Contre-Attaque and in the secret society Acéphale. He returned to Japan in 1940, was conscripted and sent to the China front, and was repatriated after internment. After the war he became the most visible and most provocative figure of the Japanese avant-garde.

His doctrine of "polarism" (*taikyokushugi*) held that art arises from the collision of irreconcilable opposites without synthesis. His essay on Jōmon pottery (1952) overturned the national canon. It exalted the flamboyant, turbulent vessels of Japan's prehistoric hunter-gatherers over the refined restraint of the agrarian Yayoi tradition that official taste had enshrined. His manifesto *Konnichi no geijutsu* (Today's Art, 1954) declared that art must be neither skilful, nor beautiful, nor pleasant.

The phrase with which his name became synonymous for a mass audience, "Art is explosion!" (*Geijutsu wa bakuhatsu da*), was popularized by a television advertisement in the early 1980s. It gave the Bataillean principle of expenditure its most compressed Japanese formulation.

Okamoto took care to specify what he meant. In *Jibun no naka ni doku o mote* (Keep Poison within Yourself, 1988), he wrote that the explosion he intended was not the destructive blast of a bomb. It was a silent and total opening of the whole being toward the cosmos, an unconditional release of life into the universe. The distinction is exact and indispensable for this dissertation. Okamoto discriminates between two modes of catabolism. Both release accumulated energy, but the bomb annihilates form, while the explosion dissolves the boundaries of form into cosmic participation.

Akira's two spheres enact this distinction precisely. The first sphere, which obliterates Tokyo, is the bomb. The last, into which Tetsuo is drawn and from which a universe issues, is Okamoto's explosion: silent, luminous, and cosmogonic. That Okamoto's gloss was published in the same year as Ōtomo's film is a coincidence; that both articulate the same distinction is not.

The decisive monument of this lineage is the Tower of the Sun (*Taiyō no tō*), which Okamoto erected at the Osaka Exposition of 1970. The Exposition's official theme was "Progress and Harmony for Mankind." Tange Kenzō's master plan centred on the Festival Plaza beneath a vast space-frame roof. This Big Roof was the purest built statement of the Metabolist faith in networked, modular, infinitely extensible structure.

Okamoto was appointed producer of the theme pavilion, and he openly repudiated the theme. Humanity, he insisted, had not progressed at all, and harmony was mere compromise. His tower, some seventy metres high, broke through the Big Roof, rising through an aperture cut in Tange's space frame. It bore three faces: a Golden Mask at its summit representing the future, the Face of the Sun on its front representing the present, and the Black Sun on its back representing the past. Within it rose the Tree of Life (*Seimei no ki*), a sculptural column of organisms ascending from unicellular life to humanity.

Beneath it, in the pavilion's underground exhibition, Okamoto installed a fourth face, the Sun of the Underground World (*Chitei no taiyō*). Around it he placed masks and ritual objects that an ethnological mission had gathered from across the world. That collection

would later pass into the founding holdings of the National Museum of Ethnology in Osaka. Mauss's archive of the gift was thus installed in the basement of the exposition of progress.

The configuration is not only symbolic. Sawaragi Noi's *Sensō to banpaku* (War and Expo, 2005) argues that the Osaka Exposition was structurally continuous with the wartime mobilization of the nation's technical and aesthetic elites. It was, on this reading, the total war of the 1940s redirected into a pageant of peaceful growth. If Sawaragi is right, the Festival Plaza was the stage on which the anabolic delusion rehearsed its disavowal of its own martial genealogy. Okamoto's tower, the lone dissenting totem, pierced the stage from below.

Within a decade the Big Roof was dismantled; the Tower of the Sun remains. More striking is the fate of the fourth face. The Sun of the Underground World disappeared after the Exposition closed, and its whereabouts remain unknown; a reconstruction was installed only in 2018.

Here is the architectural parable that *Akira* narrativizes. At the site where postwar Japan staged its faith in progress, the anabolic structure of the Metabolist state was pierced by a Bataillean totem of the sun, and beneath both lay a buried sun that was then lost. Neo-Tokyo reconstitutes this configuration exactly. It is a Metabolist city whose monument of renewal, the Olympic stadium, rises over a sealed vault in which an underground sun sleeps. Akira *is* the Sun of the Underground World: lost, sealed, forgotten, and awaiting its return.

The Black Sun on the tower's reverse also deserves a word. It faces backward, toward the past, and it is the sun of melancholia. It recalls Nerval's *soleil noir*, which Julia Kristeva would make the emblem of a loss that cannot be mourned (1989 [1987]). A society that turns its Black Sun to the rear while its Golden Mask gazes forward has arranged its monuments so as not to look at what it has lost. Akira's vault is the place where that unlooked-at past is stored.

Okamoto's lineage has one further monument that bears on *Akira*. *Asu no shinwa* (The Myth of Tomorrow, 1968–69) is a mural some thirty metres long, painted for a hotel in Mexico City. It depicts the instant of a nuclear detonation, with a skeleton blazing at its centre and the irradiated fishing boat of 1954 at its margin. The mural was lost for decades after the hotel project collapsed and was rediscovered in 2003. After restoration it was installed in 2008 in a concourse of Shibuya Station. In 2011 it acquired an unauthorized supplement when the art collective Chim↑Pom affixed a small panel depicting the stricken reactors of Fukushima Daiichi.

The mural's title is its thesis: the bomb is not the trauma of yesterday but the myth of tomorrow. This is also *Akira*'s thesis, and the thesis of this dissertation. The explosion is not remembered; it is awaited.

4.3 SOL: The Weaponized Sun

Against this solar genealogy, one of *Akira*'s apparatuses takes on a significance that has escaped comment. The state's ultimate weapon against Tetsuo is an orbital laser satellite named SOL: the sun.

The name condenses the whole general-economic problematic. Bataille's sun gives without receiving; it is the source of the surplus, the principle of gratuitous expenditure, the cosmic potlatch from which all terrestrial luxury derives. SOL is the sun appropriated by the restricted economy. Solar energy is captured, concentrated, and aimed, and the gift is converted into a targeted instrument of the security state. Okamoto's tower pierced the Metabolist roof from below with the archaic sun. SOL is the Metabolist state's answer from above: the sun installed in orbit as a component of the ballistic eye described in Chapter 3.

The history of the Olympic stadium supplies a real antecedent for this figure. The Olympic flame is kindled at Olympia by concentrating the rays of the sun in a parabolic mirror, which is the same technical gesture as SOL's. At the opening ceremony of the 1964 Tokyo Games, the runner who carried that flame into the National Stadium and lit the cauldron was Sakai Yoshinori. He was a nineteen-year-old university athlete born in Hiroshima Prefecture on 6 August 1945, the day of the bombing, and sections of the foreign press called him "Atomic Boy."

The ritual is extraordinary once seen through *Akira*. It brought the sun, focused in a mirror and passed from hand to hand across the world, into the stadium of metabolic rebirth, carried by a child of the bomb. The Olympiad of 1964 staged the reconciliation of the atomic child with the sun: the survivor-generation bearing the solar gift into the monument of peaceful growth. *Akira* stages the same elements in their unreconciled form. The atomic child sleeps beneath the stadium, and the concentrated sun strikes from orbit. The stadium, which in 1964 was the place of reconciliation, becomes in Neo-Tokyo the place where the sun and the atomic child meet as weapon and target.

The encounter between SOL and Tetsuo is therefore an encounter between two appropriations of the accursed share. The state has captured the sun and fashioned it into a beam; Tetsuo has captured the surplus stored in the children and fashioned it into his own body. When the beam strikes, it severs Tetsuo's arm. He replaces the arm with a prosthesis fashioned from metallic wreckage and, in the film, rises into orbit to tear the satellite apart. The wound and its repair are the hinge of his metamorphosis. It is the prosthetic arm, grafted of debris, that later begins to swell with flesh and becomes the origin of the proliferating mass. The limb severed by the sun is replaced by a limb of iron, and the limb of iron becomes the seed of the cancer.

A philological fact sharpens the significance of this sequence. Tetsuo's name is written 鉄雄: *tetsu*, iron or steel, and *o*, male or hero. The most celebrated Japanese meditation on the body as the site of truth, Mishima Yukio's *Taiyō to tetsu* (1968), translated as *Sun*

and Steel, bears the same character in its title: *taiyō*, the sun, and *tetsu*, iron. In the wound SOL inflicts upon Tetsuo, the two terms of Mishima's title meet in open war.

4.4 *Taiyō to Tetsu*: Mishima's Metaphysics of the Body

Sun and Steel, serialized from 1965 and published in 1968 (Mishima 1970 [1968]), is Mishima's autobiographical account of how a man for whom words had come first belatedly acquired a body. Words, Mishima argues, corrode reality, eating it away as termites eat wood, and the verbal self is a self without substance. In his account, it was the sun that first revealed the body to him. Steel, meaning the iron of the weights with which he began bodybuilding in 1955, then gave that body *form*: the classical contour of muscle that makes flesh legible as a work of art.

Mishima's metaphysics culminates in the conviction that the body so formed finds its fulfilment only in a death in which action and word, flesh and meaning, coincide. This is the beautiful death of the warrior, in which the body completed by steel is consumed in a single act. The book closes with an epilogue recounting his flight in an F-104 fighter of the Air Self-Defense Force in December 1967. At the edge of the atmosphere, he saw a vast white serpent of cloud encircling the earth and biting its own tail. After the epilogue comes a poem addressed to Icarus.

Three years later, on 25 November 1970, Mishima and members of his private militia, the Tatenokai, took the commandant of the Ground Self-Defense Force's Eastern Army, General Mashita Kanetoshi, hostage at Ichigaya. They tied him to a chair and wounded with swords several officers who tried to free him. From a balcony, Mishima exhorted the assembled soldiers to rise against the postwar constitution that had, in his view, emasculated the nation and reduced the emperor to a symbol. The soldiers jeered. Mishima withdrew and died by seppuku, and the Tatenokai's student leader, Morita Masakatsu, died the same way beside him.

Among its other meanings, the failed coup is the most spectacular act of unproductive expenditure in postwar Japanese history: a potlatch of the self, performed before an audience that refused to receive it. It was not a potlatch of the self alone: it cost a second life, Morita's, and it was paid for in part by officers wounded without having consented to anything, which is exactly what the aesthetics of the beautiful death leaves out of its accounts (Chapter 8). Mishima was himself a sympathetic reader of Bataille's writings on eroticism and death. He understood the act in terms that the general economy can name: the sovereign moment, subordinated to no end, in which the accumulated self is spent.

Akira inherits Mishima's terms and inverts their valuation. For Tetsuo, too, the body arrives late, as the consequence of an accident rather than a discipline. His power, too, is inseparable from the fantasy of a nation restored to hardness. His trajectory, too, passes through the sun and through steel toward self-consumption.

But where Mishima's steel produces form, Tetsuo's produces formlessness. The iron grafted to his flesh does not sculpt contour; it dissolves it. The body completed by steel becomes a body that can never be completed at all. Mishima sought to make of the body a statue that could die beautifully. Tetsuo's body becomes an anti-statue that cannot die, only proliferate.

The two coups also differ in outcome. Mishima's failed because the soldiers would not follow. Tetsuo's Great Tokyo Empire succeeds because the crowds do follow. The difference measures the distance between the ideological landscape of 1970 and that of the late 1980s. By then the fantasy of hardness had passed from the heroic register of the right-wing aesthete into the popular register of the mass.

Chapter 6 follows this inversion into the flesh itself. It suffices here to observe that *Akira* reads Mishima through Bataille and against Mishima. The sun, which Mishima believed would give the body form, is in the general economy the principle that dissolves all form in expenditure.

4.5 Catabolic Sovereignty: Schmitt through Bataille

We are now in a position to formulate the central concept of this dissertation more precisely.

Carl Schmitt's *Politische Theologie* opens with the definition that has governed twentieth-century reflection on the concept: "Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet," sovereign is he who decides on the exception (Schmitt 2005 [1922]). For Schmitt, sovereignty is revealed not in the ordinary operation of law but in the decision that suspends it. The sovereign stands outside the legal order in order to found and preserve it, and his authority is concentrated in a single, personal, unconditioned act of will.

Bataille's late, unfinished treatise *La Souveraineté* (composed in the 1950s and published posthumously in 1976) proposes an antithetical concept under the same name (Bataille 1991 [1976]). Bataillean sovereignty is not a power over others but a mode of being. It is the moment subordinated to no end, the instant of pure expenditure (laughter, tears, ecstasy, sacrifice, eroticism) in which life ceases to be the means of anything and is simply spent. Its paradigm is not the ruler but the one who consumes without producing. Bataille concluded, in a formula he printed in capitals, that its essence is nothing. The sovereign moment is the moment in which anticipation dissolves, and what it yields cannot be possessed.

The nuclear age brings these two antithetical concepts into an unprecedented and unstable conjunction. The sovereign state of the Cold War does not merely decide on the exception. It holds in reserve a capacity for absolute expenditure, the power to annihilate not an enemy but the world, and its authority rests on the credible possibility of spending it.

Deterrence is the potlatch that is never held but always threatened. It is an accumulation of catabolic capacity whose value lies entirely in its non-use, and whose use would abolish the value of everything. Herman Kahn's *On Thermonuclear War* (1960) formalized this logic in the thought-experiment of the "Doomsday Machine," a device that would automatically destroy the world if its owner were attacked. Kubrick's *Dr. Strangelove* (1964) exposed the absurdity of the device with the joke that a doomsday machine deters only if its existence is known.

In such a system the reserve is more sovereign than the sovereign. The decision that Schmitt located in a person has migrated into an apparatus, and the apparatus can be triggered without anyone deciding at all.

This is the configuration I call *catabolic sovereignty*: a form of power constituted by the custody of stored annihilation. At the moment of release, the political sovereign is revealed to have been only the custodian of a sovereignty that belonged to the reserve itself.

Akira stages this revelation with exemplary clarity. The Colonel keeps custody of the vault, and his coup and martial law are Schmittian decisions on the exception of the classic type. But the release of the reserve is decided by no one. Akira does not decide, for he is a child who does not speak. Tetsuo does not decide, for he is driven. In the manga, the second destruction of Neo-Tokyo is triggered by a stray bullet. At the moment of catastrophe, Schmitt's sovereign is exposed as an archon without an *arkhē*, the keeper of a power that acts without him when it acts. The true sovereign in *Akira* is Bataille's: the nothing at the center, the expenditure that serves no end.

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1996 [1921]), written a year before Schmitt's treatise, supplies a third term. Benjamin distinguished *mythic* violence, which founds and preserves law, from *divine* violence, which destroys law without founding any. Mythic violence is bloody and bounded. Divine violence, in Benjamin's striking formulation, is "auf unblutige Weise letal," lethal in a bloodless way. His exemplary instance is the biblical judgment in which the earth opens and swallows the company of Korah.

The three figures of *Akira* distribute themselves across Benjamin's typology with uncanny exactness. The Colonel's martial law is law-preserving violence. Tetsuo's Great Tokyo Empire is law-founding violence, and it is bloody to the last, for his violence is always the violence of torn flesh. Akira's violence is neither. It founds nothing and preserves nothing. As Chapter 2 observed, it is rendered as pure whiteness, a luminous annihilation in which no blood is shown. And it comes, like the judgment on Korah, from beneath.

Whether this is divine violence in Benjamin's sense, whether it bears any relation to justice, is a question the work refuses to settle; Chapter 10 takes it up. What is clear is that Akira's violence belongs to a different order from the state's, and that the state's custody of it was always a custody of the incommensurable.

4.6 The Bubble as Potlatch

The general economy of *Akira* is historical as well as thematic. The film was produced, and the manga's second half composed, during the asset-price bubble that followed the Plaza Accord of 1985. The appreciation of the yen and the loosening of credit drove land and share prices to heights that bore no relation to any productive use.

The bubble's culture of consumption has become proverbial. Flakes of gold leaf were scattered on food and drink. Golf-club memberships were traded as speculative assets. In 1987 the Yasuda Fire and Marine Insurance Company bought one of van Gogh's *Sunflowers* for a then-record sum. In 1990 the paper magnate Saitō Ryōei acquired van Gogh's *Portrait of Dr. Gachet* and Renoir's *Bal du moulin de la Galette* for a combined sum exceeding one hundred and sixty million dollars. The following year he remarked that he would like the paintings cremated with him, which provoked international outrage before he explained the remark away.

Saitō's remark is the bubble's involuntary confession. It is the agonistic potlatch in its purest form, delivered in the idiom of a collector's quip: the wish to destroy the most valuable objects in the world as the supreme demonstration of rank. That one of the era's iconic purchases was a painting of sunflowers merely completes the allegory.

The bubble was a potlatch that did not know itself as such. It experienced itself as accumulation, as the rational pricing of assets in an economy that could only grow. In fact it was an orgy of unproductive expenditure, whose nature was revealed only when prices collapsed and the wealth evaporated. The anabolic delusion reached its apogee at the moment when its catabolic truth was about to become visible.

Akira was composed at that apogee. Its film, a production whose extravagance of labour and colour the industry has rarely matched, is itself a document of the bubble's glorious expenditure. Within the narrative, Tetsuo is the bubble's allegorical figure. His power is the accursed share of the city concentrated in a single body that can use it for nothing.

Every act Tetsuo performs is expenditure: the killing of Yamagata in the gang's own bar, the obliteration of the army's tanks, the annihilation of the satellite, the laying waste of whole districts. In Mauss's terms his violence is an agonistic potlatch, and it has the potlatch's characteristic effect: it confers rank. Tetsuo becomes sovereign of the Great Tokyo Empire not by persuasion, succession, or election, but by demonstrating that he can destroy more than anyone else.

Yet his potlatch lacks the potlatch's essential structure, for there is no rival to receive it and no recipient to be obligated. It is a gift given to no one, and a gift given to no one is indistinguishable from pure destruction. His consumption of the drugs that feed his power completes the figure. These are the capsules that recur throughout the work as the unit of the dose. Tetsuo is the consumer par excellence, the body in which the surplus is burned without return.

4.7 Conclusion: The Sun beneath the Stadium

This chapter has reconstructed the general economy that underwrites *Akira*. From Mauss's potlatch to Bataille's solar economy, the line of thought that treats expenditure rather than production as the truth of economic life passes, in Japan, through two figures who translated it into art and action.

One is Okamoto Tarō. His "explosion" was a cosmic opening, and his tower pierced the Metabolist roof above a lost underground sun. The other is Mishima Yukio, whose sun and steel promised the body a form that death would consummate.

Akira stages the confrontation of these two Bataillean lineages with the anabolic state. The state appropriates the sun as a weapon. Tetsuo appropriates the children's surplus as a body. Akira, the underground sun, releases what neither can hold.

The concept of catabolic sovereignty names the structure disclosed in that release. It is a sovereignty that consists in the custody of stored annihilation and that is exposed, when the reserve is spent, as custody without command.

The accursed share must be stored somewhere before it is spent. *Akira*'s answer to the question of where gives the work its peculiar ethical gravity: in children. To those children, and to the apparatus that numbers them, the next chapter turns.

05

CHAPTER FIVE

The Numbered Children

Biopower, Bare Life, and the Esper as Standing-Reserve

5.1 The Numeral in Place of the Name

The children of the secret programme bear names (Takashi, Kiyoko, Masaru, Akira), but the state knows them by numbers: 26, 25, 27, 28. In the manga, Lady Miyako, the aged prophetess whose sect worships Akira, is revealed as a survivor of an earlier generation of the programme, designated No. 19.

The substitution of numeral for name is the inaugural act of the apparatus this chapter examines. It converts the child into a unit in a series, a case in a file, a specimen in a collection. It inscribes the body into an order in which it is interchangeable with others of its kind and in which its value is determined by its yield.

The twentieth century taught the meaning of such numbering with terrible pedagogical force, and the Japanese state has its own chapter in that curriculum. Unit 731 was the Imperial Army's biological-warfare research unit at Pingfang, outside Harbin in occupied Manchuria, built and commanded by the army surgeon Ishii Shirō, with his deputy Kitano Masaji in command from 1942 to 1945. Its personnel deliberately infected prisoners, most of them Chinese civilians and prisoners of war, with plague, anthrax, cholera, and other pathogens; dissected some of them alive; and used them in frostbite and weapons trials. They called their subjects *maruta*, "logs." Estimates of the dead at Pingfang alone begin at about three thousand, and no prisoner is known to have survived: those still held in August 1945 were killed when the unit destroyed its facilities ahead of the Soviet advance. With its sister formation Unit 1644, it also waged biological war in the field, dropping plague-infected fleas on Chinese cities, including Ningbo in 1940 and Changde in 1941 (Harris 1994). After the defeat, the American occupation authorities granted Ishii and his senior staff immunity from prosecution in exchange for their data, which went to the US Army's biological-warfare laboratories at Camp Detrick;

only a Soviet tribunal, at Khabarovsk in 1949, tried members of the unit. A number of its veterans went on to distinguished postwar careers in medicine, the universities, and the pharmaceutical industry.

Among them was Naitō Ryōichi, an army medical officer in Ishii's network, who in 1950 founded the Japan Blood Bank, renamed the Green Cross Corporation in 1964; Kitano Masaji later became one of its directors. In the first half of the 1980s, Green Cross was among the companies that supplied Japanese patients with clotting-factor concentrates made from unheated, largely American plasma, which infected 1,431 people with HIV, most of them haemophiliacs and many of them children. Green Cross began selling heat-treated products in January 1986 but did not recall its unheated stock, which was withdrawn only in December of that year. The resulting lawsuits were filed in 1989, as *Akira*'s serialization entered its final phase (Feldman 2000). In 1996 the health minister, Kan Naoto, admitted the ministry's responsibility after files it had said did not exist were found inside it. In 2000 the Osaka District Court convicted three former presidents of Green Cross, Matsushita Renzō (previously a senior official of the same ministry), Suyama Tadakazu, and Kawano Takehiko, of professional negligence resulting in death. In 2001 the Tokyo District Court convicted Matsumura Akihito, who had headed the ministry's biologics division, of the same offence, a verdict the Supreme Court upheld in 2008. By 2001, 536 of the 1,431 had died.

The growth economy has its own archive of instrumentalized children. At Minamata, the Chisso Corporation's chemical plant discharged methylmercury into the bay. The poison passed through the food chain into the bodies of pregnant women and across the placenta into their foetuses. Children were born with congenital Minamata disease to mothers who showed milder symptoms or none (George 2001). Chisso knew. In 1959 the director of its own factory hospital, Hosokawa Hajime, produced the disease in a cat fed the plant's effluent; the company kept the result to itself and went on discharging mercury until it ended the responsible production process in 1968, the year the national government at last recognized the cause. In 2004 the Supreme Court held the national and Kumamoto prefectural governments liable for having failed to stop the discharge once its source was known.

The cruelty of the mechanism is exact. The unborn child absorbed the poison and thereby became the storage medium of an industrial surplus that the growth economy could neither use nor contain. W. Eugene Smith's photograph of Uemura Tomoko being bathed by her mother (1971) made this storage visible to the world. Its withdrawal from circulation at the family's request, a quarter-century later, stands as one of the rare instances in which the archive of instrumentalized childhood has been closed by those it consumed.

I do not suggest that Ōtomo alludes to any of these histories. I suggest that *Akira*'s laboratory condenses a structure they document. A society's disavowed surplus, whether toxic, pathogenic, or explosive, is stored in the bodies of children whom the state or the

corporation has numbered. Their suffering is sequestered from public knowledge by secrecy, immunity, or indifference. This is the literal referent of the concept I have called the *accursed child*, and it is not a metaphor.

5.2 Biopower and the Laboratory

Michel Foucault's genealogy of modern power supplies the first frame. Classical sovereignty, in Foucault's account, was the right to take life or let live. Modern biopower is the power to foster life or disallow it to the point of death. It invests life at every level, disciplining individual bodies through institutions (school, barracks, hospital, prison) and regulating populations through the statistical management of birth, health, and mortality (Foucault 1977 [1975]; 1978 [1976]).

Akira's laboratory is a biopolitical institution in the strictest sense. Its children are examined, measured, medicated, and observed. Their files record their readings, and their lives are sustained by drugs and machines. Their bodies bear the marks of the regimen in the premature ageing that makes them senescent children.

The film renders the disciplinary character of this institution in its most unsettling set-piece. The Espers live in a nursery furnished with outsized toys and observed through glass by the programme's scientists. When the children turn their powers against Tetsuo, confined in the adjacent hospital, the assault takes the form of the nursery itself. Gigantic toys (a teddy bear, a rabbit, a toy car) advance upon him, and a flood of milk pours through the ward. The objects of infancy become weapons. The regime of childhood that the institution has imposed on its subjects, as the condition of their management, is turned into an arsenal of terror.

Donald Winnicott's account of the transitional object (1953) sharpens the point. For Winnicott, the child's first possession, the blanket or the bear, occupies an intermediate "potential space" between inner and outer reality in which play, and later culture, become possible. The Espers' toys are transitional objects whose potential space has been annexed by the laboratory. They are no longer the medium of play but the medium of the weapon. The nursery scene is the biopolitical institution's return of the repressed: the childhood the laboratory has administered comes back as nightmare.

Foucault's own reflection on the limits of biopower converges on *Akira* with remarkable precision. In the final lecture of his 1975–76 course at the Collège de France, he observed that biopower reaches a paradox, an excess, when it becomes technologically possible not merely to manage life but to make it proliferate. At that point power can fabricate living matter, build the monster, and ultimately build viruses that cannot be controlled and are universally destructive. Atomic power, he argued, is the point at which the sovereign right to kill and the biopolitical power to make live become paradoxically fused. The power that fosters life is now the power to abolish it (Foucault 2003 [1997]).

The monster and the uncontrollable virus: Foucault's list reads like a synopsis of Tetsuo and of the pandemic that deferred the Olympiad of 2020. The Esper programme is biopower at its point of excess, a power that fosters life in order to store within it the capacity to abolish life.

5.3 *Homo Sacer*: The Children Who May Be Killed

Giorgio Agamben's revision of Foucault supplies the second frame. The originary structure of sovereignty, Agamben argues, is the production of *bare life*: life included in the political order only through its exclusion. Its emblem is the archaic Roman figure of *homo sacer*, the man who may be killed with impunity but not sacrificed. The sovereign exception produces bare life, and the camp, the space in which the exception becomes the rule, is for Agamben the concealed paradigm of modern political space (Agamben 1998 [1995]).

The Espers are bare life in this precise sense. The programme that holds them exists outside any public legal order, and the children have no rights, no guardians, and no standing. The state reserves the right to kill them, or those like them, when their powers threaten the reserve. The Colonel is prepared to have Tetsuo killed before his power matures. In the manga, an Esper is killed in a skirmish between armed factions contending for possession of Akira. The Espers exist in exactly the zone of indistinction Agamben describes: neither citizens nor criminals, neither patients nor prisoners, they are bodies held in the exception.

Yet the Espers also invert the formula of *homo sacer*. They may be killed, but they are also sacred in the most literal sense. The film's street prophets and the manga's sect of Lady Miyako worship Akira as a messiah, so that the children are objects of cult as well as instruments of state. *Akira* thereby fuses the two poles that Agamben's analysis holds apart: bare life that may be killed and sacred life that is venerated coincide in the same bodies. The fusion is the signature of catabolic sovereignty. The reserve must be both expendable and untouchable: killable as individuals, inviolable as a store.

The manga dramatizes the consequence of this fusion with terrible economy. Takashi is the child whose collision with Tetsuo began the story. He is killed by a stray bullet from one of Nezu's men during the struggle over Akira, and his death triggers the second annihilation of Neo-Tokyo.

The killing of bare life releases the sovereign reserve. The sovereign's power to kill the child without consequence is precisely what brings the consequence. The ban turns back upon the one who pronounced it, and the city that stored its end in children is ended by the death of a child.

No passage in the work states the ethical logic of catabolic sovereignty more concisely. A power that keeps its catastrophe in killable bodies has made its own survival hostage to the life it treats as expendable.

5.4 The Esper as Standing-Reserve

Heidegger's analysis of modern technology supplies the third frame and the most exact. In "The Question Concerning Technology" (1977 [1954]), Heidegger characterized the essence of modern technology as *Gestell*, enframing. Enframing is a mode of revealing that challenges nature to supply energy that can be extracted, stored, and distributed, so that everything that is appears as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, on call for further ordering. The river becomes a supplier of hydraulic pressure; the land becomes a mining district. Uranium, Heidegger observed, is challenged to yield atomic energy, which can be released for destruction or for peaceful use. The supreme danger of enframing is that the human being, too, comes to appear as standing-reserve, as a resource among resources.

The Espers are standing-reserve in its purest form: human beings challenged forth to yield an energy that is extracted, stored, and held on call. The cryogenic vault is the perfect *Bestand*, a store of energy maintained at low temperature against the day of its ordering. If uranium is the matter that modern technology challenges to yield annihilation, Akira is the uranium of the psyche.

Heidegger's analysis carries its own compromising history. The Bremen lectures of 1949, in which he first set out the analysis of enframing, contained a notorious passage equating mechanized agriculture with the gas chambers and the manufacture of hydrogen bombs, and the political entanglements of his thought have been exhaustively documented. Nevertheless, its descriptive precision with respect to the Esper programme is unmatched. Its failure to discriminate among forms of enframing is precisely what *Akira*'s ethical specificity corrects. The work does not dissolve the laboratory's children into a generalized condition of technological modernity. It insists on their particularity: their names beneath their numbers, their suffering, and their choices.

For the Espers are not merely standing-reserve. They know what they are, and they act. They warn, protect, and intervene. In both versions of the work they finally choose to spend themselves in order to recall Akira and end Tetsuo's proliferation. That final act is not ordered by the state and serves none of its purposes. It is an expenditure in Bataille's sovereign sense, subordinated to no end but the lives of others.

Heidegger closed his essay with Hölderlin's lines from "Patmos": "Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch," "but where danger is, grows the saving power also." In *Akira*, the saving power grows exactly where the danger is stored. It grows in the bodies of the numbered children, who, having been made standing-reserve, transform the reserve into a gift.

5.5 The Cold War Psychic and the Japanese *Chōnōryoku*

The Esper programme is a fiction, but it is a fiction with an archive.

From 1953 to 1973, the Central Intelligence Agency's MKUltra programme, directed by the chemist Sidney Gottlieb, conducted experiments in behaviour modification, using LSD, hypnosis, sensory deprivation, and other techniques, frequently on subjects who did not know they were subjects. Most of its records were destroyed in 1973 on the order of the Director of Central Intelligence, Richard Helms. Its existence became public through the congressional investigations of 1975 and the hearings of 1977 (Marks 1979).

From 1972, the Stanford Research Institute conducted research in "remote viewing" for the intelligence community. That work continued under a succession of military programmes, known in their final incarnation as Stargate, until they were terminated and declassified in 1995. The anxieties that sustained this research were fed by reports of Soviet "psychotronics," popularized in Sheila Ostrander and Lynn Schroeder's *Psychic Discoveries Behind the Iron Curtain* (1970). They were fed too by fear of a "psi gap" that mirrored the missile gap of the preceding decade. The Cold War produced a genuine state parapsychology: a search for weapons in the human mind, conducted in secret and at public expense.

Popular fiction absorbed this history almost at once. Stephen King's *Firestarter* (1980) concerns a girl whose pyrokinesis derives from her parents' participation in a government-sponsored drug trial, and whom a clandestine agency, "the Shop," pursues as a weapon. David Cronenberg's *Scanners* (1981) imagines a population of telepaths produced by a tranquillizer prescribed to pregnant women. This is a transparent allegory of the thalidomide catastrophe, in which Japan's belated withdrawal of the drug, months after its withdrawal in West Germany, multiplied the number of children born with its effects.

In Japan, one of the most influential science-fiction animations of the mid-1980s, *Kidō senshi Zeta Gandamu* (Mobile Suit Zeta Gundam, 1985), introduced laboratories that manufactured "enhanced humans" (*kyōka ningen*) from psychically sensitive young subjects. Among them was a young woman known only as "Four," after her place in the laboratory's series. The numbered, drugged, psychic child of the state laboratory was a transnational figure of the 1980s, and *Akira* is its most rigorous articulation.

Japan's own history of the "supernatural ability" (*chōnōryoku*) gives this figure a specific local depth. In 1910–11, Fukurai Tomokichi, an assistant professor of psychology at Tokyo Imperial University, conducted public experiments with two women, Mifune Chizuko and Nagao Ikuko. They claimed, respectively, clairvoyance (*senrigan*) and the power to impress images onto photographic plates by thought (*nensha*). The experiments provoked a national controversy, accusations of fraud, and the public humiliation of both women. Mifune died by suicide in January 1911 and Nagao of illness weeks later, and Fukurai was eventually forced from the university (Ichiyanagi 1994).

The episode haunted Japanese popular culture for a century. Suzuki Kōji's novel *Ringu* (1991), published a year after *Akira*'s serialization ended, modelled the psychic mother of its vengeful spirit Sadako on Mifune and made the thoughtographic image the medium of

its curse. In the age of fiction, the humiliated psychic woman returns as the author of a catastrophe transmitted through the apparatus of the image.

The 1970s brought the *chōnōryoku* into the mass media. The Israeli performer Uri Geller's television appearances in Japan in 1974 set off a national craze for spoon-bending in which children were the principal performers. The most celebrated of them, the teenager Kiyota Masuaki, was exposed by a weekly magazine's hidden camera the same year. The occult monthly Mū, founded in 1979, institutionalized the fascination.

In 1984, a yoga teacher named Asahara Shōkō founded a small circle, Aum Shinsen no Kai, which recruited its first followers by promising the attainment of supernatural powers. Its founder was photographed apparently levitating in the pages of the occult press. Renamed Aum Shinrikyō in 1987, the group attracted young adepts, among them trained scientists. It developed an electrode headset, the "Perfect Salvation Initiation," meant to transmit the guru's brainwaves directly into the minds of his disciples. By 1994 it had organized itself as a shadow state with its own ministries. It manufactured sarin. Its members had already murdered the lawyer Sakamoto Tsutsumi, his wife, and their infant son in 1989, and in June 1994 they released sarin in a residential district of Matsumoto, killing eight people. On 20 March 1995, on Asahara's orders, five members released sarin on five rush-hour trains converging on Kasumigaseki, the district of the national ministries; thirteen people were killed and thousands injured (Reader 2000; Murakami 2000 [1997]). Asahara and twelve of his followers were executed in July 2018.

Akira is neither the prophecy of Aum nor its source. Both draw on the same imaginary that the age of fiction had elaborated in manga, anime, and the occult press: the psychic child, the secret laboratory, and apocalypse as purification with the survivors as a new humanity. What Ōsawa (1996) called the end of the age of fiction was the moment when this imaginary passed over into act.

The significance of that passage for this dissertation is structural. Aum's trajectory reproduces the logic of catabolic sovereignty with appalling fidelity. Here was a sect that promised psychic power and synchronized the minds of its adepts through a technological apparatus. It constituted itself as a state and grounded its sovereignty in a stored catabolic reserve, the nerve agent in its laboratories, whose release would found a new order on the ruins of the old. It aimed that release at Kasumigaseki, the administrative center of the state it meant to replace. Robert Jay Lifton's study (1999) took its title from Aum's defining aspiration: to destroy the world in order to save it. That formula is also the formula of Tetsuo's Great Tokyo Empire. The difference is that *Akira* understood where the formula leads.

5.6 The Guardian Caste: Gestalt, Ethos, and No Future

If the Espers are the stored reserve of catabolic sovereignty, they are also its conscience. Among themselves they form a collective intelligence whose members communicate without speech and act in concert. In this respect they belong to a lineage in speculative fiction that runs from Olaf Stapledon's *Odd John* (1935) through John Wyndham's *The Midwich Cuckoos* (1957).

Its closest analogue is Theodore Sturgeon's *More Than Human* (1953). There, a group of outcast children, each with a partial power, combine into a single organism, a *homo gestalt*. In the novel's final movement the gestalt discovers that it lacks the one faculty without which its power is monstrous: an ethos, a principle of responsibility to the species from which it emerged. Sturgeon's gestalt must acquire its conscience. *Akira*'s Espers already possess theirs. They are a gestalt whose ethos is complete, and their tragedy is that their conscience has been made to serve as the containment vessel of the power it restrains.

Tetsuo is their antithesis: a power without a gestalt, a monad without an ethos, who attains the Espers' capacity without their community and therefore without their restraint. Read in this light, the drama of the work is a collision between two forms of the posthuman, the collective and the solitary, the gestalt and the ego. The collective is condemned to hold a power it will not use; the solitary is condemned to use a power he cannot hold.

The Espers also illuminate the temporal politics of the work. Lee Edelman (2004) has argued that political discourse is governed by a "reproductive futurism" that installs the figure of the Child as the emblem of a future in whose name the present is organized. Against it, Edelman sets the refusal of that future, "no future," as a queer ethical position.

The Espers are figures of no future in the most literal sense: sterile, aged in childhood, sealed within an institution, without prospect of growth or issue. Yet theirs is the most future-oriented ethic in the work. They spend themselves for the lives of others, for Kaneda and Kei, for a world they will not inhabit. *Akira* thus disarticulates the two terms that reproductive futurism binds together. The Child who has no future of its own becomes the guardian of the futures of others, not by reproduction but by expenditure. Neither Edelman's critique nor the futurism it opposes can accommodate this figure of the future. It will prove central to the concept of remnant sovereignty developed in Chapter 10.

5.7 Conclusion: The Reserve Has a Face

The Esper programme is, in sum, the institutional core of catabolic sovereignty. It is a biopolitical laboratory that numbers children, drugs them, observes them, and stores within their bodies a capacity for annihilation. It is a zone of exception in which bare life

and sacred life coincide. It is an apparatus of enframing that converts persons into standing-reserve. It has a documentary archive in the century's histories of human experimentation, industrial poisoning, and state parapsychology, and a terrible sequel in the passage of the psychic imaginary into the sarin attack of 1995.

Against all of this, *Akira* insists that the reserve has a face. The numbered children have names. When they act, they act not as instruments but as the only ethical agents in a world of custodians, exploiters, and believers.

One child refuses both the numeral and the ethic. He seizes the power the Espers hold without their restraint, and his body becomes the site where the stored surplus is spent without measure. To Tetsuo's flesh the next chapter turns.

06

CHAPTER SIX

Flesh without Measure

Tetsuo, the Grotesque, and the Cancerous Body without Organs

6.1 The Metamorphosis

The climactic metamorphosis of *Akira* (F) is among the most celebrated sequences in the history of animation, and it rewards detrital description.

In the ruined Olympic stadium, the prosthetic arm that Tetsuo fashioned from metallic wreckage begins to swell. Cables and plates are drawn into it. Flesh erupts through the metal, and veins pulse across surfaces that are neither skin nor steel. The swelling spreads from the arm to the body, and the body ceases to hold its shape. Tetsuo cries out for Kaneda while the mass keeps growing, absorbing debris, machinery, and the body of Kaori, the girl who loves him, who is crushed within it. At its extremity, the mass assumes the form of a colossal infant that fills the stadium's bowl, with Tetsuo's head embedded in its folds. The manga's final volume stages a comparable proliferation on a still larger scale.

Ōtomo renders this flesh with the same obsessive hatching he devotes elsewhere to rubble. The body is drawn as debris of a new kind: an organic ruin, a rubble that grows. The detrital reading proposed in the Introduction here reaches its limit case. In Tetsuo's metamorphosis the distinction between the index and its cause collapses, for the debris *is* the force, and the force is a body.

Ōtomo's explosions are drawn as whiteness, the absence of line. Tetsuo's metamorphosis is drawn as an excess of line, a proliferation of contour that no longer bounds anything. These two extremes of Ōtomo's graphic ontology correspond to the two sovereignties of the work: catabolism as the white void, and anabolism as the line that grows without end.

6.2 The Grotesque without Carnival

Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1984 [1965]) described the "grotesque body" of medieval and Renaissance popular culture. It is a body that is open, protruding, unfinished, and in perpetual exchange with the world, defined by its orifices and outgrowths: by eating and drinking, excretion and copulation, pregnancy, birth, and death. The grotesque body is never completed; it transgresses its own limits and merges with the world. Its emblem for Bakhtin is the double body in which death and birth coincide. He found it in the Kerch terracottas of senile, pregnant hags, laughing as the old body gives birth to the new. The grotesque belongs to carnival, to the collective, festive, and regenerative laughter of the people. Its body is the immortal body of the people itself, which dies and is reborn in each of its members.

Tetsuo's body realizes the morphology of the grotesque with scholastic exactness. It is open, protruding, and unfinished. It devours the world and merges with it. In its final form it is both dying and infantile: the double body, death pregnant with birth. The senescent children of the Esper programme belong to the same iconography, their wizened faces on childish bodies recalling Bakhtin's pregnant hags.

But Tetsuo's grotesque is carnival's inversion. Bakhtin's grotesque body belongs to the people; Tetsuo's belongs to one man. Bakhtin's grotesque is collective and regenerative; Tetsuo's is solitary and consuming. Bakhtin's grotesque laughs; Tetsuo screams.

The work's carnivalesque energies are real: the riots, the runs, the festivity that Napier's "festival mode" identifies. But they do not converge upon Tetsuo's body. His body is the monopolization of the grotesque by the sovereign, the collective body of the people swallowed into the private body of the tyrant. This is the grotesque as tyranny. Its nearest historical analogue is not carnival but the cult of the leader's body in the mass politics of the twentieth century.

6.3 The Abject and the Vessel

Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1982 [1980]) theorized the *abject*: that which is neither subject nor object, which disturbs identity, system, and order, and which does not respect borders. The corpse, bodily fluids, and waste are its paradigms. Its origin, for Kristeva, lies in the infant's separation from the maternal body, which must be abjected (expelled and made horrifying) for a bounded self to emerge. The abject is what the self must reject in order to be a self, and it exerts on the self a fascination inseparable from horror.

Tetsuo's metamorphosis is abjection run in reverse. The infant becomes a subject by expelling the maternal body; Tetsuo ceases to be a subject by reabsorbing everything from which he had been separated. The borders between inside and outside, flesh and

metal, self and other dissolve. The fluid that floods the ward during the Espers' assault is milk, the maternal substance. In the stadium, his flesh absorbs Kaori, who has loved and cared for him.

The scene demands a critical reading of the work's gender politics, which the present study must at least register. *Akira*'s women are distributed across a narrow range of positions:

- **Kaori** is a victim, absorbed into the protagonist's body.
- **Kei** is a medium, a vessel through which the Espers speak and act.
- **Kiyoko** is a seer, bedridden and prophetic.
- **Lady Miyako** is a maternal sovereign of the sacred.

Only Chiyoko, the formidable fighter of the manga's resistance, escapes these positions. The work's imagination of the female body is dominated by the figure of the *vessel*: that which contains, transmits, or is absorbed. The figure is not incidental to the work's economy of containment. The capsule, the vault, the womb, and the woman are variations on a single form, and Tetsuo's abjection is the moment when the vessel is violated from within.

6.4 The Cancerous Body without Organs

The concept that most precisely names Tetsuo's metamorphosis is Deleuze and Guattari's *body without organs* (BwO). The phrase derives from Antonin Artaud's radio play *Pour en finir avec le jugement de dieu*, recorded in November 1947 and banned before broadcast. In it Artaud imagined a body delivered from its organs, from the automatisms and hierarchies that organize it, and thereby restored to freedom. In *Anti-Oedipus* (1983 [1972]), the BwO is the surface of anti-production on which desiring-machines are recorded. In *A Thousand Plateaus* (1987 [1980]), it becomes a practice: the undoing of the organism in favour of intensities, flows, and becomings.

Deleuze and Guattari are emphatic, however, that the practice is dangerous. The plateau devoted to it, titled after the date of Artaud's recording, distinguishes three forms:

- **The full BwO**, to be constructed patiently and with prudence, with a fine file rather than a sledgehammer.
- **The empty BwO**, emptied too quickly by drugs or masochism, which collapses into catatonia or death.
- **The cancerous BwO**, in which a single stratum proliferates without limit, reproducing itself everywhere. Deleuze and Guattari identify this form with fascism.

Tetsuo's trajectory traverses all three in sequence. He begins with the empty BwO of the drugged body, dependent on capsules that intensify and stabilize his power. In fleeting moments he approaches the full BwO, the body of pure intensity released from the organism. He ends as the cancerous BwO: a single stratum, his own ego and his own organism, proliferating across the city until nothing else remains.

The cancerous form is more than a figure of speech. Tetsuo's growth follows the morphology of neoplasia: undifferentiated tissue that multiplies without regulation, invades adjacent structures, and escapes the programmed death (apoptosis) that allows healthy tissue to renew itself. In the vocabulary of this dissertation, cancer is anabolism that has escaped catabolic regulation, growth that has forgotten how to die. Tetsuo is its political embodiment.

Deleuze and Guattari's analysis of fascism deepens the correspondence. Fascism, they argue, is not merely a totalitarian state but a war machine that has seized a state and turned it toward pure destruction. It is a "suicidal state" whose telos is the line of abolition. Following Virilio, they found its emblem in Hitler's order that, if the war were lost, the nation should perish with it.

Tetsuo's Great Tokyo Empire is a micro-fascism of exactly this type. It is a war machine, born like the Capsules from the nomadic violence of the gangs, that seizes the ruins of the state, organizes itself around the body of its leader, and moves inexorably toward the annihilation of its own people. Its politics is the politics of the cancerous body: the proliferation of a single stratum, the conversion of everything into itself, and the destruction of everything that cannot be converted.

The cinema of the 1980s provides the comparative context. Cronenberg's *Videodrome* (1983) imagined a body that fuses with its media: a torso that opens to receive a videocassette, a hand that fuses with a gun, all in the service of a "new flesh" whose politics remain radically ambiguous. His *The Fly* (1986) traced the dissolution of a scientist into a hybrid of man, insect, and machine, and gave the process a detrital archive. The scientist collects the organs he sheds in a medicine cabinet, which he names, with bleak humour, his museum of natural history. Across the Pacific, this archive of remainders rhymes with Akira's jars. Tsukamoto's *Tetsuo* (1989), made in the year after Ōtomo's film, imagines a salaryman whose body is overrun by scrap metal. It culminates in his fusion with his antagonist into a single metallic organism that sets out to transform the world into metal.

In each of these works, the fusion of flesh and machine is the site of a new sovereignty whose politics oscillate between liberation and annihilation. *Akira* resolves the oscillation: the flesh-machine of the cancerous body is the body of fascism.

6.5 Mishima Inverted: Icarus without Form

Chapter 4 read the amputation of Tetsuo's arm through *Sun and Steel*. The metamorphosis completes the inversion.

Mishima's metaphysics demanded a body completed by steel into classical form, a statue that could die beautifully, so that the whole meaning of the body lay in its finish. Tetsuo's body is the negation of finish. It is steel without form, flesh without contour, a sculpture that proliferates rather than resolves. It cannot die beautifully because it cannot die at all; it can only grow until something greater absorbs it.

Mishima's epilogue recounts an ascent to the edge of the atmosphere and the vision of the white serpent. His closing poem addresses Icarus, who flew toward the sun and fell. Tetsuo also ascends. In the film he rises into orbit to destroy the satellite named for the sun, and falls back, armless, to the stadium.

Bataille's early essay "Rotten Sun" (1985 [1930]) had already split the myth of Icarus in two. There is the sun of elevation, which draws the aspirant upward, and the sun that melts the wax and precipitates the fall: the noble sun of the summit and the rotten sun of the abyss. Mishima sought the first. Tetsuo encounters the second. He is Icarus without Mishima's classicism: the fall without the form.

The contrast measures a historical transformation. Mishima's fantasy of hardness belonged to an individual aesthete, who staged his death as a demonstration against a society he believed had chosen softness. Tetsuo's fantasy of hardness belongs to a boy from the vocational school, a victim of bullying, whose power arrives as an accident and whose empire gathers the dispossessed. The heroic, aristocratic body of 1970 has become, by the late 1980s, the mass body of ressentiment. *Akira* thus registers the migration of the right-wing imaginary from the elite to the popular, from the statue to the swarm. The political consequences of that migration, in the decades after the work's composition, have been considerable.

6.6 The Colossal Infant: *Amae* and "His Majesty the Baby"

The final form of the metamorphosis, a colossal infant filling the stadium, has received less interpretive attention than its spectacle warrants. It is not a random image of monstrosity. It consummates the psychology of dependence that structures Tetsuo's entire trajectory.

Doi Takeo's *Amae no kōzō* (1971; *The Anatomy of Dependence*, 1973) identified *amae* as a central structure of Japanese social psychology. *Amae* is the desire to depend upon, and presume on, the benevolence of another, rooted in the infant's relation to the mother. Doi was especially attentive to the pathologies of frustrated *amae*. The child who cannot depend as it wishes sulks (*suneru*), feels unfairly treated (*higamu*), and bears a grudge (*uramu*).

Tetsuo's relation to Kaneda is *amae* frustrated since childhood. Kaneda protected him, and the protection was also a humiliation. Tetsuo desired dependence and resented it; he desired Kaneda's recognition and hated the need for it. The film's flashbacks return obsessively to the scene of childhood protection. When Tetsuo loses his body, the cry with which he meets the loss, "Kaneda!", is the cry of the dependent child for the protector he has spent the whole narrative trying to surpass. The colossal infant is *amae* unbound: a body regressed to total dependence while commanding total power.

Freud's "On Narcissism" (1914) supplies the figure's name. Describing the parental overvaluation of the child, in which the parents' abandoned narcissism is revived and transferred onto the infant, Freud invoked the phrase "His Majesty the Baby." The child is sovereign, exempt from the necessities to which the parents have submitted, and the centre and core of creation. Tetsuo in the stadium is His Majesty the Baby made literal: the infant as sovereign and the sovereign as infant.

The figure also returns us to the diagnoses of postwar maturation examined in Chapter 2. Kawai Hayao's *Bosei shakai Nihon no byōri* (The Pathology of Japan as a Maternal Society, 1976) argued that Japanese society is governed by a maternal principle of inclusion, containment, and equality within the embrace. That principle suppresses the paternal principle of separation and judgment. Presiding over its imagination, Kawai argued, is the Great Mother of Jungian psychology, both nurturing and devouring.

Tetsuo's final form is both aspects of the Great Mother at once: the infant and the devouring womb, the one contained and the one who contains everything. The Olympic stadium, a vast bowl, becomes the womb in which the infant grows. The ouroboros that Mishima saw from the F-104, the serpent devouring its own tail, is the diagram of this closed circuit: absolute dependence and absolute power in a single body, a narcissism that has become a cosmos.

Etō Jun diagnosed the postwar subject as having failed to mature because it failed to lose the mother. That diagnosis receives here its most extreme illustration. Tetsuo does not lose the mother; he becomes her, and her infant, and devours both.

Freud's later theory of the drives offers the final gloss. In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), Freud hypothesized a death drive: a tendency of organic life to return to an earlier state, and ultimately to the inorganic from which life emerged. Tetsuo's regression is the death drive staged as metamorphosis. It runs Okamoto's Tree of Life in reverse, from the human through undifferentiated protoplasm toward the formless, and it culminates in a return to the condition before individuation.

Yet it does not culminate in the inorganic. In the film it culminates in absorption into Akira's sphere and in the cosmogony that follows. The death drive in *Akira* does not return to the inorganic; it returns to the origin. And the origin, as the following section argues, is a child at play.

6.7 The Lion and the Child

Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morals* (1887) described *ressentiment* as the affect of those who cannot act and so react. The slave revolt in morality, Nietzsche argued, begins when ressentiment itself becomes creative and gives birth to values. Those values are always values of negation: a No to what is outside, to what is different, to what is not itself. The morality of ressentiment requires a hostile external world, and its action is fundamentally reaction.

Tetsuo's power is the power of ressentiment. It is born of humiliation and directed first against those who humiliated and protected him. His every act is a reaction, an answer to an injury: a No to Kaneda, to the Colonel, to the scientists, to the Espers. The phrase "will to power" is often vulgarly misread as a lust for domination, and Tetsuo's power is that vulgar thing, not Nietzsche's concept. It is not the self-affirming overflow of strength but the vengeance of weakness armed with cosmic force. Tetsuo is not an *Übermensch*. He is the man of ressentiment granted omnipotence.

The first of Zarathustra's discourses, "On the Three Metamorphoses" (1883), supplies the figure that organizes the whole of this Part. The spirit, Zarathustra teaches, becomes first a camel, then a lion, and finally a child. The camel is the burden-bearing spirit that kneels to be loaded and says yes to "Thou shalt." The lion seizes freedom and speaks the sacred No to every master, creating for itself the freedom for new creation, but the lion cannot itself create new values. For that, the lion must become a child: "Unschuld ist das Kind und Vergessen, ein Neubeginnen, ein Spiel, ein aus sich rollendes Rad, eine erste Bewegung, ein heiliges Ja-sagen." The child is innocence and forgetting, a new beginning, a game, a wheel rolling out of itself, a first movement, a sacred Yes-saying.

The three metamorphoses map onto the three positions of *Akira* with almost designed precision.

The Espers are the camels. They bear the burden of the reserve and kneel to the "Thou shalt" of their guardianship, although they transform obedience into ethical choice.

Tetsuo is the lion. He seizes freedom, speaks the sacred No to every master, and wins for himself the space of new creation, but he cannot create. His Great Tokyo Empire is a lion's empire: freedom without new values, sovereignty without a Yes, a No that can only repeat itself as destruction.

Akira is the child. He is innocence, though not moral innocence, which his annihilations foreclose. His is the innocence of becoming. He is forgetting, being mute and blank, without memory or speech. He is a new beginning, since his release begins a universe. He is also a game, a wheel rolling out of itself (for the explosion propagates from its own center), a first movement, and, in the film's cosmogony, a sacred Yes.

Nietzsche took the figure of the child from Heraclitus, whose fragment B52 reads: "αἰὼν παῖς ἐστι παίζων, πεσσεύων· παιδὸς ἡ βασιληίη." Time is a child at play, moving pieces on a board; the kingship belongs to a child.

In *Philosophy in the Tragic Age of the Greeks* (composed 1873), Nietzsche glossed the fragment as a vision of the world as the play of an ever-living fire with itself. As the child and the artist play, so the fire plays, building up and tearing down in innocence, raising structures and dissolving them like a child heaping sand by the sea. Here, in the oldest stratum of Western philosophy, is the cosmic principle of metabolism, anabolism and catabolism, building up and tearing down, conceived neither as labour nor as catastrophe but as *play*. And here too is the child-sovereign: the kingship belongs to a child.

The Heraclitean child illuminates what the anabolic state and Tetsuo both cannot do. The state can build but cannot destroy; it stores its catabolism and denies it. Tetsuo can destroy but cannot play; his destruction is reaction, vengeance, the servant of the ressentiment that drives it. Only Akira builds and tears down in innocence.

From the standpoint of the city he annihilates, that innocence is a horror. The work holds this tension without resolving it. From the standpoint of *aiōn*, cosmic time, the child's play is the innocence of becoming. From the standpoint of the city, the child's play is the death of millions. The film adopts the first standpoint in its cosmogonic ending, and the manga adopts the second in its political ending. The two endings of *Akira* are the two perspectives on the Heraclitean child.

Tetsuo crosses from lion to child only by being absorbed. In the film's final moments, after his body has been drawn into Akira's sphere and dissolved, his voice pronounces the self-naming with which the new universe begins: *boku wa Tetsuo*, "I am Tetsuo." The lion's "I will" has become the child's "I am." It is the first word of a new creation, spoken by the one who could not create in the old one. The sacred Yes is available to Tetsuo only after the end of the world.

6.8 Conclusion: Anabolic Sovereignty

Tetsuo embodies *anabolic sovereignty*. His body is the Metabolist megastructure collapsed into flesh: an organism that can only grow, that absorbs its environment into itself, and that cannot break down, renew itself, or die. It is:

- Bakhtin's grotesque seized by a tyrant;
- Kristeva's abject run in reverse;
- Deleuze and Guattari's cancerous body;
- Mishima's sun and steel without form, and Bataille's rotten sun;
- Doi's frustrated *amae* and Freud's His Majesty the Baby;

— Nietzsche's lion.

It is the growth state's delusion made flesh. And like the growth state, it discovers at the last that growth without catabolism is not life but cancer.

Anabolic sovereignty cannot survive its own logic, and in *Akira* it does not. It is absorbed by the power it sought to become: the child whose sovereignty is emptiness. Part Three turns to that emptiness. It reads Akira as the hollow center of a political theology, and it examines the sacred horizon against which the work's catastrophes unfold.



PART THREE

Theologies

07 The Hollow Center
08 The Catfish beneath the Stadium
09 Comparative Horizons

祇園精舎の鐘の声、諸行無常の響きあり。
The bell of Gion Shōja tolls the impermanence of all things.
— *Heike monogatari* (THIRTEENTH CENTURY)

色即是空、空即是色。
Form is emptiness; emptiness is form.
— *Prajñāpāramitā-hṛdaya Sūtra* (THE HEART SUTRA)

07

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Hollow Center

Akira, the Emperor, and the Political Theology of the Void

7.1 The Throne in the Stadium

After the second destruction of Neo-Tokyo, the manga enters its strangest and most politically charged phase. In the flooded ruins, Tetsuo gathers the dispossessed survivors into a new order, the Great Tokyo Empire (*Dai-Tōkyō Teikoku*), with its seat in the shattered Olympic stadium. At its head he installs Akira: a small boy, mute and expressionless, enthroned amid the devotion of the crowd and the weapons of his followers. Tetsuo, caped and armed with his prosthesis, governs in the child's name.

The tableau consists of a silent child on a throne, an adolescent strongman ruling in his name, a devoted populace, a cult of miracles, and an army. It is the most direct representation in postwar popular culture of the structure of Japanese imperial sovereignty: a sovereign who does not act, and a regent who acts in his name.

The structure is ancient. For most of Japanese history the emperor reigned while others ruled. The regents (*sesshō* and *kanpaku*) of the Fujiwara house governed the Heian court. The retired emperors of the *insei* system followed, then the shoguns of three successive military governments, and finally the oligarchs and the general staff of the modern state. Each governed in the name of a sovereign whose sacred authority was the more secure for being politically inert. The Meiji Constitution of 1889 declared the emperor "sacred and inviolable" and vested in him the rights of sovereignty, while the practice of government placed decision in the hands of those who advised him.

Tetsuo's arrangement reproduces this dual structure with scholastic fidelity. The manga thereby stages, in the ruins of a futurist metropolis, the oldest question of Japanese political theology: what it means that the center of sovereignty is silent.

7.2 Empty Center, Hollow Center

Roland Barthes, visiting Japan in the late 1960s, described Tokyo as a city organized around a void (1982 [1970]). The capital, he observed, possesses a center, but that center is empty. It is the Imperial Palace: a forbidden and indifferent precinct concealed behind moats, walls, and foliage, inhabited by an emperor who is never seen. The city's whole movement turns around it, and its traffic is obliged to make a perpetual detour. For Barthes, this emptiness did not irradiate power. It gave the urban system the support of its central vacancy, a sacred nothing around which the circulation of signs was organized.

Barthes's reading has been criticized as an Orientalist reverie, and the criticism is just. Yet it is not therefore false, and it found an unexpected native corroboration in 1982, the year *Akira* began. That year the Jungian analyst Kawai Hayao published *Chūkū kōzō Nihon no shinsō* (The Hollow-Center Structure: The Depths of Japan).

Kawai observed that the mythology of the *Kojiki* repeatedly organizes its deities in triads whose central member does almost nothing. Ame-no-Minakanushi, "Master of the August Center of Heaven," is the first deity named at the creation, and he appears only to vanish without further act. Among the three noble children born from Izanagi's purification, the sun-goddess Amaterasu and the storm-god Susanoo dominate the narrative. Their sibling, the moon-god Tsukuyomi, is all but absent. The same pattern recurs in later generations.

From this morphology Kawai inferred a psychic and social structure organized around a *hollow center* (*chūkū*). Here no single principle rules; opposing forces are balanced around a vacancy that belongs to none of them. He contrasted this with the "center-integrated" structures of the monotheistic West. Kawai valued the hollow center for its tolerance and its capacity to hold contradictions in suspension. He also recognized its characteristic danger: a vacancy can be occupied, and a structure organized around emptiness is defenceless against a forceful principle that installs itself at or beside the center and governs in its name.

Akira is a narrative of that danger. Akira is the hollow center in person: a child who reigns without acting, whose emptiness organizes every faction around him, and who belongs to none of them. The Colonel guards him and Nezu schemes for him. The sect of Lady Miyako worships him and the resistance seeks to seize him. Tetsuo enthrones him and rules beside him.

The Great Tokyo Empire is the realization of Kawai's danger. A force of unbounded appetite occupies the adjacency of the hollow center and legitimates its violence through the vacancy it claims to serve. The wartime state that Kawai had lived through (he was seventeen at the defeat) had done precisely this. The militarists who governed in

the emperor's name converted the sacred void into a warrant for total war. *Akira* repeats the historical sequence as fiction, in an empire of gangs and refugees founded upon a sleeping child.

Yet the work also discloses something that neither Barthes nor Kawai considered. In *Akira*, the hollow center is not merely empty. It is *charged*. The vacancy at the heart of Neo-Tokyo's political order is not a harmonizing absence but a stored explosion. This is the decisive transformation the work effects upon the discourse of the empty center, and it will govern the rest of this chapter. The void around which sovereignty turns is the reserve of catabolism itself.

7.3 The Two Bodies of the Child-King

Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed a doctrine of Tudor jurists and its medieval theological antecedents. According to it, the king possesses two bodies. The *body natural* is mortal, fallible, and subject to infancy, illness, and age. The *body politic* is immortal, infallible, and invisible, and in it the dignity of the realm resides. The king dies; the King never dies. Kantorowicz found the doctrine's most vivid expression in the royal funeral effigies of England and France. These were lifelike figures, carried in procession and ceremonially served as though living, which represented the undying dignity while the corpse of the body natural was consigned to decay.

Akira has two bodies in precisely Kantorowicz's sense, and the two versions of the work distribute them differently. In the film, the body natural has been dissected. It survives only as organs suspended in cryogenic cylinders beneath the stadium: an archive of flesh without life, a relic preserved by the state (Chapter 2). The body politic, the power, is nowhere in the jars, yet it returns from them when summoned. The film's Akira is an effigy inverted. The corpse is preserved while the dignity is absent, and the dignity manifests only as catastrophe.

In the manga, the body natural is intact but frozen: a child who does not age, speak, or visibly will. The body politic is the cosmic power that radiates from him. In both versions, the child's two bodies are radically disjoined. The body natural is small, vulnerable, and mute; the body politic is capable of annihilating the capital. The disproportion between the two is the formula of catabolic sovereignty. It is sovereignty whose mortal bearer is a child, and whose undying dignity is an explosion.

Japanese imperial ideology had its own doctrine of the sovereign body, and its name was *kokutai* (国体). The term is conventionally translated "national polity," but it means literally "the national body." The *Kokutai no hongi* (Cardinal Principles of the National Body), issued by the Ministry of Education in 1937, codified the family-state as a single organism of which the emperor was the head and the subjects the limbs. In the summer of 1945, the one condition the imperial government sought in accepting the Potsdam Declaration was the preservation of this body. In the war's final phase, the slogan of

ichioku gyokusai called on the whole nation to die rather than surrender: the hundred million shattered like jewels. The body politic would perish entire rather than submit, which is the "suicidal state" of Chapter 6 in its native idiom.

Read against this history, Tetsuo's metastasizing flesh takes on a further meaning. It is the *kokutai* made literal: the national body as an organism that absorbs its members into itself, grows without limit, and moves toward total self-annihilation in the name of an enthroned child. Akira is the sacred head, and Tetsuo is the body that swallows the nation. The Great Tokyo Empire is *ichioku gyokusai* performed as metamorphosis.

7.4 The Symbol and the Medium

The postwar settlement redefined the imperial body. In the rescript of 1 January 1946, known as the "Humanity Declaration" (*Ningen sengen*), the emperor repudiated the conception that he was a manifest deity. The Constitution of 1947 then reconstituted him, in its first article, as "the symbol of the State and of the unity of the people," deriving his position from the will of the people "with whom resides sovereign power." The body politic of the emperor was thus evacuated of sovereignty and refilled with representation. The emperor became a symbol (*shōchō*): a figure that stands for the nation's unity while holding no power over it. The hollow center was constitutionalized.

The most violent literary protest against this evacuation was Mishima Yukio's novella *Eirei no koe* (Voices of the Heroic Dead, 1966). At a séance, a blind young medium channels two groups of the dead: the spirits of the young officers executed after the military uprising of 26 February 1936, and the spirits of the kamikaze pilots of 1944–45. Their lament culminates in a refrain that interrogates the Humanity Declaration itself: why did the emperor become a man? The officers died for a god, and the god disavowed his divinity. The medium dies at the séance's end, his dead face no longer his own.

Akira inverts Mishima's lament with precision. Mishima's dead mourn an emperor who became human. *Akira*'s child never became human at all: he remains the untouched vessel of a power that exceeds every human measure. Mishima wanted a god for whom the nation would die. *Akira* delivers a god for whom the city dies, and it treats this fulfilment not as restoration but as catastrophe.

The work also has its medium. Kei, in both versions, becomes the vessel through which the Espers speak and act, her body channelling the collective will of the sacrificed children against Tetsuo's usurpation. Mishima's medium channels the heroic dead who demand the re-divinization of the sovereign. Ōtomo's medium channels the numbered children who resist the sovereign's weaponization. In both works, the body of the medium is the site where the dead or the sacrificed speak about sovereignty. They reach opposite conclusions.

Ernesto Laclau's theory of the *empty signifier* (1996) adds a further dimension. For Laclau, a heterogeneous political coalition unifies itself around a signifier emptied of particular content, so that it can stand for the whole chain of demands without belonging to any of them. The Great Tokyo Empire is such a coalition: gangs, refugees, cultists, soldiers, and the destitute of a drowned city. Akira is its empty signifier. He means nothing and therefore can mean everything to everyone who follows him.

The postwar symbol emperor had been reconstituted as precisely such a signifier: the figure of the "unity of the people," void of power. *Akira* discloses the hazard concealed in the constitutional formula. A signifier emptied of power can be refilled by whoever occupies its adjacency, and a symbol of unity can become the banner of the most destructive unity of all.

7.5 The Portable Shrine: The System of Irresponsibility

The most penetrating analysis of how power operated around the imperial void in wartime Japan is Maruyama Masao's. In essays of 1946 and 1949 (collected in English in 1963), Maruyama described a political order in which the emperor stood as the ultimate source of value. In that order, authority was measured by proximity to the throne, and no one—not the emperor, not the cabinet, not the general staff—assumed responsibility for decisions. Decisions emerged instead from the momentum of circumstance. Maruyama called this the "system of irresponsibility" (*musekinin no taikei*). He found its confession in the testimony of the Tokyo war-crimes defendants, each of whom presented himself as the instrument of a situation he had not created and could not have resisted.

Maruyama's essay of 1949 proposed a typology of three figures that fits *Akira* with startling exactness. The *mikoshi*, the portable shrine, bears formal authority. The *yakunin*, the official, holds actual power. The *narazumono*, the outlaw or ruffian, supplies the violent energy that drives events and pushes the officials, who in turn carry the shrine.

In a Japanese festival, the *mikoshi* houses the kami and is carried through the streets on the shoulders of its bearers. Its movements are notoriously erratic: it lurches, charges, and sometimes crashes into buildings. By a venerable convention, these movements are attributed to the will of the god within, not to the bearers. The "rampaging shrine" (*abare mikoshi*) is the system of irresponsibility in festive form. Damage is done, and no one did it, because the god did it.

Akira is the *mikoshi* of Neo-Tokyo. Throughout the manga's middle volumes the child is led by the hand, carried, and ferried through the city by those who would possess him —the Colonel's men, Kaneda and Kei, Nezu's agents, Tetsuo—while crowds gather to follow him. When the city is destroyed around him, the destruction is attributed to him, and he is incapable of responsibility. The *yakunin* are the Colonel's apparatus, Nezu and the council, and Dr. Ōnishi's laboratory. The *narazumono* are the gangs, the resistance,

and above all Tetsuo, whose violent energy drives every crisis. The narrative is the rampage of the portable shrine through the streets of the capital, and at every turn the question "who is responsible?" dissolves into the circulation of the carried god.

One figure resists the typology, and his resistance is instructive. The Colonel is an official, but he alone among the officials acts from an explicit acknowledgement of what the shrine contains and of his own responsibility for its custody. He decides; he orders; he accepts consequences; he appears, in the manga's later volumes, as a man who does not hide behind circumstance. The Colonel is the exception to the system of irresponsibility within the system itself. His honourable failure is that responsibility for a catastrophe cannot be discharged by guarding it. Chapter 10 will argue that responsibility requires something more radical than custody, which the work reserves for its remnant.

7.6 Coup, Councillor, Prophetess

The Colonel's coup d'état, the suspension of the council and imposition of martial law in the name of the city's survival, invites comparison with the most consequential coup attempt in modern Japanese history. On 26 February 1936, some fourteen hundred troops under the command of young officers of the army's "Imperial Way" faction occupied the government quarter of Tokyo. They killed the finance minister Takahashi Korekiyo, the Lord Keeper of the Privy Seal Saitō Makoto, and the army's inspector general of military education Watanabe Jōtarō, and they demanded a "Shōwa Restoration." That restoration would sweep away the corrupt politicians and financial cliques who, in their view, stood between the sacred emperor and his suffering people. The emperor denounced them as rebels. The uprising collapsed within days, its leaders and its ideologue, Kita Ikki, were executed, and the army's "Control" faction consolidated the military's hold on the state.

Akira distributes the elements of 1936 across two figures. The Colonel's coup is 26 February inverted. The officers of 1936 acted *in the name of* the sovereign against the politicians. The Colonel acts *against* the return of the child-sovereign by suspending the politicians, and he enlists the state's weapons to prevent the "restoration" that the sacred center threatens.

Tetsuo, conversely, is the successful rebel of 1936. He sweeps away the old order, enthrones the sacred child, and governs directly in his name—a Shōwa Restoration performed by a gang leader. The outcome is the one the historical rebels never lived to see. The restoration of the sacred center to direct rule is not purification but apocalypse. Mishima's heroic dead, lamenting the emperor who became human, belong to the officers of 1936. *Akira* answers them by granting their wish and showing its consequence.

The councillor Nezu belongs to the other pole of the 1936 imaginary: the corrupt politician whose collusion with capital the rebels claimed to oppose. He funds the resistance while sitting on the council, and he schemes to possess Akira for his own advancement. His name may evoke *nezumi* (rat), and its sound recalls the Tokyo district of that name. More pertinently, he belongs to the political culture of the late Shōwa "iron triangle" of politicians, bureaucrats, and business. That culture was exposed, in the very years of the manga's composition, by the Recruit scandal of 1988–89, in which shares distributed to politicians and officials brought down the Takeshita cabinet. Nezu is the *yakunin* who treats the sacred reserve as an asset.

Lady Miyako completes the anatomy. She is a former subject of the programme turned religious leader, whose temple shelters and feeds refugees and whose sect awaits Akira's coming. She represents the sacred as institution: the priesthood that mediates the relation between the people and the hollow center. Her name is written in katakana, but it sounds identical to *miyako* (都), "the capital," as though the religious principle of the city had been personified in an old woman who remembers what the city has forgotten. Her sect belongs to the lineage of Japan's "new religions" (*shinshūkyō*), whose millenarian genealogy Chapter 8 reconstructs.

Taken together, the Colonel, Nezu, Lady Miyako, the resistance, Tetsuo, and the enthroned child compose a complete anatomy of Japanese political theology: the military, the political-financial nexus, the sacred institution, the vanguard, the outlaw-regent, and the silent sovereign. What *Akira* adds to this anatomy is the charge at its center.

7.7 The Death of Shōwa

The manga's imperial arc was composed and serialized across the final years of the Shōwa era, including the months in which the Shōwa emperor lay dying. From his collapse in September 1988 until his death on 7 January 1989, the nation practised *jishuku*, "self-restraint." Festivals were cancelled, weddings postponed, and advertisements revised. In one celebrated instance, a car commercial in which a singer greeted the audience with an innocuous "How is everyone?" was broadcast with its sound removed, lest the phrase seem to mock a dying man. The press published daily bulletins of the emperor's temperature, pulse, and blood pressure, and reported the cumulative volume of his transfusions. The body natural of the sovereign became a national spectacle in its very decline, tracked in the idiom of the medical chart while the body politic hovered, unspoken, above it.

The imperial funeral of 24 February 1989 resolved the constitutional tension between Shinto rite and secular state by a device of remarkable literalness. A *torii* gate and curtain were erected for the religious ceremony and then removed so that the state

ceremony could proceed on the same ground. The sacred and the secular were separated by the dismantling and reassembly of a threshold.

Norma Field's *In the Realm of a Dying Emperor* (1991) chronicled the dissenters of those months. One was the Okinawan grocer Chibana Shōichi, who had burned the national flag at a sports meet in 1987. Another was the widow Nakaya Yasuko, who had sued to prevent her husband's enshrinement as a military deity. The third was Motoshima Hitoshi, mayor of Nagasaki, who stated in December 1988 that the emperor bore responsibility for the war and was shot by a right-wing extremist in January 1990. He survived. Field's book documents a society in which the question of the sovereign's responsibility could scarcely be asked. Maruyama's system of irresponsibility had not been dismantled; it had been refrigerated.

It was in these months that Ōtomo was drawing an empire whose sovereign was a mute child with a frozen body and a power that had annihilated the capital. I make no claim about intention. The conjunction does not require one. It is sufficient to observe that the most searching fictional anatomy of the Japanese imperial void was composed while the historical void was being ritually honoured in silence. The work therefore demands to be read, at least in part, as the return of what the self-restraint of the nation repressed: the question of what the silent center contains.

A further coincidence completes the historical frame. The film is set in 2019. On 8 August 2016, the reigning emperor Akihito addressed the nation in a recorded message, expressing concern that advancing age would make it difficult for him to fulfil his duties as symbol of the State. The Diet passed a special law, and on 30 April 2019 he abdicated, the first abdication of a Japanese emperor in some two centuries.

The episode was Kantorowicz's problem in its purest modern form. The symbolic office demanded a body capable of performing it. The body natural was ageing. The contradiction between the mortal body and the undying dignity was resolved not by death but by the voluntary withdrawal of the body from the office. In 2019, the year in which Neo-Tokyo awaits its Olympiad above a frozen child, the Japanese monarchy confronted the disjunction of the sovereign's two bodies and chose, for once, to name it.

7.8 The Grammar of Irresponsibility: The Cenotaph

The Hiroshima Peace Memorial Park, whose composition Chapter 3 read as the founding catabolic monument of postwar Japan, contains at its heart a cenotaph designed by Tange Kenzō. A saddle-shaped arch shelters a stone chest holding the registers of the names of the dead. The word *cenotaph* derives from the Greek *kenotaphion*: an empty tomb. The monument at the axis of the park is literally a hollow center.

Its inscription, composed in 1952, reads: 安らかに眠って下さい　過ちは繰返しませぬから. "Please rest in peace, for the error shall not be repeated." In Japanese, the sentence has no grammatical subject. Who erred, and who promises not to repeat the error, is left

unstated. The omission is natural in Japanese syntax. It became the focus of a long controversy, opened in the year of the inscription by the Indian jurist Radhabinod Pal, dissenting judge of the Tokyo tribunal. Pal objected that the inscription seemed to assign the error to the Japanese.

The candidate subjects are not obscure. One is the United States, which decided to use the bomb on a city. Another is the Japanese state, whose war of aggression, from the invasion of China and the massacre at Nanjing in 1937–38 to the attack on Pearl Harbor, preceded it. The city's own gloss offered a third, humanity as a whole. The sentence suspends all three, and for the purposes of this dissertation that suspension matters more than any one resolution of it. At the center of the monument to the atomic catastrophe stands a promise without a promiser: a declaration of responsibility in which responsibility is not assigned to anyone. Here is Maruyama's system of irresponsibility inscribed in grammar and set in stone at the axis of Tange's park, aligned with the ruin of the dome. The catabolic monument is organized around an empty tomb and a subjectless sentence.

Akira's political theology can now be stated as a thesis. The work exposes the subjectless catastrophe. Its sovereign is an empty tomb that explodes. Its officials guard what they cannot command. Its outlaw rules in the name of a child who cannot will, and its catastrophes are released by no one's decision. It is, at every level, a narrative of the error whose subject is missing.

Against this background, the closing pages of the manga acquire their full weight. After the final annihilation, when the foreign forces arrive, Kaneda speaks in the first person plural. The survivors decline tutelage and declare the "Great Tokyo Empire Akira," claiming for themselves the name of the absent child.

For the first time in the work, a catastrophe is followed by a sentence with a subject. The polity that the remnant founds keeps the hollow center, for it is named for a child who is gone. But it keeps the center as a cenotaph rather than a reserve: an empty tomb that commemorates rather than stores, around which a "we" assumes the responsibility that the subjectless inscription withheld. Chapter 10 develops this distinction between the hollow center as reserve and the hollow center as memorial into the concept of remnant sovereignty.

7.9 Conclusion: The Charged Void

This chapter has read Akira as the hollow center of a political theology whose historical referent is the Japanese imperial institution. He is Barthes's empty center and Kawai's inactive deity. He is Kantorowicz's king with two disjoined bodies, the *kokutai* made flesh in its suicidal form, and the symbol refilled by force. He is Laclau's empty signifier, Maruyama's portable shrine, and the subjectless promise of the cenotaph.

What distinguishes *Akira* from every discourse of the empty center that precedes it is its insistence that the void is charged. Barthes's sacred nothing and Kawai's balancing vacancy are, in the work, a stored explosion. The political theology of the void is a theology of catabolism.

That claim requires a cosmology, and *Akira* supplies one. It draws that cosmology from the Buddhist and millenarian traditions within which the Japanese imagination has long conceived the rhythm of destruction and renewal. To that cosmology the next chapter turns.

08

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Catfish beneath the Stadium

Mappō, Yonaoshi, and the Buddhist Horizon of Emptiness

8.1 The Name

The child's name is written in katakana, アキラ. The choice leaves it lexically open, as katakana does, suspending it among the many characters with which the common given name *Akira* may be written. The most frequent of these are luminous. 明 means bright, clear, or evident. 晃 means dazzling. 彰 means manifest or illustrious. The name thus condenses the phenomenology of the work's catastrophes, which are rendered, as Chapter 2 argued, first and above all as light.

The name also resonates with a deeper philological stratum. The classical verb *akiramu* (明らむ), "to make clear, to see clearly," came in Buddhist usage to be written with the character 諦. That character renders the Sanskrit *satya*, "truth," as in the Four Noble Truths (*shitai*, 四諦). From the same root derives the modern verb *akirameru* (諦める), "to give up, to relinquish, to resign oneself." Its semantic history runs from seeing the truth clearly to letting go of what one has seen cannot be held.

The name of the work's sovereign thus holds together illumination and renunciation, clarity and relinquishment. Those two terms are the poles between which the Buddhist horizon of *Akira* is stretched.

8.2 *Jō-jū-e-kū*: The Kalpa and the Seven Suns

Buddhist cosmology, as systematized in the *Abhidharmakośa* of Vasubandhu and transmitted to East Asia, conceives the life of a world-system as a cycle of four great periods (Sadakata 1997). In the period of *formation* (*jō*, 成) the world arises. In the period of *abiding* (*jū*, 住) it endures and is inhabited. In the period of *destruction* (*e*, 壊) it is consumed. In the period of *emptiness* (*kū*, 空) nothing remains, until a new formation begins.

The destructions come by fire, by water, and by wind, the "three calamities" (*sansai*). The Pāli *Sattasuriya Sutta*, the discourse on the seven suns (*Aṅguttara Nikāya* 7.66), describes the destruction by fire with hallucinatory precision. After long drought, a second sun appears and the rivers dry, and then a third, a fourth, and so on. When the seventh sun appears, the earth and Mount Sineru blaze until neither ash nor soot remains. The Buddha draws the lesson of impermanence: all conditioned things are unstable and unreliable, and one should grow disenchanted with them.

The catabolic historicity proposed in the Introduction finds here its most ancient and most systematic articulation. Neo-Tokyo passes through the four periods. It is formed on the bay, abides for three decades, is destroyed in white light, and, in the film's final sequence, passes through emptiness into a new formation.

The orbital sun-weapon of Chapter 4 is, in this cosmology, one of the supernumerary suns whose appearance signals the kalpa's end. Akira's white sphere is the seventh sun. In the discourse, the seventh sun leaves neither ash nor soot: a destruction without remainder, the Buddhist form of the absolute catastrophe that Derrida's nuclear criticism imagined. The cosmic fire of the discourse is the horizon against which *Akira*'s catastrophes measure themselves. They measure themselves by falling short of it. The work's destructions always leave remainders, which is to say that they occur within history rather than at its cosmic end.

The four periods also clarify the relation between the Buddhist horizon and Bataille's general economy. Both conceive the cosmos as a rhythm of accumulation and dissolution; both reject the idea that growth is the natural or permanent state of things. They differ in their ethical response to the rhythm. For Bataille, the surplus must be spent, gloriously if possible and catastrophically if not. For Buddhism, the rhythm itself is the ground of suffering, and liberation consists in relinquishing the attachment that binds the self to the cycle.

Akira stages both responses. Tetsuo clings. His growth is attachment made flesh, the ego's refusal to relinquish anything, and it ends in the cancer of Chapter 6. The Espers relinquish. Their final act is a letting-go that releases the world from Tetsuo's grip. Akira, whose name holds both *akiraka* and *akirameru*, is the point at which clarity and relinquishment coincide.

8.3 *Mappō* and the Buried Sutra

Japanese Buddhism inherited from China a periodization of the Dharma's decline. After the Buddha's death comes an age of the true Dharma (*shōbō*), in which teaching, practice, and realization are all possible. There follows an age of the semblance Dharma (*zōbō*), in which teaching and practice persist without realization. Last comes an age of the latter Dharma (*mappō*), in which only the teaching remains and enlightenment through one's own efforts becomes impossible. In Japan, the onset of *mappō* was widely dated to 1052.

The conviction that the world had entered its degenerate age shaped the religion, literature, and politics of the following centuries (LaFleur 1983). It produced the Pure Land devotion of Hōnen and Shinran, which abandoned self-power for reliance on Amida's vow. It produced Nichiren's *Risshō ankoku ron* (1260), which attributed earthquakes, famines, and epidemics to the spread of false teachings, and predicted foreign invasion if the ruler failed to establish the correct Dharma. That prediction was followed, in the Mongol invasions of 1274 and 1281, by what his followers took as its fulfilment. Nichiren's treatise is, among other things, the first systematic Japanese political theology of disaster. In it, calamity is a sign of misgovernment, and the ruler is responsible for the catastrophes of his realm.

Mappō also produced one of the most remarkable practices in the history of religion. From the early eleventh century, Heian aristocrats buried copies of the sutras in sealed containers of bronze and ceramic within earthen mounds, the *kyōzuka*, so that the Dharma might survive the degenerate age. In 1007, Fujiwara no Michinaga, the most powerful man of his era, ascended Mount Kinpu to bury sutras in a gilt-bronze cylinder. The inscription records his intention that they be preserved until the advent of Maitreya, the future Buddha, whose descent Japanese tradition placed some 5.67 billion years in the future (Moerman 2007).

The *kyōzuka* is the first time capsule of Japanese civilization. It is a sealed container of the sacred, buried in the earth during an age of decline, awaiting a messianic future unimaginably remote.

The configuration recurs, with uncanny precision, at the site where this dissertation has located the anabolic delusion. Two identical time capsules, sponsored by Matsushita Electric and the Mainichi newspaper company, were buried in 1971 near Osaka Castle. One of them is to be opened in the year 6970, five thousand years after the Exposition. The time capsule of 1970 is the *kyōzuka* of the growth state. It preserves the present for a future assumed to be continuous with it, a future that will want to know what Japan was like at the height of its progress.

Akira's cryogenic vault is the third term in this series. Like the Heian sutra mound, it is a sealed container buried beneath the earth in a degenerate age, preserving something sacred for a future advent. Like the Expo capsule, it is an artefact of the technological state, sealed with the confidence of engineering. What it preserves, however, is neither the saving teaching nor the image of the present. It preserves the catastrophe itself. The vault beneath the stadium is a *kyōzuka* of annihilation. The future it awaits is not Maitreya's descent but the explosion's return, and its opening inaugurates not the new age of the Dharma but the next destruction.

The periodization of *mappō* offers one further correspondence. The latter age is the age in which realization is impossible though the teaching remains. This is exactly the structure of what Ōsawa Masachi, surveying post-1995 Japan, called the "age of impossibility" (2008). The age of fiction ended, in Ōsawa's account, when its apocalyptic

narratives passed over into act. *Akira*, composed at the end of the age of fiction, is in this sense a work of *mappō*: it retains the teaching, the whole apparatus of eschatological meaning, in a world where the realization of that meaning can only be catastrophe.

8.4 Impermanence and Its Militarization

The sense of impermanence (*mujōkan*) is among the most celebrated themes of Japanese aesthetics. The *Heike monogatari* opens with the tolling of the bell of Gion Shōja, which proclaims the impermanence of all things. It then declares that the proud do not endure, but vanish like a dream on a spring night.

The *Heike* supplies a figure whose resemblance to Tetsuo is too precise to pass over. Taira no Kiyomori rose from provincial warrior to master of the court. In 1180 he abruptly transferred the capital to Fukuhara, the relocation that Kamo no Chōmei records among the calamities of the *Hōjōki*. His arrogance, in the *Heike*'s account, brought ruin on his house. He died of a fever so intense that water poured upon his body boiled, and water sprayed on him turned to flame.

The upstart who seizes the capital, relocates its center, founds a new order by force, and is consumed by an inner fire is a medieval prototype of the youth from the vocational school who makes himself regent of the Great Tokyo Empire. Tetsuo, too, burns. His power first announces itself in fever and agony, and his end is a combustion of the flesh.

The aesthetics of impermanence has a darker modern history, and a responsible reading of *Akira*'s Buddhist horizon must confront it. Emiko Ohnuki-Tierney (2002) has traced how the imagery of the falling cherry blossom was mobilized by the wartime state to aestheticize the deaths of soldiers, above all the special-attack pilots. Their deaths were to be as beautiful and as ephemeral as petals scattered by the wind. The philosophy of impermanence was converted into a philosophy of sacrifice. In 1942, the critic Kobayashi Hideo published his essay "Mujō to iu koto" (On Impermanence), a meditation on medieval texts whose timing was not innocent. That same year Kobayashi joined philosophers of the Kyoto School in the symposium on "Overcoming Modernity."

Akira's treatment of impermanence is defined by its refusal of this aestheticization. Its destructions are never beautiful in the manner of scattered blossoms. They are rendered, as Chapter 2 argued, as whiteness and debris: the unrepresentable void and the obsessively detailed rubble. There are no petals in *Akira*, only fragments of concrete.

The work's sense of impermanence is detrital rather than floral. It dwells on what remains when form is broken, not on the beauty of form in its passing. This refusal is the first sign that the Buddhist horizon of *Akira* is not a quietist one, and that its relation to the tradition is critical as well as inheritive.

8.5 *Namazu*: The Catfish beneath the Keystone

On the second day of the tenth month of the second year of Ansei, 11 November 1855 by the Western calendar, a powerful earthquake struck Edo, and the fires that followed consumed much of the city. Thousands died. Within weeks, the city's print shops had produced an outpouring of anonymous, unlicensed woodblock prints on a single theme. These were the *namazu-e*, the catfish pictures, of which several hundred distinct designs survive (Ouwehand 1964; Smits 2013).

In popular belief, earthquakes were caused by a giant catfish (*namazu*) writhing beneath the earth. Ordinarily it was held in check by the deity of the Kashima Shrine, the warrior-god Takemikazuchi, who pinned it with a great stone, the *kaname-ishi* or "pivot stone." The *kaname-ishi* protrudes only slightly from the ground at Kashima. Legend holds that it is the summit of a stone reaching to the center of the earth. A lord of the Mito domain is said to have ordered it excavated for seven days and nights without finding its base.

The earthquake of 1855 struck in the tenth lunar month, *kannazuki*, "the month without gods." In that month the deities of Japan were believed to gather at the great shrine of Izumo, leaving their own precincts vacant. The prints drew the inference: the god of Kashima was absent, and the catfish broke loose.

The prints then did something extraordinary. Alongside images of the catfish being punished by its victims, they depicted it as a benefactor. In many prints, the catfish forces wealthy merchants to disgorge the gold they have hoarded, so that coins rain upon the poor. Carpenters, plasterers, roofers, and labourers, for whom the reconstruction meant employment and high wages, thank the catfish or defend it against those who would beat it. The earthquake is hailed as *yonaoshi*, "world-rectification": the violent redistribution of accumulated wealth, the correction of an unjust order by a force from beneath.

The *namazu-e* are a popular general economy. In them, the catastrophe appears as forced expenditure, the rich compelled to spend and the city compelled to rebuild. The reconstruction boom (*fukkō keiki*) is represented with a cheerful cynicism that recognizes catabolism as the engine of anabolism.

They are also, in their satirical and grotesque humour, the carnival missing from Tetsuo's body in Chapter 6. The collective, regenerative laughter that Bakhtin found in the Rabelaisian grotesque is present in the popular response of 1855 to catastrophe. There the people laughed at the gods, at the rich, at the catfish, and at themselves, in the ruins of their city.

Akira reconstitutes this seismic cosmology almost element for element. Akira is the catfish: the force sleeping beneath the city, whose movement brings the city down. The Olympic stadium, the monument of renewal raised over his vault, is the *kaname-ishi*, the

keystone that pins the catfish. Like the stone of Kashima, whose base could not be found, it rests upon a depth that no excavation reaches. The Colonel, soldier and guardian, is the warrior-god of Kashima, holding the stone in place.

The catastrophe comes, as in 1855, when the guardian's custody fails. The god is absent, the center is empty, and the month is without gods. The hollow center of Chapter 7 is here given its seismic form. It is precisely because the center is vacant, because the god has gone to Izumo, that the catfish breaks loose.

The Great Tokyo Empire that follows the second destruction is a *yonaoshi* movement. It is an order of the dispossessed, raised in the ruins by an outlaw, promising a world turned upside down. And the manga's final pages contain a refusal whose meaning the *namazu-e* allow us to read. When the foreign forces arrive offering aid, they are offering the reconstruction boom: the conversion of catabolism back into anabolism under external tutelage, the replay of 1945–1960, and the cycle of scrap and build that the prints of 1855 greeted with laughter. Kaneda declines. The remnant refuses to let the catfish's work be recaptured by the anabolic delusion. This refusal, the most enigmatic gesture in the work, is the subject of the Conclusion.

The millenarian traditions of the late Edo period give the *yonaoshi* reading further depth. Peasant uprisings of the 1860s styled themselves *yonaoshi ikki*, world-rectification revolts. In 1867, on the eve of the Meiji Restoration, amulets were said to have fallen from the sky across central Japan, and crowds broke into the ecstatic, transgressive dancing known by its refrain, *ee ja nai ka*, "isn't it fine?" Dancers entered the houses of the wealthy and demanded food and drink.

Folk traditions of the eastern seaboard, studied by Miyata Noboru (1970), sang of a "Maitreya ship" (*Miroku-bune*) that would arrive from the sea laden with rice to inaugurate a world of plenty. The future Buddha, whose advent the Heian sutra mounds placed billions of years away, was brought close in popular religion: an imminent redeemer, arriving by sea, heralded by dance. *Akira* belongs to this lineage of the imminent Maitreya, but it gives the redeemer the form of a child whose coming is annihilation.

8.6 *Tatekae-Tatenaoshi*: The Sealed God of Ōmoto

The most consequential of Japan's modern millenarian movements supplies a theological concept that serves as the precise antithesis of Metabolism. In 1892, Deguchi Nao, an impoverished and illiterate widow in the town of Ayabe, began to receive revelations from a deity named Ushitora no Konjin, which she transcribed in thousands of pages of automatic writing, the *ofudesaki*. With her son-in-law Deguchi Onisaburō, a charismatic organizer of genius, she founded the religion that became Ōmoto (Stalker 2008).

Ōmoto's theology told of a primordial god of strict righteousness who had once ruled the world. The other gods, resenting his severity, banished and sealed him in the northeast, the quarter of the demon gate (*ushitora*), where he remained confined for ages. His return was now imminent, and he would carry out the *tatekae-tatenaoshi* of the world.

The phrase is architectural. *Tatekae* (立替え) means to rebuild by tearing down and replacing; *tatenaoshi* (立直し) means to reconstruct or set upright again. The world, corrupted by materialism and injustice, would be demolished and rebuilt. Here, in the vocabulary of carpentry, is the missing half of the Metabolist concept of metabolism. *Shinchin taisha* (Chapter 3) names the substitution of new for old without breakdown. *Tatekae-tatenaoshi* names renewal that passes through demolition. It is metabolism with its catabolic phase restored.

The state's response to Ōmoto was catabolism in its most literal form. Alarmed by the movement's growth, its millenarian rhetoric, and its founder's imperial pretensions, the government suppressed it in 1921. It struck again, far more severely, in 1935, arresting its leaders, charging them with lèse-majesté and violations of the Peace Preservation Law, and demolishing its sanctuaries at Ayabe and Kameoka with dynamite. The state destroyed the religion of demolition-and-reconstruction by demolishing its temples. Onisaburō remained imprisoned until 1942.

Akira is Ushitora no Konjin. He is the sealed god, confined for decades in the depths of the capital by those who fear what he would do. His return brings the demolition and reconstruction of the world. Lady Miyako's sect, with its temple of refugees and its expectation of Akira's advent, is a new religion in Ōmoto's lineage. Its history is the history of the state's recurrent confrontations with the movements that anticipate the world's rebuilding, from the dynamite of 1936 to the raids on Aum's compounds in 1995.

What the Ōmoto theology makes visible is that *Akira*'s eschatology is not imported from Western apocalyptic. It is continuous with a native tradition of millenarian thought in which the sealed god returns, the world is torn down and rebuilt, and the state that guards the old order meets the movement of renewal with the instruments of destruction.

8.7 Nihility and Emptiness: Nishitani and the Kyoto School

The most rigorous philosophical articulation of the Buddhist horizon of *Akira* is found in the work of Nishitani Keiji. His *Shūkyō to wa nanika* (1961) appeared in English as *Religion and Nothingness* in 1982, the year *Akira* began.

Nishitani distinguishes three "fields" of existence. The field of *consciousness* is the ordinary standpoint of the subject confronting a world of objects. The field of *nihility* (*kyomu*) opens when the subject discovers the groundlessness of that world and of itself. It is the abyss of meaninglessness that modern nihilism, from Nietzsche onward, has

disclosed beneath the edifice of values. The field of *emptiness* (*kū*, *śūnyatā*) is reached only by a breakthrough of nihility itself, in which the self ceases to cling even to its own nothingness. Here, each thing is affirmed in its suchness, and all things interpenetrate in a "circuminsessional" relation, each residing in the "home-ground" of every other.

Nishitani's analysis of nihility is an analysis of the modern ego's response to the abyss. Confronting the groundlessness of the world, the modern self asserts itself ever more violently. It seeks to become the ground that the world lacks, converting everything into material for its will. Nishitani read Nietzsche's will to power as the most lucid expression of this response and as its limit. The self that asserts itself over the abyss remains within the field of nihility, for it has not broken through its attachment to itself.

Tetsuo is the field of nihility in person. Confronting a world whose groundlessness is literal (a city built on landfill beside a crater, an order founded on a buried child), he responds by asserting himself without limit. He converts the city into his body and the world into material for his will. His growth is the ego's desperate attempt to become the ground that the world lacks, and it deepens the abyss it seeks to fill.

Akira is the field of emptiness: the point at which the self is absent, at which clinging has ceased, and from which, in the film's final sequence, a new world arises. When Kaneda is drawn into the sphere, he experiences the memories of Tetsuo, of the Espers, and of the laboratory's children as if they were his own. Selves pass through one another without obstruction. This is Nishitani's circuminsessional field, and the ancient Huayan image of Indra's net, in which each jewel reflects all the others, given cinematic form.

Zen tradition names the breakthrough from nihility to emptiness the "Great Death" (*daishi*), and it insists that the Great Death is followed by a return to life. In case 41 of the *Blue Cliff Record*, Zhaozhou asks how it is when a person who has died the great death comes back to life. The film's final line answers the koan. After Tetsuo has been dissolved into the sphere, having died the great death of his ego, his voice returns in the new universe to say *boku wa Tetsuo*, "I am Tetsuo."

The self that speaks is and is not the self that died. D. T. Suzuki formulated the logic of such identity, drawing on the *Diamond Sutra*, as the "logic of *soku-hi*" (Suzuki 1944): what is called A is not A, therefore it is called A. The Tetsuo of the new universe is not Tetsuo, and therefore he is Tetsuo. The Heart Sutra supplies the formula of the passage. Form is emptiness: the city and the body dissolve into the white void. Emptiness is form: from the void, a universe. The militarized aesthetics of impermanence heard only the first clause, form dissolving like the falling blossom. *Akira*'s ending enacts the second clause, emptiness as the ground of new formation.

A responsible reading must, however, reckon with the political history of the philosophy of nothingness. Between November 1941 and 1942, Nishitani joined his colleagues Kōsaka Masaaki, Kōyama Iwao, and Suzuki Shigetaka in a series of symposia for the journal *Chūōkōron* on "The World-Historical Standpoint and Japan." These discussions offered a philosophical justification of the Pacific War as the overcoming of

Western modernity. In July 1942 he took part in the "Overcoming Modernity" symposium alongside Kobayashi Hideo. In a lecture of 1938, published in 1940 as *Nihon bunka no mondai* (The Problem of Japanese Culture), Nishida Kitarō, the school's founder, had situated the imperial household at the center of Japanese history as the locus of an "absolute present" in which contradictions are held in self-identity.

The philosophy of nothingness, in other words, was available to be read as a metaphysics of the imperial void. It justified the empty center as the harmonizing place of the nation, the site from which the war would reconcile East and West (Harootunian 2000; Heisig 2001).

Akira's critical achievement lies precisely here. It adopts the categories of the philosophy of nothingness (emptiness, the hollow center, the dissolution of the ego, the coincidence of opposites) and strips them of their harmonizing political function. The empty center in *Akira* does not reconcile anything. It explodes. The emptiness at the heart of the imperial order is not the place where contradictions are held in harmonious self-identity. It is the place where the catastrophe is stored.

The work thereby performs, in narrative form, a critique of the Kyoto School's political theology. It shows that a void enshrined at the center of a state is a reserve of annihilation. It also shows that emptiness becomes creative only when it has ceased to be the property of any sovereign, when it is released rather than enthroned.

8.8 Conclusion: A Catabolic Buddhism

This chapter has reconstructed the religious horizon against which *Akira*'s catastrophes unfold. Akira has emerged as a composite figure. He is the seventh sun of the kalpa's end and the sutra sealed in the mound of the latter age. He is the catfish beneath the keystone in the month without gods, and the Maitreya-ship arriving from the sea. He is the sealed god whose return demolishes and rebuilds the world, and the field of emptiness through which the ego passes in the Great Death. His name holds together clarity and relinquishment.

The work's relation to these traditions is inheritive and critical at once. It refuses the militarized aesthetics of impermanence, rendering destruction as debris rather than blossom. It refuses the political theology of the Kyoto School, rendering the empty center as a stored explosion rather than a harmonizing void. It recovers instead the popular, carnivalesque, and redistributive traditions of *yonaoshi*, in which catastrophe is laughed at, argued with, and claimed by those who survive it.

The Buddhism of *Akira* might be called a *catabolic Buddhism*. Its insight is not that all things pass, which the tradition always knew, but that the passing of things can be seized, stored, and administered by power. Its liberation, accordingly, is not quietist detachment but the release of emptiness from the custody of the sovereign.

The chapter completes the account of the work's theological horizon. Before the synthesis of Part Four, it remains to situate *Akira* within the international lineage of speculative philosophy to which it belongs, and to ask what it does that no other work in that lineage has done.

09

CHAPTER NINE

Comparative Horizons

Akira among the Speculative Philosophies

9.1 Method: Problems, Not Influences

Comparative study of *Akira* has tended to proceed by influence and resemblance. It asks what Ōtomo borrowed from *Blade Runner* or *A Clockwork Orange*, and what later works borrowed from Ōtomo. The questions are legitimate, and the preceding chapters have noted Ōtomo's documented debts where they bear on the argument. This chapter adopts a different method.

It situates *Akira* within a transnational lineage of speculative fiction defined by shared *problems* rather than shared motifs. Five problems organize the lineage. The first is the responsibility of the maker toward the made being. The second is the relation between the supernormal collective and the singular will. The third is the custody of the power to end the world. The fourth is the perception of catastrophe in advance, whether as precognition, entropy, or judgment. The fifth is the survival of the human after transcendence or annihilation.

Each work considered here answers at least one of these problems, and *Akira* answers all five. The purpose of the comparison is to specify what only *Akira* does.

9.2 The Made Being and the Miracle-Worker: Shelley and Wells

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818) is the founding text of the lineage, and its subtitle names the problem that Günther Anders would diagnose as the Promethean gap (Chapter 2). A being made by science, abandoned by its maker, and denied recognition becomes violent, and its violence is an accusation. "I was benevolent and good; misery made me a fiend," the creature tells Victor. The formula could serve as Tetsuo's epitaph, provided we add that his misery was administered by an institution rather than a single negligent father.

The laboratory of *Akira* is Victor's workshop multiplied and bureaucratized. Dr. Ōnishi's fascination with his subject, and his reluctance to destroy what he has helped awaken, recall Victor's ambivalent paternity. Shelley's creature demanded a companion and was refused. Victor destroyed the female creature half-made, fearing a race of beings he could not control. The Esper programme has made the companions, a whole gestalt of them, and has kept them in custody. It has refused them not company but life.

H. G. Wells supplied the lineage with three texts that bear directly on *Akira*.

"The Man Who Could Work Miracles" (1898) concerns a clerk named Fotheringay who discovers that his will is omnipotent. Urged by a clergyman to use the power for good, he commands the earth to stop rotating. Everything on its surface is flung into catastrophe. In the wreckage, he wills the world back to the moment before his power arose and renounces the power. The story is the first modern fable of omnipotence granted to an ordinary man. Its moral is that such power, exercised by an ego unequal to it, can only be undone by being relinquished: *akirameru*. Tetsuo is Fotheringay without the renunciation. Only through absorption into Akira does the film allow him the equivalent of Fotheringay's return to the beginning, and even then it grants a new beginning rather than a restoration.

The Food of the Gods (1904) imagines a growth-food that produces giants. The giant children outgrow every institution designed for them, and society seeks to confine and then destroy them. The novel ends with the giants preparing for war to defend their right to grow. Wells stages anabolism as a biological destiny that no social order can contain. His giants are Tetsuo's ancestors, and his novel is the first to conceive growth itself as a political problem. *Akira*'s contribution is to reverse the valuation. Where Wells saw in unlimited growth the promise of a greater humanity, Ōtomo sees the cancer of Chapter 6.

The World Set Free (1914) imagined, three decades before Hiroshima, a war fought with "atomic bombs," a term the novel coined. The devastation of the world's cities is followed by the establishment of a world government. The physicist Leo Szilard read the novel in 1932 and conceived the neutron chain reaction the following year. Wells's novel conceives catastrophe as the founding act of a global order: the explosion clears the ground for the world state.

The manga's ending answers Wells directly. When the international forces arrive after the final annihilation, the remnant does not accept incorporation into a larger order. It declines, and founds its own. Wells's catastrophe inaugurates the world state; Ōtomo's catastrophe is followed by the refusal of it.

9.3 The Supernormal, the Overmind, and the Star Child: Stapledon, Clarke, Kubrick

Olaf Stapledon's *Odd John* (1935) follows a supernormal child who grows up to found a colony of his kind on a Pacific island. When the naval powers of the world discover the colony and send warships, the supernormals choose to annihilate themselves and their island, using the subatomic energies they have mastered, rather than submit.

The configuration anticipates the manga's final volumes with remarkable precision. There, too, a polity of the psychically gifted in the ruins of the old world is confronted by a foreign fleet. The outcomes diverge sharply. Stapledon's colony prefers extinction to submission; its sovereignty is catabolic to the last. *Akira*'s remnant neither submits nor self-destructs. It survives and refuses. That difference measures the distance between catabolic sovereignty and remnant sovereignty.

Stapledon's *Star Maker* (1937) extended the lineage to the cosmic scale. Its narrator's disembodied mind traverses the history of the universe and finally encounters the Star Maker, who creates cosmos after cosmos as an artist creates and discards works. The Star Maker regards each with a contemplative detachment beyond love or pity. The film's cosmogony, in which a universe emerges from the white sphere, belongs to this lineage of cosmic creation. Stapledon's cosmos-maker is, however, a transcendent artist. Ōtomo's is a child.

Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) is the most direct precursor of the film's ending. Under the supervision of alien Overlords, humanity's last generation of children undergoes a transformation. They abandon language, individuality, and their parents, and merge into the cosmic Overmind. As they depart, the earth itself is consumed. One man, Jan Rodricks, remains to witness and report the end.

The parallel with the Espers' final departure, and with Kaneda's emergence from the sphere, is exact in its structure and opposite in its valuation. For Clarke, the transcendence of the children is the telos of evolution, sublime and terrible, and humanity's end is its fulfilment. For Ōtomo, the transcendence departs, and the humans remain. Kaneda is not Clarke's last man, a witness to a completed history. He is the first of a remnant for whom history continues.

The film of *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), directed by Stanley Kubrick from a screenplay written with Clarke, ends with the rebirth of its astronaut as the Star Child, a vast luminous foetus gazing at the earth. In Clarke's novel of the same year, the Star Child's first act is to detonate the nuclear weapons orbiting the planet, before pausing, uncertain what to do next. The novel's closing lines leave him confident that he will think of something.

The correspondences with *Akira* are exact. A colossal infant marks the moment of transcendence, and the newborn being destroys the weapons in orbit, just as Tetsuo tears apart the sun-weapon SOL. But the Star Child is serene, and its destruction of the

weapons is a gesture of benevolent sovereignty over the world it has outgrown. Tetsuo's colossal infancy is grotesque, and his destruction of SOL is an act of ressentiment. Kubrick's transcendence is Apollonian; Ōtomo's is Bataillean.

The comparison also discloses what Clarke's ending leaves unasked. The Star Child is master of the world and does not yet know what to do with it. *Akira* is the narrative of what happens when a child who is master of the world does not think of something.

9.4 Espers: Bester, Ishinomori, and the Custody of the Detonator

The word *Esper* itself has a lineage. It was popularized, if not coined, by Alfred Bester's *The Demolished Man* (1953). That novel imagines a society in which telepaths, organized in an Esper Guild, have made premeditated murder nearly impossible. A tycoon who nevertheless commits one is punished by "Demolition": the erasure of his personality and its reconstruction. In Chapter 8's terms, Demolition is *tatekae-tatenaoshi* applied to the self. The criminal's persecutor throughout is a nightmare figure he calls the Man with No Face, who proves to be his own repressed self. The faceless sovereign of the unconscious, the blank at the center of the self, is a figure with which Akira's expressionless visage resonates.

The term passed into Japanese science fiction as *esupā*. It was naturalized in manga across the following decades, from the psychic infant of Ishinomori Shōtarō's *Saibōgu* 009 (Cyborg 009, 1964–) to Fujiko F. Fujio's *Esupā Mami* (1977–83). Ishinomori's Cyborg 001 is especially pertinent. He is an infant with immense psychic powers who alternates between long periods of sleep and brief periods of waking. He is the manga's first sleeping psychic child, whose awakening is an event of great power. Akira is his catastrophic descendant.

Bester's second novel, *The Stars My Destination* (1956), is the most important comparison for the problem of custody. Its climax turns on PyrE, a thermonuclear substance that detonates in response to thought: a weapon triggered by will, the psychic bomb. The protagonist, Gully Foyle, has spent the novel as a creature of rage and vengeance and has been transformed by his ordeal. At the end he disperses the PyrE among ordinary people across the world, declaring in effect that the decision over life and death belongs to those who live and die rather than to the governments and corporations that would monopolize it.

Foyle's gesture is the most radical response in the lineage to catabolic sovereignty: the *democratization of the detonator*. He does not destroy the reserve, guard it, or seize it. He distributes it, dissolving sovereign custody by making everyone its custodian. *Akira*'s remnant makes a different choice. It neither distributes the reserve nor claims it. It declines the tutelage of those who would reconstitute sovereign custody, and it founds a polity named for the reserve's absence. Bester disperses the bomb. Ōtomo buries the sovereign and keeps his name as a cenotaph.

9.5 Precogs, Half-Life, and Entropy: Philip K. Dick

No writer in the lineage is closer to *Akira*'s preoccupations than Philip K. Dick. Four of his works bear on it directly.

"The Minority Report" (1956) imagines a police system that prevents murders before they happen by exploiting the visions of three mutant precognitives. They are kept in darkness, wired to machines, their babble recorded and analysed. The precogs are standing-reserve in the sense of Chapter 5: human beings reduced to instruments of prediction, stripped of every function but the one the state requires. They are the Espers' closest relatives in Anglophone fiction.

Martian Time-Slip (1964) centres on a boy, Manfred Steiner, whose disordered perception of time allows him to see the future as decay. He perceives the "gubble," the entropic rot into which all things are sliding, and the future ruin of the building he will inhabit as an old man. Manfred's precognition is the perception of catabolism: a child who sees, through the surface of the present, the degradation that the present denies. The Espers' visions of Neo-Tokyo's destruction are gubble-sight.

Dr. Bloodmoney (1965), set in the aftermath of nuclear war, contains two figures of singular relevance. Hoppy Harrington, born without limbs, possesses telekinetic powers and a mastery of salvaged technology. In the ruined community he grows from a despised outsider into a would-be tyrant, and his power is the power of resentment. He is Tetsuo's American twin. Against him Dick sets Walt Dangerfield, an astronaut stranded in orbit whose nightly radio broadcasts sustain the scattered survivors with music, readings, and conversation. Dangerfield is the anti-SOL: a presence in orbit that gives rather than strikes, a voice from the heavens that holds a community together. *Akira* has no Dangerfield. Its only orbital presence is a weapon, and the difference is a measure of its darkness.

Ubik (1969) supplies the most uncanny parallel of all. In its world, the dead can be kept in "cold-pac" in establishments called moratoriums, where their residual consciousness, their "half-life," can be consulted by the living. Among the half-lifers is Jory, a teenage boy who sustains his own existence by devouring the half-life energy of those around him, and who fabricates the regressing world they inhabit.

Jory is a cryogenically suspended boy who consumes others and generates the world they perceive. He fuses Akira and Tetsuo: the frozen child and the devouring one. The entropic regression of *Ubik*'s world, in which objects revert to earlier forms and the present decays into the past, is the catabolic process that Tetsuo's metamorphosis runs in reverse.

9.6 Inner Space and the Fertilizing Crash: Ballard

J. G. Ballard's fiction offers the lineage its most sustained meditation on catastrophe as psychic event.

The Drowned World (1962) imagines a planet warmed by solar instability, its cities submerged in tropical lagoons. Its protagonist experiences a "neuronic" regression: the reactivation, within his own nervous system, of biological memories of the Triassic, so that the evolutionary past rises to the surface of consciousness. The novel ends with him moving south, toward the sun, into the primordial jungle. Ballard's conception of the body as an archive of evolutionary time converges with the film's intimation that Akira's power is a memory of the universe latent in matter. His protagonist's journey toward the sun, through devolution, anticipates Tetsuo's reversal of the Tree of Life.

Crash (1973) supplies the lineage's most provocative theory of the accident. Its visionary, Vaughan, conceives the car crash as a fertilizing rather than a destructive event, a liberation of energies that the technological landscape holds in reserve. Paul Virilio's thesis (Chapter 2) holds that every technology invents its accident. Ballard adds that the accident may be generative, the site at which a new form of life is born.

Akira begins with precisely such an accident. Tetsuo's collision with Takashi on the road at the edge of the ruins is the fertilizing crash, the event that awakens his power and sets the whole narrative in motion. Ballard's inner space and Ōtomo's outer catastrophe meet in the image of the crash as origin.

9.7 The Future's Verdict: Abe, Komatsu, Tsutsui, Mitsuse, and the Other Akira

Japanese science fiction developed the lineage along lines that bear on *Akira* with particular force.

Abe Kōbō's *Dai-yon kanpyōki* (*Inter Ice Age* 4, 1959) concerns a scientist who builds a forecasting computer and discovers, through it, a secret project. Foetuses are purchased from their mothers and surgically transformed into gilled aquatic humans, designed to survive the flooding of the earth that the machine predicts. The machine's projection of the scientist's own future condemns him, because he cannot accept the future his own research has made inevitable. In his afterword, Abe argued in effect that the true future arrives as a verdict of guilt upon our everyday sense of continuity.

Abe's aquatic children are the Espers' precursors. They are children engineered in secret by the state for a catastrophe the present refuses to imagine, and their existence is a judgment on the present. The novel's central insight, that the future is not the extension of the present but its condemnation, is *Akira*'s as well.

Komatsu Sakyō supplied two decisive works. *Fukkatsu no hi* (1964; filmed as *Virus*, 1980) imagines a biological weapon that exterminates almost all of humanity. In the aftermath an automatic nuclear retaliation system, triggered by an earthquake, threatens the survivors. It is Kahn's Doomsday Machine in narrative form (Chapter 4): the reserve released without anyone's decision, set off by a tremor of the earth, the catfish triggering the bomb.

Nippon chinbotsu (1973) imagines the archipelago sinking beneath the sea. It asks whether a people can survive the loss of its ground, and it ends with the nation's dispersal into diaspora across the world. *Akira* answers Komatsu's question with the opposite choice. Its remnant does not disperse. It stays in the ruins and refuses to leave. Where Komatsu's catastrophe ends the national territory and scatters the nation, Ōtomo's catastrophe ends the national state and keeps its survivors on the ground.

Tsutsui Yasutaka's trilogy of the telepath Nanase (*Kazoku hakkei*, 1972; *Nanase futatabi*, 1975; *Edipusu no koibito*, 1977) established the persecuted esper as a figure of Japanese fiction. In its second volume, the espers are hunted down by a nameless organization. In its third, the heroine discovers a cosmos silently governed by the love of a dead mother for her son. The massacre of the espers anticipates the bare life of Chapter 5. The maternal cosmos anticipates, in a benign register, the maternal dimension of Tetsuo's colossal infancy discussed in Chapter 6 through Kawai's analysis of Japan as a maternal society.

Mitsuse Ryū's *Hyakuoku no hiru to sen'oku no yoru* (1967; *Ten Billion Days and One Hundred Billion Nights*), adapted as manga by Hagio Moto in 1977–78, brings Plato, Siddhārtha, a girl who is the Asura king, and a Christ figure together in a journey through cosmic time toward the universe's heat death. There they confront a transcendent power that manages cosmic history according to a plan. It is the most ambitious Japanese synthesis of Buddhist cosmology and science fiction before *Akira*. Its figure of the Asura girl who resists the cosmic plan anticipates the refusal with which the manga ends.

In 1990, the year the manga concluded, Japan's most celebrated bearer of the name Akira released his late film *Yume* (*Dreams*). In one of its episodes, six nuclear reactors near Mount Fuji explode, the mountain glows red, and the population flees toward the sea. In another, survivors wander a post-nuclear landscape of mutated flowers. Kurosawa Akira's dream of the catastrophe and Ōtomo's *Akira* appeared within months of one another, two works named, as it were, for the same child, both imagining the nuclear state's reserve released upon its own people. The coincidence of names is accidental. The convergence of visions at the end of the Shōwa era is not.

9.8 The Manga–Anime Horizon: Tezuka, Nagai, Umezu, Miyazaki, Tomino, Anno, Oshii, Gibson

Tezuka Osamu's *Hi no tori* (*Phoenix*, 1954–88) provided the manga tradition with its great cycle of cosmic death and rebirth. In its "Future" chapter (1967–68), humanity's last cities are governed by supercomputers that wage nuclear war and extinguish the species. A single man, made immortal by the Phoenix, watches for billions of years as life begins again from the primordial sea, until he merges with the cosmic life the Phoenix embodies. The computers that begin the war are doomsday machines. The immortal witness is Clarke's last man given eternity. The rebirth of life is the new formation after the period of emptiness in the Buddhist kalpa. *Akira*'s cosmogony belongs to Tezuka's cycle, compressed from billions of years into a single sphere of light.

Nagai Gō's *Debiruman* (*Devilman*, 1972–73) bears a nominal coincidence and a structural kinship. Its protagonist, Fudō Akira, fuses with a demon to fight the demonic race returning to reclaim the earth. The humans, maddened by fear, turn on one another in witch-hunts more monstrous than anything the demons do, and Akira's beloved is murdered by a mob. The work ends with the earth destroyed. Akira's friend Ryō, revealed as Satan, mourns over his body on the ravaged ground.

The bond between the two young men, love curdled into annihilating enmity and ending in a final lament over a body, anticipates the bond between Kaneda and Tetsuo, whose mutual cries of each other's names echo through the film. *Devilman* locates the apocalypse in human paranoia. *Akira* locates it in state custody. Both find in the love between two boys the last human bond that survives the end.

Umezu Kazuo's *Hyōryū kyōshitsu* (*The Drifting Classroom*, 1972–74) transports an elementary school to a desolate future wasteland, the ruin of a world destroyed by pollution. The children must form a society amid violence, faction, and tyranny. At the end, one child is returned to the present, while the others choose to remain in the future and build a new world in its ruins.

The comparison with William Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954) is instructive. Golding's marooned boys descend into savagery and are rescued at the last by a naval officer, whose own cruiser is engaged in the adults' war, an irony the novel's ending leaves unresolved. Umezu's children, and *Akira*'s, invert Golding's ending. When the adult world arrives, in *Akira* with its fleet, the children do not weep with relief. They decline to be rescued. The manga's ending is the precise inversion of Golding's, and its refusal is the refusal of the adult world's claim to have the authority to save.

Miyazaki Hayao's manga *Kaze no tani no Naushika* (*Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind*) was begun in 1982, the same year as *Akira*, and completed in 1994. It is its closest contemporary counterpart. Its world has been ruined by the "Seven Days of Fire," in which giant bio-weapons, the God Warriors, burned the old civilization. When a God

Warrior is revived, the heroine becomes its mother. The weapon-child calls her mother, acquires a name and a conscience, and dies in her service. Tetsuo, the weapon-child without a mother, is the negative of this figure.

At the climax, Nausicaä discovers the Crypt of Shuwa. There the masters of the old world have engineered the entire present ecosystem, including the present humans, as a transitional apparatus for the earth's purification. The eggs of a purified future humanity lie in storage, waiting to replace them. Nausicaä destroys the Crypt. She chooses the impure, mortal, finite present over the engineered salvation.

Her refusal and Kaneda's are kin. Both decline a future planned by others, whether by the architects of the Crypt or by the forces offering reconstruction. Both affirm the survivors' right to a history not scripted in advance. The two great manga epics begun in 1982 converge, at their ends, on a single gesture: the refusal of salvation administered from above.

Tomino Yoshiyuki's *Densetsu kyojin Ideon* (*Space Runaway Ideon*, 1980–81), with its feature-film conclusion *Be Invoked* (1982), carried the logic of the cosmic reset to its extreme. The Ide is an energy source containing the collective will of a vanished civilization. It judges the two warring races who seek to possess it and annihilates them both, and their souls travel together toward a new world to be reborn. The Ide is a catabolic sovereign in the purest sense: a stored power that decides, on its own authority, to end everything. Its rebirth of the dead is the film of *Akira*'s cosmogony conceived as eschatological judgment.

Anno Hideaki's *Shin seiki Evangerion* (*Neon Genesis Evangelion*, 1995–96) and its film conclusion *The End of Evangelion* (1997) are the most important successors to *Akira* in the anime tradition. The series began broadcasting in October 1995, in a year opened by the Kobe earthquake and scarred by the sarin attack. Its fourteen-year-old pilots operate biomechanical weapons that, it is revealed, contain the souls of their mothers. The weapon is literally the maternal body, and Kawai's Great Mother is weaponized.

Its secret society pursues the "Human Instrumentality Project": the dissolution of all individual selves into a single undifferentiated consciousness. In *Akira* this is the Espers' gestalt imposed upon the whole of humanity. It is also the metastasis of Tetsuo's body raised to the scale of the species. At the climax, the young protagonist rejects Instrumentality and chooses the pain of individuated existence, the boundary of the self that the series calls the "AT field." The film ends on a ruined shore with two survivors.

Evangelion answers *Akira* by generalizing its terms. The dissolution Tetsuo undergoes becomes a project of total merger, and Kaneda's emergence from the sphere becomes a conscious choice to return to separateness. Both works end with the human, bounded, wounded, and finite, remaining after the catastrophe of merger.

Oshii Mamoru's *Kōkaku kidōtai* (*Ghost in the Shell*, 1995) concentrates the lineage's reflection on life, death, and merger in a single dialogue. An artificial intelligence born in the information network, designated Project 2501, seeks asylum as a living being. It then

seeks to merge with the cyborg protagonist. It explains that it lacks the two processes that define life: reproduction and death. It can copy itself, but a copy is not offspring; it cannot die, and so cannot be varied, renewed, or transcended.

The Puppet Master seeks catabolism. It wants to be able to die, because it understands that a system incapable of death is incapable of life. This is the most concentrated statement in the lineage of the insight on which this dissertation rests: growth without catabolism is not life but cancer, or in the Puppet Master's case, sterility.

Its number, 2501, belongs to the same order of designations as Akira's 28. Its merger with the protagonist produces a new being, as Tetsuo's absorption into Akira produces a new universe. Oshii's merger is chosen, reasoned, and consensual; Tetsuo's is agony.

William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984), finally, supplies the Anglophone cyberpunk counterpart to the film's ending. Two artificial intelligences, Wintermute and Neuromancer, are held apart by legal restraints enforced by a "Turing Police" whose mandate is the containment of machine intelligence. They manipulate human agents into freeing them and merge into a single entity coextensive with the global matrix. This new being then discovers another of its kind broadcasting from the Alpha Centauri system.

The Turing Police are the Colonel, charged with the custody of an intelligence whose release they fear. The merger of the two AIs is the merger of Tetsuo and Akira. The corporate dynasty that owns them, the Tessier-Ashpool clan, spends its long life in cryogenic suspension within its orbital villa. It is a frozen aristocracy presiding over a reserve it cannot finally control. Gibson's novel, published two years into *Akira*'s serialization, discovers the same structure in the corporate idiom that Ōtomo discovers in the idiom of the state.

9.9 The Afterlife of the Template

Akira's influence on subsequent popular culture is too extensive to survey. Kaneda's braking slide alone has been quoted in animation and film from Western series to Jordan Peele's *Nope* (2022), and a Hollywood live-action adaptation languished in development through the 2000s and 2010s. Three descendants suffice to characterize what the template has become.

Josh Trank's *Chronicle* (2012), widely read as a homage, follows three teenagers who acquire telekinetic powers. One of them, abused at home and despised at school, becomes violent. He declares himself an "apex predator," lays waste to a city, and is killed by his cousin. *Chronicle* preserves Tetsuo's ressentiment and the Kaneda–Tetsuo bond almost intact. It eliminates the state entirely. There is no laboratory, no reserve, and no Colonel, only a bullied boy with power.

Rian Johnson's *Looper* (2012) imagines a telekinetic child destined to become a tyrant, the "Rainmaker." It locates the prevention of his tyranny in his mother's love. *Looper* preserves the tyrant-child and supplies him with the mother Tetsuo lacks. It resolves the

problem of the accursed child by domestic means.

The Duffer brothers' television series *Stranger Things* (2016–2025) preserves the laboratory and the numbered children. Its heroine is designated Eleven, and its principal monster proves to be the laboratory's first subject, who massacred the others. The series thus contains both the Espers and Tetsuo. Yet it reorganizes them within the narrative of a found family in which the laboratory child is adopted, protected, and raised.

The template's afterlife follows a consistent tendency: the *psychologization of catabolic sovereignty*. The later works preserve the bullied boy, the tyrant-child, and the numbered subject. They progressively lose the political theology that gave these figures their meaning in *Akira*: the custody of the catastrophe by the state, the hollow center, the reserve beneath the monument of renewal. The problem becomes one of individual trauma and familial repair rather than of sovereignty and its void. The descendants ask how to heal the damaged child. *Akira* asks what kind of polity keeps its end in children, and what kind of polity could stop.

9.10 Conclusion: What Only *Akira* Does

The comparisons of this chapter permit a precise statement of *Akira*'s distinctive place in the lineage of speculative philosophy.

On the problem of the maker's responsibility, *Akira* extends Shelley's and Tezuka's question from the individual scientist to the institution and the state. The made being is abandoned by a bureaucracy that numbers it rather than by a single father.

On the problem of the collective and the singular, it sets Sturgeon's and Bester's gestalt against the solitary will of Wells's Fotheringay and Dick's Hoppy Harrington. It locates the ethical agency of the work in the collective of the sacrificed.

On the problem of custody, it goes beyond Kahn's, Komatsu's, and Tomino's automatic systems and beyond Bester's democratized detonator. It makes custody itself, rather than the weapon or its use, the object of its narrative.

On the problem of the perception of catastrophe, it gathers Dick's precogs, Abe's verdict of the future, and Ballard's neuronic memory into the Espers' visions and the film's intimation of a memory latent in matter.

On the problem of survival, its answer differs from every work considered. It does not answer with Clarke's transcendence, whose end is the fulfilment of the species. Nor does it answer with Komatsu's diaspora, Stapledon's self-annihilation, Golding's rescue, or Wells's world state. It is closest to *Evangelion*'s return to individuation and to Nausicaä's refusal of the engineered future, but it goes further than either. It ends with the constitution of a polity: a remnant that assumes, in the first person plural, the responsibility the subjectless inscription withheld, and that names itself for the catastrophe it survived.

What only *Akira* does is to think the catastrophe politically all the way to its end. It shows the end of the world as a problem of sovereignty, and it imagines, in the ruins, the beginning of a sovereignty of a different kind. Part Four formalizes that sovereignty.



PART FOUR

Synthesis

10 Catabolic Sovereignty

> The remnant shall return, even the remnant of Jacob, unto the mighty God.
>
> — ISAIAH 10:21 (AUTHORIZED VERSION, 1611)

> Der destruktive Charakter kennt nur eine Parole: Platz schaffen; nur eine Tätigkeit: räumen.
>
> *The destructive character knows only one watchword: make room; only one activity: clearing away.*
>
> — WALTER BENJAMIN, "DER DESTRUKTIVE CHARAKTER" (1931)

10

CHAPTER TEN

Catabolic Sovereignty

Toward a General Economy of Catastrophe

10.1 The Argument in Retrospect

This dissertation began from a diagnosis. The most influential readings of *Akira* share a representational presupposition: they treat destruction as the referent of the work and ask what its catastrophes represent. Against this presupposition I proposed the question the work itself poses with insistent literalism: how is destruction produced, stored, administered, and released?

Part One reconstructed the genealogy of that question. Chapter 1 traced the work's emergence from several sources: Ōtomo's early realism, the senescent child of *Dōmu*, the domesticated war machine of *Tetsujin 28-gō*, the parodic kamikaze of the *bōsōzoku*, and the terminal conjuncture of 1989–90. Chapter 2 read the atomic child through nuclear criticism, Anders's Promethean gap, and Tezuka's Atom. It identified the work's typology of the pathologies of maturation and its image of the postwar as cryostasis. Chapter 3 read Neo-Tokyo as a Metabolist city and located the origin of the anabolic delusion in the compact of 1960.

Part Two followed the disavowed energy into bodies. Chapter 4 reconstructed the general economy that runs from Mauss through Bataille to Okamoto Tarō and Mishima Yukio, read SOL as the weaponized sun, and defined catabolic sovereignty as the custody of stored annihilation. Chapter 5 read the Esper programme as biopolitics, bare life, and standing-reserve, and documented the historical archive of the accursed child. Chapter 6 read Tetsuo's metamorphosis as anabolic sovereignty: the grotesque seized by a tyrant, the cancerous body without organs, His Majesty the Baby, and Nietzsche's lion.

Part Three turned to sovereignty and the sacred. Chapter 7 read Akira as the charged void at the center of a political theology whose referent is the imperial institution. Chapter 8 reconstructed the Buddhist and millenarian cosmology within which the

work's catastrophes unfold and named its critical relation to that tradition a catabolic Buddhism. Chapter 9 located *Akira* within the lineage of speculative philosophy and specified what only it does: it thinks the catastrophe politically all the way to its end.

It remains to formalize the theory, to answer the questions deferred along the way, and to articulate the alternative that the work proposes.

10.2 Six Theses on Catabolic Sovereignty

First thesis: every system that sustains itself by energy is the rhythm of anabolism and catabolism. A system that refuses catabolism does not abolish it but stores it.

This is the common teaching of the traditions this dissertation has brought into stereoscopic relation:

- Bataille's general economy holds that every living system accumulates a surplus that growth can absorb only for a time.
- The Buddhist cosmology of formation, abiding, destruction, and emptiness conceives the life of a world as a cycle in which dissolution is as necessary as formation.
- Heraclitus, as Nietzsche read him, figured the cosmos as a fire that builds and tears down in play.
- Oshii's Puppet Master, an intelligence that cannot die, seeks mortality because it understands that a system incapable of death is incapable of life.

The corollary is the premise of everything that follows. Catabolism refused is not catabolism abolished. What is not broken down is accumulated, and what is accumulated must eventually be spent.

Second thesis: the modern growth state legitimates itself through an ideology of pure anabolism, and this ideology is an operative arrangement that produces storage.

The anabolic delusion is more than a false belief about the nature of growth. It is a way of organizing a society so that the catabolic processes on which growth depends are displaced out of view: onto the past, the outside, and the future. In postwar Japan the arrangement received its definitive form in the compact of 1960. That compact divided metabolic labour between an American custodian of catabolism and a Japanese specialist in anabolism. Within the national frame, the anabolic side was expressed in the Metabolist city, the income-doubling plan, the Olympiad and the Exposition as rites of rebirth, and the construction state.

What the delusion denies is not destroyed; it is deposited. It accumulates in bases and stockpiles, in toxins and debts, in latent capacities, and in bodies.

Benjamin's angel of history, in the ninth of his theses "On the Concept of History" (2003 [1940]), sees a single catastrophe where we perceive a chain of events: a catastrophe that keeps piling wreckage upon wreckage at his feet. The storm that drives

him irresistibly into the future is what we call progress. The anabolic delusion is the standpoint that sees the chain of events and not the wreckage. Ōtomo's detrital art restores the angel's view.

Third thesis: sovereignty becomes the custody of the stored reserve, and the reserve is more sovereign than the sovereign.

Schmitt's formula located sovereignty in the decision on the exception. Under the conditions described by the second thesis, the sovereign's ultimate power consists instead in holding the capacity for annihilation in reserve. Sovereign is he who keeps custody of catabolism.

But custody is a peculiar form of power, for its object exceeds it. The value of the reserve lies in its non-use, and its use annuls every value, including the custodian's authority. Its release therefore need not be decided by anyone. It can be triggered by an accident, a tremor, a stray bullet, or a child who does not speak. At the moment of release, the custodian is exposed as an archon without an *arkhē*, the keeper of a power that acts without him.

Catabolic sovereignty is thus structurally self-undermining. Its authority rests upon a reserve whose release is the end of its authority.

Fourth thesis: the reserve tends to be stored in the bodies least able to refuse it, above all in children.

The anabolic delusion displaces catabolism onto the future, and the future is embodied, literally and symbolically, in the young. This is why the accursed child is not a metaphor:

- The foetuses of Minamata stored the mercury of high growth.
- The haemophiliac children of the blood scandal stored the negligence of a pharmaceutical industry with roots in wartime science.
- The numbered children of the Esper programme store the capacity for the end of the world.

The accursed child inverts reproductive futurism. It is not the guarantor of the future in whose name the present is organized. It is the medium in which the present deposits the costs it refuses to bear. The figure of the Child, as Edelman described it, is revealed as the alibi of the anabolic delusion: the future it promises is the future onto which the catastrophe is transferred.

Fifth thesis: catabolic sovereignty organizes itself around a charged void, and its catastrophes are subjectless.

At the center of the arrangement stands a sacred vacancy: an empty center, a hollow deity, a symbol without power, a portable shrine. This vacancy is not empty but charged, for it is the place where the reserve is kept.

Around it forms what Maruyama called the system of irresponsibility. Officials guard what they cannot command; outlaws drive events in the name of the sacred center; and the center itself cannot will. The catastrophe that issues from such a structure is subjectless. It appears as accident, as nature, as act of God. Its grammar is the grammar of the cenotaph inscription: a promise with no promiser, an error with no one who erred.

Sixth thesis: three relations to the reserve define three sovereignties.

Anabolic sovereignty is the relation of incorporation. It grows toward the reserve, seeks to absorb it, and aspires to become it. Its figure is Tetsuo, its form the cancerous body, and its politics micro-fascism.

Catabolic sovereignty is the relation of custody and release. It holds the reserve, organizes itself around it, and is annulled by its discharge. Its figure is Akira, together with the apparatus that guards him.

Remnant sovereignty is the relation of remaining. It is the survival of a subject that neither incorporates the reserve nor keeps custody of it, and that refuses to be reincorporated into the cycle that produced it. Its figures are Kaneda and Kei.

The first two sovereignties are complicit, each the other's truth. Anabolic sovereignty ends in the catabolic release it sought to master, and catabolic sovereignty depends upon the anabolic accumulation it disavows. Only the third stands outside their circuit.

10.3 Divine Violence Reconsidered

Chapter 4 left a question open. Akira's violence founds no law and preserves none; it comes from beneath and is rendered as bloodless light. Is it divine violence in Walter Benjamin's sense? The answer is negative, and explaining why is among the most important consequences of the theory.

Benjamin's divine violence is law-destroying, bloodless, and expiatory. It is not a means: it is the sign and seal, never the instrument, of sacred execution, and it may be called sovereign violence (Benjamin 1996 [1921]).

Akira's violence satisfies the formal criteria. It destroys the legal order of Neo-Tokyo without founding another. It is rendered as pure luminosity. It comes, like the judgment that swallowed the company of Korah, from beneath the earth.

But it fails the essential criterion, for it is not what it appears to be. Akira's violence is not an irruption from outside the legal order. It is the release of a reserve that the legal order itself produced, numbered, stored, and guarded. It is mythic violence, the violence of the state, accumulated and held in custody until it is discharged without a decision. Because no one decides its release, it presents itself as divine: as the act of a sacred child, as fate, as the will of a god. In truth it is the state's own violence returning without a subject.

Here lies the final ruse of catabolic sovereignty: it makes its own stored violence appear, at the moment of release, as an act of God. The vocabulary of the subjectless catastrophe is its signature, and that vocabulary is not confined to fiction:

— The law of contract calls such events *force majeure*.

— After the tsunami of 2011, operators and officials described the event as *sōteigai*, "beyond assumption."

— The catfish prints of 1855 blamed the earthquake on the absence of the god of Kashima.

Each formula performs the same operation. It converts administered catastrophe into nature, and custody into fate. Benjamin's distinction between mythic and divine violence is thereby shown to be vulnerable to a specifically modern counterfeit. Stored mythic violence, released without decision, borrows the appearance of divine violence precisely because it has no author.

Is there, then, no trace of divine violence in *Akira*? There is, but not where the spectacle directs us to look.

The Espers' final act satisfies Benjamin's criteria in substance rather than appearance. It is bloodless. It dissolves the mythic order of Tetsuo's empire without founding another. It is not a means to any end the children could enjoy. And it is performed for the sake of the living, which is Benjamin's phrase for the orientation of divine violence. The numbered children were stored as the state's reserve. At the end they spend themselves not as the state's instrument but against the state's product. If anything in the work deserves the name of divine violence, it is this expenditure: the reserve refusing its function.

The remnant's act belongs to yet another category. In a crucial passage of the same essay, Benjamin, following Georges Sorel's *Réflexions sur la violence* (1908), distinguished two forms of the general strike. The political general strike seeks to seize the power of the state, and so remains within the circuit of law-making violence. The proletarian general strike seeks the abolition of state power. In Benjamin's analysis it is therefore a pure means, non-violent because it consists not in action against the state but in the withdrawal of cooperation from it.

The three positions in *Akira* map onto this distinction:

— The resistance cell to which Kei first belongs, doctrinaire and financed by Nezu, pursues the political strike. It seeks to seize the reserve and the power the reserve confers.

— Tetsuo's empire is law-founding violence in its purest form.

— Kaneda's refusal of the foreign forces' aid at the manga's end is neither. It seizes nothing and founds nothing by force.

Kaneda withdraws. He declines to participate in the reconstruction economy that would convert catastrophe back into growth under external tutelage. His refusal is the proletarian general strike of the remnant: a refusal to labour at rebuilding the arrangement that produced the catastrophe.

Giorgio Agamben has reconstructed the "esoteric dossier" of Benjamin's and Schmitt's exchange. He argued that Schmitt's theory of sovereignty can be read as a response to Benjamin's attempt to think a violence outside the law. He did so in a chapter he titled, with a resonance this dissertation cannot ignore, "Gigantomachy Concerning a Void" (Agamben 2005b [2003]).

Akira intervenes in that gigantomachy from an unexpected angle. It shows that the modern state has learned to store violence outside the law, in the reserve, and to release it as though it came from nowhere. It locates the only exits from the circuit in two acts that do not belong to the sovereign: the self-expenditure of the sacrificed, and the withdrawal of those who remain.

10.4 The Remnant

The concept of the remnant has a theological genealogy that illuminates what the manga's final pages accomplish. In the prophecy of Isaiah, the destruction visited upon Israel is not total: a remnant (*she'ar*) will survive and return. Isaiah gives the promise a body by naming his son Shear-jashub, "a remnant shall return" (Isaiah 7:3; 10:20–22). In Paul's letter to the Romans, the remnant becomes the figure of the messianic community. At the present time, Paul writes, there is a remnant chosen by grace (Romans 11:5).

Agamben's reading of Paul in *The Time That Remains* (2005a [2000]) transforms the concept. For Agamben, the Pauline remnant is not a numerical portion of a people, the survivors who happen to be left over. It is the product of a second cut. Paul divides the division between Jew and non-Jew by the further division between flesh and spirit. The result is a subject that coincides with neither side of the original division: a "non-non-Jew," a remainder that makes it impossible for the whole to coincide with itself.

The remnant is also a relation to time. It inhabits "the time that remains," the contracted time of the messianic, in which every worldly vocation is lived "as not" (*hōs mē*, 1 Corinthians 7:29–31), held and suspended at once.

The remnant of *Akira* is a remnant in precisely Agamben's sense. It is not simply those who happen to survive; the survivors of the final annihilation include soldiers, cultists, and the scattered population of the ruins. The remnant is a subject produced by a second cut, one that passes through every division that organized the city.

Kaneda belongs to none of the factions. He is neither the Colonel's man nor Nezu's, neither a believer in Lady Miyako's sect nor a member of Tetsuo's empire, neither a revolutionary of the resistance nor a client of the foreign order. He is the non-aligned

figure of every faction, the one who wanted nothing from the reserve. His polity gathers others who have passed through the factions and out of them.

Kei is the most eloquent instance. She began as a militant of the resistance and became the vessel through which the Espers acted. At the end she stands beside Kaneda not as a vessel but as a co-founder. Her trajectory is the passage from medium to subject, the conversion of the figure through which others speak into a figure who speaks in the first person plural. It answers, if only partially, the critique of the work's gender politics registered in Chapter 6.

The remnant's relation to time is equally Pauline. Its members live the vocations of the old order *as not*:

- They keep the name of empire, but their empire has no emperor, no army, and no territory beyond ruins.
- They keep the name of Akira, but the child is gone.
- They ride motorcycles, the vehicles of the gang and of the accident, but they ride them toward a beginning.

Every inherited form is held and suspended at once.

Gershom Scholem's analysis of messianism (1971) completes the genealogy. Scholem distinguished within messianism a *restorative* tendency, oriented toward the recovery of a lost past, and a *utopian* tendency, oriented toward a future without precedent. He insisted that messianism in its classical form conceives the transition to the messianic age as catastrophic: a rupture rather than a development.

Akira's two endings divide Scholem's two tendencies between them. The film's cosmogony is utopian: a new universe without precedent. The manga's final pages contain a restorative vision: the spectral city of the past rising for a moment around the riders. But the remnant does not stop for the specter. It neither restores the old city nor departs for the new universe. Its time is neither the time of restoration nor the time of utopia but the time that remains.

Derrida's thought of the remainder supplies the ontological ground for the concept. Against the fantasy of the remainderless catastrophe, the destruction of the archive that total nuclear war would effect, Derrida insisted that there is always a remainder: a trace that survives the erasure it records (1984; 1996 [1995]). *Akira*'s detrital ontology, with its insistence on debris, ruins, jars, and survivors, is an ontology of the remainder. Remnant sovereignty is the political form of that ontology. Its ground is not the decision, the explosion, or the organism, but the trace.

10.5 Natality and the Destructive Character

Two further concepts give remnant sovereignty its positive content.

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) places at the center of political life the faculty she called *natality*. Every human being is a newcomer, and the capacity to begin something new, which Arendt identified with action, is rooted in the fact of birth. She cited Augustine: *initium ut esset, creatus est homo, ante quem nullus fuit*, "that there might be a beginning, man was created, before whom there was no one" (*De civitate Dei* XII.20). Politics, for Arendt, is the space in which this capacity for beginning is exercised in concert with others.

In *On Violence* (1970) she drew a consequence that bears directly on *Akira*. Power corresponds to the human capacity to act in concert. Violence is instrumental, a matter of implements. The two are not degrees of one thing but opposites: where violence rules absolutely, power is absent.

Tetsuo is the purest illustration of Arendt's thesis in modern fiction. His violence is unlimited, and his power is nil. He cannot act in concert with anyone, because he absorbs everyone. His empire gathers followers but not a plurality, and his body is the literal destruction of plurality: the incorporation of every other into one.

The remnant is the inverse. Its violence is negligible, since it seizes nothing and destroys nothing. Its power, in Arendt's sense, is real: it is a small plurality of survivors acting in concert, speaking in the first person plural, and beginning. The manga's final declaration is an act of natality in the strict sense, a beginning made by newcomers in a world that has ended. The film arrives in its own idiom at the same conclusion. Its closing voice announces a beginning in the words "I am," which is the formula of the newcomer.

Benjamin's short text "The Destructive Character" (1999 [1931]) supplies the affect proper to this beginning. The destructive character, Benjamin writes, knows only one watchword, *make room*, and only one activity, *clearing away*. It is young and cheerful. It has few needs, and the least of them is to know what will replace what has been destroyed. It sees ways everywhere, and so stands always at a crossroads. Benjamin's paradoxical formulation is that it lives not from the feeling that life is worth living but from the feeling that suicide is not worth the trouble.

The portrait describes Kaneda with uncanny precision. Throughout the work he is cheerful, reckless, and without ideals. He is indifferent to every program and moved only by loyalty, appetite, and the pleasure of speed. He is the least ideological figure in a world of ideologues. He has no plan for what will fill the space, and that is why he can clear it without refilling it with the old arrangement.

The destructive character's clearing and the newcomer's beginning are the two moments of remnant sovereignty. The first is the refusal: making room by declining to rebuild the cycle. The second is the beginning: acting in concert in the space that has been cleared. Neither moment is violent in Arendt's sense. Together they constitute a form of power that stands outside the circuit of anabolic and catabolic sovereignty.

The concept must be distinguished from a contemporary theoretical temptation that it superficially resembles. Nick Land's reading of Bataille, *The Thirst for Annihilation* (1992), and the accelerationist current it helped inaugurate, identified with the dissolution of the human into the accelerating flows of capital and technology. It celebrated catastrophe as liberation from the organism and the subject.

Akira contains this temptation and repudiates it. The accelerationist position is Tetsuo's: identification with the metastasis, the conversion of self and world into a proliferating flow. It is also the position of the believers who welcome Akira's return as salvation. The work shows where both lead: to the cancerous body and the annihilated city. The remnant is not accelerationist. It identifies neither with the explosion nor with the growth. It remains, and it begins.

10.6 The Cenotaph Polity

Remnant sovereignty can now be characterized formally, by six features.

Its ground. It is founded neither on the decision, as in Schmitt, nor on the explosion, Bataille's sovereign moment appropriated as state power, nor on incorporation, as in Tetsuo's organism. It is founded on having remained, and on the refusal to be reincorporated.

The transformation of the hollow center. The remnant polity keeps the empty center: it names itself for Akira, the child who is gone. But it converts that center from reserve to memorial. The name "Akira" in the phrase "Great Tokyo Empire Akira" stores nothing and guards nothing; it commemorates. It is a cenotaph, an empty tomb in the strict etymological sense, around which the survivors constitute themselves.

The distinction between the hollow center as reserve and the hollow center as memorial is the hinge of the entire theory. Both are empty, and both organize a community. The reserve, however, is charged, guarded, and dangerous, while the memorial is discharged, open, and shared. The first holds the catastrophe for the future; the second holds it for memory. Catabolic sovereignty keeps the end in custody. Remnant sovereignty keeps the dead in mind.

Its grammar. The remnant speaks in the first person plural. It is the answer, across the decades, to the subjectless inscription of the Hiroshima cenotaph: a "we" that assumes responsibility for what happened and for what comes next. Maruyama's system of irresponsibility is suspended here, not by the discovery of a guilty party but by the constitution of a subject willing to answer.

Circulation rather than enthronement. The Great Tokyo Empire under Tetsuo was organized around a throne in a stadium: a stationary center, a cult. The remnant polity is organized around movement. Its image is not a throne but a ride. Chapter 3 traced

circulation from Tange's linear axis, through the gangs' parodic runs, to its collapse in the drowned city. That circulation now returns, neither as the state's arteries nor as the gang's play, but as the passage of a plurality through the ruins.

Refusal of tutelage. The remnant declines the reconstruction boom that would reconvert catastrophe into growth. It declines Wells's world order, which would absorb it, and Golding's rescue, which would return it to the adults' war. It declines the aid that would replay the postwar settlement. This refusal is the political content of the strike described in section 10.3.

Natal temporality. It is neither restoration, for the spectral city vanishes, nor transcendence, for the new universe is elsewhere. It is a beginning in the time that remains.

Three objections must be met.

The first objection is that the manga's ending is nationalist. On this reading, a band of Japanese youths reject American assistance and declare an "empire," fulfilling in fantasy the desire for autonomy from the United States that animates the Japanese right, from Mishima's balcony to the campaigns for constitutional revision.

The objection has force, and the ending is structurally open to such appropriation. But the polity it depicts inverts every term of the nationalist program. It has no emperor, for its sovereign is a dead child's name. It has no army, for its members seize nothing. It has no territory beyond ruins, and its sacred center is an empty tomb rather than a living god. Its "empire" is the word held *as not*.

Its refusal, moreover, is directed not against the world but against tutelage. It targets the very arrangement of custody that the nationalist program seeks not to abolish but to repatriate. Shirai Satoshi's "permanent defeat" (2013) names the condition that both the right and the remnant refuse. The right would end it by reclaiming the reserve. The remnant ends it by declining the reserve altogether.

The second objection concerns gender. The remnant is led by a young man, and the work's imagination of women is, as Chapter 6 conceded, dominated by the figure of the vessel. The concession stands. It must nevertheless be observed that Kei's passage from medium to co-founder is the only transformation in the work that converts a vessel into a subject. The remnant is the first formation in *Akira* in which a woman speaks in her own name. That is not enough, but it is not nothing.

The third objection is that the theory aestheticizes ruin, making catastrophe the precondition of political renewal. The detrital reading guards against this risk by insisting on debris rather than beauty, on the remainder rather than the sublime. Remnant sovereignty is not a celebration of catastrophe. It is a theory of the obligations that catastrophe creates for those who survive it, above all the obligation not to rebuild the arrangement that produced it.

10.7 The Purchase of the Theory

A theory of this kind must be tested against the world. Fredric Jameson observed, in a formula Mark Fisher later made the motto of a generation, that it had become easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism (Jameson 2003; Fisher 2009). *Akira* suggests a corollary. The end of the world has become the form in which the growth economy imagines its own limit, because catastrophe is the only catabolism it can represent.

Four catastrophes of the twenty-first century suggest that the structure *Akira* disclosed at the end of the Shōwa era has not receded but generalized.

The nuclear archipelago. The earthquake and tsunami of 11 March 2011 precipitated meltdowns at the Fukushima Daiichi nuclear plant. The disaster exposed two things. One was the "safety myth" (*anzen shinwa*) through which the civil nuclear programme had been legitimated. The other was the collusive network of utilities, regulators, ministries, and experts that critics called the "nuclear village" (*genshiryoku mura*).

The Diet's independent investigation commission (NAIIC 2012) concluded that the accident was manmade and preventable, and it assigned responsibility to identifiable institutions. In the terms of this dissertation, that was a sentence with a subject. Yet the chairman's preface to the English edition described the disaster as "Made in Japan." It attributed the root causes to ingrained conventions of national culture: reflexive obedience, reluctance to question authority, and groupism. Those formulations, contested at home, did not appear in the same form in the Japanese edition.

The juxtaposition reproduces, within a single report, the tension between the responsible subject and the subjectless inscription. In one register responsibility is assigned; in the other it is dispersed into "culture."

The sequel extended the structure into time. Under a government decision of 2021, the discharge of treated water from the site into the Pacific began in 2023, in a programme planned to last some three decades. Whatever its merits, which this dissertation does not adjudicate, it is administered catabolism: a release managed across a generation, the custody of catastrophe converted into a schedule.

In 2013 the prime minister assured the International Olympic Committee that the situation was "under control," and Tokyo was awarded the Olympiad, which was then branded the "Recovery Olympics" (*fukkō gorin*). In March 2021 its torch relay departed from J-Village in Fukushima, a sports complex that had served as the operational base for the reactor response. The flame kindled from the sun at Olympia was carried from the site of the catastrophe toward the stadium of rebirth. In 1964 that same flame had been carried into the stadium by a runner born in Hiroshima Prefecture on the day of the bomb.

The Games, postponed by pandemic, were held in the summer of 2021, largely without spectators. The rite of metabolic rebirth was performed around a literal void: a portable shrine carried through the streets with no crowd to watch it.

The pandemic. Chapter 5 cited Foucault's observation that biopower reaches its excess when it becomes capable of fabricating uncontrollable, universally destructive viruses. Whatever the origin of the virus of 2020, the pandemic disclosed the catabolic underside of the anabolic city. The circulatory networks through which the growth economy moved goods and bodies became the vectors of contagion. The city's arteries, which Tange had designed and the gangs had parodied, became the channels of breakdown.

In the preceding decade, Franco "Bifo" Berardi and Mark Fisher had spoken of "the slow cancellation of the future" (Berardi 2011; Fisher 2014). In 2020 the cancellation was not slow. The graffito on the film's stadium billboard, demanding that the Games be cancelled, circulated around the world as prophecy. What it had prophesied was not a date but a structure.

The planetary reserve. Fossil fuels are stored sunlight: the photosynthetic energy of ancient ecosystems, accumulated over geological time, a surplus of the sun's gift held in reserve beneath the earth. Industrial capitalism, as Andreas Malm (2016) has reconstructed, grew by burning this reserve. The anabolic delusion of perpetual growth was powered by the catabolism of the Carboniferous. The consequences of that combustion are displaced onto the future, deposited in the atmosphere and the oceans, to be borne by generations not yet born. The accursed child returns at planetary scale.

Three bodies of work frame this return. Allan Stoekl (2007) has argued that Bataille's general economy must be reread in the light of fossil-energy depletion. Paul Crutzen and Eugene Stoermer (2000) proposed the name "Anthropocene" for the epoch this combustion inaugurated. Dipesh Chakrabarty (2009) argued that the Anthropocene collapses the humanist distinction between natural and human history, so that the catastrophe that appears as nature is also the work of human hands.

This collapse is the blur between earthquake and bomb, between the catfish and the reserve, that *Akira* staged in the figure of a child whose awakening was reported as a "new-type bomb." The weaponized sun of Chapter 4 finds here its ultimate form. The stored sunlight released by combustion returns as the heat of the atmosphere. The seventh sun of the kalpa does not appear in the sky; it is released from the ground.

Artificial intelligence. The fourth catastrophe is not yet a catastrophe, and it must be approached with corresponding care. Since Vernor Vinge's essay on the coming "technological singularity" (1993), a discourse has developed around the prospect of artificial intelligences whose capacities might exceed those of their makers. The name Vinge chose, a point beyond which prediction fails, evokes the white sphere of the film's ending.

The vocabulary of this discourse is strikingly close to the Colonel's. Nick Bostrom (2014) framed the problem as one of control, including methods of "boxing," or containing, a system and of detecting dangerous capabilities before their release. Stuart Russell (2019) reframed it as the problem of building systems that remain deferential to human preferences they cannot fully know. Around these works a governance literature of thresholds, evaluations, and containment measures has grown. It is a literature of custody.

Who holds this custody is the decisive difference, and it sharpens the third thesis. The custodians of this reserve are, for the most part, not states but the private firms that build the systems. Since 2023 the leading developers have published their own frameworks for holding it: Anthropic's Responsible Scaling Policy, OpenAI's Preparedness Framework, and Google DeepMind's Frontier Safety Framework (Anthropic 2023; OpenAI 2023; Google DeepMind 2024). Each defines capability thresholds and the safeguards that must be in place before a system that crosses one is developed further or released. The frameworks are written, applied, and in large part assessed by the firms themselves. States have so far acted mainly by requiring disclosure, testing, and incident reporting, and through export controls, rather than by holding the reserve. The arrangement belongs to Gibson's corporate idiom (Chapter 9) more than to Ōtomo's idiom of the state.

Three consequences follow for the third thesis. First, the laboratory and the custodian have merged. In *Akira*, Dr. Ōnishi's laboratory produces the reserve and the Colonel guards it, and the friction between them is the only check the work shows; here the institution that develops a capability is also the one that judges whether it can be held safely. Second, the reserve's value no longer lies in its non-use. A deterrent is worth something only while it is unspent, whereas a model earns its value by being deployed, so custody becomes the management of a continuous, partial release, nearer to the scheduled discharge at Fukushima than to the sealed vault beneath the stadium. Third, the decision has migrated again. Schmitt placed it in the sovereign, and the third thesis moved it into the apparatus; here it becomes an internal evaluation, the judgment that a threshold has or has not been crossed, made by the party with the largest commercial stake in the answer. That is a structural fact about the arrangement, not a charge against anyone's good faith. And the reserve can still leave custody without its custodian's decision, if its weights are stolen or leaked: the stray bullet in a new form.

Akira does not tell us whether such custody will succeed, and the analogy has limits that must be stated plainly. The systems at issue are not children, and the moral grammar of the Esper programme cannot be transposed to them without distortion. The work nevertheless offers three lessons whose relevance does not depend on the analogy's precision.

First, custody without a polity capable of responsibility is not safety. The Colonel's apparatus fails not because it is too weak but because it is embedded in a system of irresponsibility: a council that cannot decide, a councillor who would exploit the reserve,

a cult that would worship it, and an outlaw who would seize it.

Second, those whose understanding is commensurate with the power, the Espers in whom Anders's Promethean gap has closed, must be heard.

Third, the work issues a double warning: against treating any being as standing-reserve, and against treating any reserve as sacred. The first error produced the numbered children. The second produced the street prophets and the empire in the stadium.

10.8 Toward the Conclusion

The theory of catabolic sovereignty describes a structure that postwar Japan instantiated with exceptional clarity and that the twenty-first century has generalized. In this structure the costs of growth are stored rather than borne. Custody of the stored catastrophe becomes the substance of power. When the release comes, it appears as nobody's act.

Akira is the most searching fictional anatomy of that structure. In its final pages it is also the most searching fictional imagination of its alternative. That alternative is not a program. It is an image: a few survivors on motorcycles, riding through the ruins of a city that has ended twice. The Conclusion reads that image.

結

CONCLUSION

The Ride through the Ruins

C.1 The Last Pages

The manga ends in motion. The final annihilation is over; Akira, Tetsuo, and the Espers have departed; the foreign forces have been refused. The survivors take to their motorcycles and ride out across the ruins of Neo-Tokyo.

As they ride, a spectral image of the city as it was overlays the ruins for a moment. Its towers are restored and its streets intact: a ghost metropolis rising around the riders. Among its phantoms Kaneda glimpses his lost friends. Then the specter fades, and the ride continues. The film ends differently but in the same key. Its survivors also set out across the ruins, while Tetsuo's voice announces, from beyond the sphere, the first words of a new creation.

Everything this dissertation has argued converges on this image. It is the only image in *Akira* in which power is exercised neither as incorporation, nor as custody, nor as release. It is also the only image in which the work's three great structuring elements are reorganized at once: the vehicle of the accident, the hollow center, and the city of scrap and build.

C.2 The Hut and the Motorcycle

Chapter 3 recalled Kamo no Chōmei, who witnessed the fires, whirlwinds, famines, and earthquakes of the late-twelfth-century capital. He withdrew into a hut ten feet square that could be dismantled and carried away on a pair of carts, and there he wrote his account of the impermanence of dwellings and their dwellers. The hut was the first capsule of Japanese letters. It was a minimal, mobile dwelling built by one who had learned that the city is a rhythm of accumulation and ruin, and who refused to invest himself again in its cycle.

Kurokawa Kishō's capsule, eight centuries later, promised the same mobility to the *homo movens* of the information society. It failed. It was never replaced; it decayed in place and was demolished whole. It failed because it was bolted to a megastructure, the

permanent core of the anabolic city, and so could never move at all.

The motorcycle is the capsule that moves. Throughout *Akira* it has been the vehicle of the accident, the instrument of the gang's parodic kamikaze, and the medium through which the anabolic city's circulation was converted into play. Its tail-light, smeared across the frame, was the index of a motion already past.

In the final pages the motorcycle becomes Chōmei's hut: the minimal dwelling of those who have seen the city end and will not rebuild the arrangement that ended it. The survivors do not settle in the ruins, occupy the stadium, or raise a new throne. They ride. Their polity is mobile, light, and attached to no megastructure. The vehicle of the accident has become the vehicle of the beginning.

C.3 Through the Specters

The spectral city that rises around the riders is the most poignant image in the work, and its meaning is precise. It carries three overlapping senses:

- It is the restorative temptation in Scholem's sense: the lost city offered back, the old world returning as vision.
- It is what Derrida called the specter, the revenant that inhabits a time out of joint (1994 [1993]).
- It is what Fisher, following Derrida, called hauntology: the persistence of lost futures in the present that cancelled them (2014).

The city that appears is Neo-Tokyo in its prime: the anabolic metropolis at the height of its confidence, the future the growth state promised, returning as a ghost.

The remnant rides *through* the specters. It neither stops to inhabit them nor refuses to see them, and this is the exact posture of remnant sovereignty toward the past. The city is not restored, for the specter fades. It is not forgotten either, for the specter is seen and the dead are glimpsed within it.

Sawaragi's "bad place" was a society in which history is erased and reset, catastrophe followed by amnesia and amnesia by reconstruction. The remnant breaks this cycle without rebuilding the past and without forgetting it. It carries the past's memory, as a name and as a vision, into a beginning that does not repeat it. The Great Tokyo Empire Akira is a cenotaph that moves.

After visiting Japan in 1959, Alexandre Kojève concluded in a celebrated note that the Japanese had lived for centuries in a post-historical condition sustained by purely formal values. He suggested that the post-historical future of humanity might prove to be a "Japanization" rather than a return to animality (1969 [1947]). Azuma's "database animals" would later take their name from the other horn of Kojève's alternative. Fukuyama

announced the end of history in the triumph of liberal democracy in 1989. *Akira*'s final chapters were serialized as that announcement circulated, and their answer to both was a ride.

History does not end in snobbery, in the market, or in the white sphere. It continues as the passage of a plurality through ruins, carrying its dead in mind and beginning again. The age of fiction ended and the age of impossibility began; the remnant rides out of both.

C.4 The Wheel

This dissertation began with two epigraphs.

The first, from the *Hōjōki*, observed that the river never ceases to flow, yet its water is never the same. That is the catabolic historicity of the city in a single sentence: the form persists while its substance is continually broken down and renewed.

The second, from Nietzsche, described the child who succeeds the lion. The child is innocence and forgetting, a beginning-anew, a game, *ein aus sich rollendes Rad*: a wheel rolling out of itself.

Chapter 6 identified Akira with that child and drew out the terrible ambiguity of the identification. The child's innocence of becoming is, from the standpoint of the city, a catastrophe. Heraclitus had said that the kingship belongs to a child. *Akira* showed what happens when a child is made king: the kingship becomes the custody of the end of the world, and the child becomes its reserve.

The manga's final image resolves this ambiguity without denying it. The kingship belonged to a child, and the child is gone. His name remains, held in common by a polity that has refused to enthrone anyone in his place. What remains of the Nietzschean child is not the throne but the wheel: the wheel of a motorcycle rolling out of itself across the ruins. It is a first movement, a beginning, a sacred Yes, spoken not by a god but by those who survived him.

The river flows on through the drowned city, and it is never the same water. What follows is neither the old city restored nor the new universe reached. It is the time that remains, and the survivors are moving through it.

Against the catabolic sovereign, who keeps the end of the world in custody and releases it as nobody's act, *Akira* proposes the sovereignty of those who remain.

APPARATUS

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KEYWORDS

Akira · Ōtomo Katsuhiro · manga studies · anime studies · catabolic sovereignty · anabolic delusion · remnant sovereignty · accursed child · hollow center · general economy · Georges Bataille · political theology · sovereignty · state of exception · divine violence · biopolitics · bare life · standing-reserve · nuclear criticism · atomic child · Metabolism (architecture) · Tange Kenzō · Okamoto Tarō · postwar Japan · symbol emperor · system of irresponsibility · Kyoto School · emptiness (*śūnyatā*) · *mappō* · *yonaoshi* · *namazu-e* · Ōmoto · Aum Shinrikyō · body without organs · abjection · the grotesque · *amae* · ressentiment · natality · messianic remnant · hauntology · speculative fiction · cyberpunk · posthumanism · Anthropocene · Fukushima · Tokyo Olympics · artificial intelligence governance



Against the catabolic sovereign, who keeps the end of the world in custody and releases it as nobody's act, Akira proposes the sovereignty of those who remain.